

*Spirituality—
Our Foundation*

**THE FORTY-SEVENTH ANNUAL MEETING
OF THE GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE
OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS**

*1997
Final Report*

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Confidential—full names used

Since this report is a *confidential* A.A. document, for members only, it contains members' full names and addresses. This usage—to facilitate communication within the Fellowship—was approved by the 1975 Conference. Such confidential use does not, of course, violate in any way our Tradition of anonymity in *public* communications media (press, radio, TV, etc.)



47TH GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE

Spirituality—Our Foundation

The Conference had closed the evening before, with the Serenity Prayer in English, French and Spanish. Now, Saturday morning, April 19th, members of the 47th General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous, U.S. and Canada had gathered for the last time at the closing brunch. It was a time for good-byes, hugs, a few tears, picture taking, and the farewell talks of those trusted A.A. servants who were rotating on.

Alcoholics Anonymous is about people — “a fellowship of men and women”—and the rope of identification that binds us to each other in the quest “to solve our common problem and help others to recover from alcoholism.” The rotating trustees, in their own way and from the experience of their own history, spoke of the people who had journeyed with them through their sobriety. The closing talks, said Don Weaver, East Central regional trustee, “are not about rotating on—they are about saying thank you.” Don thanked the delegates in his area, present and past, and acknowledged the contributions of trustee emeritus Gordon Patrick and G.S.O. archivist Frank Mauser, both of whom will not be at the next Conference. Rotating general service trustee Michael McPherson remembered fellow trustee Peter Brock, who passed

away last August, and Larry Nelson, who served as trustee-at-large/U.S., related his experiences at the World Service Meeting and with the legion of A.A. members around the world that had touched his life.

General service trustee Jane Murphy Schulberg remembered those who did not make it and died of alcoholism—her late husband, a sponsee, and others. “My sobriety does not protect those I love,” Jane said, “it only protects me.” Gay Garner, Southeast regional trustee, also mentioned family and spoke of “the importance of sharing in service, just as we share in recovery.”

Chairman of the General Service Board, Class A (nonalcoholic) trustee Jim Estelle was also rotating after many years of service to the Fellowship. “We need to always take a reality and spiritual check,” Jim said, and ask “are we still talking to drunks—one-on-one?”

Delegates, trustees and directors began to assemble at the Crowne Plaza Hotel, New York City on Saturday, April 12th. New York Intergroup’s hospitality suite, where local A.A. and Al-Anon members welcomed delegates, spouses, family members and friends, was busy all day. Going on simultaneously was a meeting

of the Remote Communities Committee (see Presentation, p. 16) and the trustees' orientation for delegates.

Sunday evening Conference members, friends of A.A., former staff members and trustees filled the Broadway Ballroom for the Opening Dinner, followed by an A.A. meeting chaired by Wendy Zapanianuk (Saskatchewan), chairperson of the Conference Agenda Committee. The meeting leader was Charlotte Ingalls, (Alaska), alternate chair of the Agenda Committee; speakers were Greg Tobin, Grapevine director; Mike Smith (Southern Indiana); Carl Budd, West Central regional trustee; Adrienne Brown, G.S.O. staff; and Rikki Schock, (New Brunswick/PEI).

Monday morning the Conference was officially opened. Sharing chairing responsibilities were George Dorsey, general manager, G.S.O.; Jim Estelle, chairman of the General Service Board; John N. Chappel, M.D., Class A trustee; and Jack Shaver, (Manitoba) delegate chairperson.

The program during the busy week included Area Service Highlights (page 51), Sharing Sessions, Presentations (page 11), and committee meetings and reports. From the deliberations of the 11 standing Conference Committees came recommendations and suggestions that were presented for discussion and vote to the entire Conference. Many of these items became Conference Advisory Actions (page 8).

Wednesday afternoon, at the trustees elections, Betty Stevens, Columbia, South Carolina, was elected Southeast regional trustee; Jack Ostrem, Joliet, Illinois, will be the new East Central regional trustee; the new trustee-at-large/U.S. will be Dean Rinehart, El Reno, Oklahoma. At the close of Conference Gary Glynn, Class A trustee, assumed the position of chairman of the General Service Board.

At the Delegates Only Dinner Tuesday evening, Bob Kosloff, California, Northern Coastal Area, was elected delegate chairperson for the 48th General Service Conference; Keith Lake, NW Ontario will serve as alternate delegate chair.

A special, very welcomed observer to the Conference was Michaela Klimanova Trizulaikova, an A.A. member from the Slovak Republic. Following G.S.O. Publications director Vinnie McCarthy's presentation on A.A.'s Growth in Eastern Europe (page 21) she introduced Michaela. In her brief remarks Michaela expressed her gratitude and reported that there are now 10 meetings in Slovakia, with approximately 50 members meeting in five groups. Proving the message continues to spread to every corner of the world, Michaela had brought the manuscript of the newly translated *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* in Slovak.

Following the closing brunch Saturday afternoon Conference members began returning home with a renewed sense of Alcoholics Anonymous's purpose. Several delegates from the Midwest had left their homes as the flood waters were rising in Minnesota and the Dakotas, where their towns were being evacuated and dykes were perilously close to breaking. A few members had left behind grave family problems of illness and alcoholism—but, in the true spirit of the Third Step, they had taken the action, they had shown up and turned the results over to a higher power. The members of the 47th General Service Conference had, as Bill Archer (SW Quebec) said, "translated the actions of Alcoholics Anonymous."

Profile of a Delegate

The average age of a delegate is 51.5 years, with the oldest being 68 and the youngest 31 years; average length of sobriety 15.0 years, longest sobriety 32 years and shortest 8 years; average length of service 12.1 years, longest 25, shortest 6 years. (Compiled on responses from 87 delegates.)

Greetings from Delegate Chairperson

Greetings and welcome to the 47th General Service Conference, especially those who are attending their first Conference. You are about to participate in a most moving and spiritual experience. For me, it is second only to the experience of lying in a treatment center and, for some unknown reason, asking God, with no strings attached, for the strength and guidance to get through it. He did, and led me to Alcoholics Anonymous. He did not do that directly. Rather, He provided me with a variety of "spiritual" people who brought me here and led me down the path of recovery.

I put the word spiritual in quotation marks for a reason, that being I had no idea what it meant. Sometimes I still don't; just ask my wife! However, I do recall someone, at some crucial point, stating that "religion was studying the words and spirituality was putting it to work." Bingo! Spiritual meant doing the work, and that is what the people who led me here were doing. They were doing the work. I got sober not by *studying* the Big Book but by *doing* the Big Book, and I stayed sober by doing the work. Spirituality is work.

I also had no idea what the foundation was that they kept talking about. I kept looking around for something made out of concrete, and one day I found it. It was the basement of the church where our group meets. The church had a concrete basement which held up the main structure. I guess a foundation is a base that holds something up. Also, a concrete foundation is not a simple thing. Concrete is a bunch of stones of varying sizes bonded together with something.

Just in case you are wondering where I am going with this I am getting around to the theme of the Conference but, before I do, I think we should consider the word "our." Before I came here, I was lost in the singular world of I, me and mine. I simply could not consider any needs other than my own. However, through love and tolerance, you showed me how to live in and be a part of something. This something is a Fellowship beyond my wildest imagination and something I am a part of. To me, this is the most important concept. It is OURS.

Therefore, I can relate to the Conference theme, "Spirituality—Our Foundation," as doing the work to keep the base of our Fellowship strong so the structure remains sound. We are the stones and God, as we understand Him, bonds us together to ensure we don't fall apart. It is up to us, under His guidance, to keep the base solid so that the structure, which is the groups, can carry the message. That is the part the still-suffering alcoholic will see and, if it remains attractive, he or she will come. If not, we all know the alternative.

We are here this week to do the work of Alcoholics Anonymous, and we bring the experience, strength and hope of our respective areas with us. They have entrusted us with the job of finding out, through the committee structure and the group conscience, what is best for A.A. as a whole. At times, I may have to realize that what is good for our area might not be the best for the Fellowship. In these situations I must respect the group conscience, then go back to my area and proceed with the most difficult job facing a delegate—explaining to them why. Last year I found out they can even be quite open-minded about the outcome, providing I return with all the background information and reasons behind the recommendations. Not only is it our job to come here prepared, but to go home prepared. That is a challenge.

This challenge can be met by working with faith and serving with love. We must all have faith that not one of us would intentionally do anything to harm the Fellowship and, in the process, we must love each other enough to ensure that all the opinions

are considered to ensure we reach the group conscience. This entails a lot of listening, but I have learned God gave me two ears and one mouth for a reason. I am supposed to listen twice as much as I talk. We are going to learn a lot this week, and if we can pass it on when we get back our areas will be stronger. In turn, our groups will be stronger and, consequently, A.A. will be stronger, because the groups make the A.A. structure.

We must also remember that our presence here is somewhat self-fulfilling. I used to wonder why I was in service, then, after being elected area chair, it dawned on me to read the chairperson's qualifications in *The A.A. Service Manual* (p. S60). The last line points out service is part of our personal recovery; therefore, we must be conscientious and cautious. Whatever we do will affect us. If we do our job well, it is another step forward in our own recovery. I can't speak for you but, for me, the more steps I am away from a drink the more comfortable I am. Whenever I hear someone say they are only one step away from a drink I want to encourage them to do Step Two.

There is one last thought I would like to share. For the first eight years of sobriety I always wondered why I drank. I just couldn't find the reason. Then, one day while reading *Living Sober* (p. 2) I found the answer. I drank because I had never learned to live sober. It was that simple!

Thank you for teaching me this way of life.

*Jack Shaver, Manitoba
delegate chairperson*

Keynote Address

My name is Donald Weaver and I am an alcoholic. My home group is the Vicksburg Group in Vicksburg, Michigan. Our theme for this Conference is "Spirituality—Our Foundation." This theme covers a lot, but to bring it down to where I could talk about it I first had to find out what it meant. So I went to the dictionary. Spirituality, it says, is a spiritual character, quality or nature. Under Foundation there were quite a few definitions, but the one we are talking about is "the fundamental principle on which something is founded."

Having put that together I started to look at my program, beginning with the Twelve Steps. I saw the building of a foundation by first seeing the problem—Step One. With Steps Two and Three I hired the contractor or Higher Power. Steps Four and Five cleared the ground. Steps Six through Eleven poured the walls. Step Twelve is where the spiritual foundation starts, and we try to carry this message to another alcoholic. How we do that is shown through the Twelve Traditions.

The Twelfth Tradition says (long form): "And finally, we of Alcoholics Anonymous believe that the principle of anonymity has an immense spiritual significance. It reminds us that we are to place principles before personalities; that we are actually to practice a genuine humility. This to the end that our great blessings may never spoil us; that we shall forever live in thankful contemplation of Him who presides over us all."

And so, as we spend this week together, let us (as past Conferences have) find new ways to reach those who still suffer from alcoholism by letting the principles of Alcoholics Anonymous work through us. One hand giving to another, asking nothing in return, is truly the Spiritual Foundation of our A.A. program.

Donald Weaver, East Central trustee

Workshop: Spirituality — Our Foundation

Wednesday morning Conference members divided into groups of 12 to 14 for workshop discussions based on the Conference theme. Following are the questions and a summary of responses from these discussions.

What can we do in our home groups, district meetings, area assemblies, board meetings and the Conference to emphasize spirituality in our efforts to carry the message? How does spirituality play a part in the following A.A. ideas?

1 Rotation

The shared experience about rotation is that it is very much spiritual in nature. Rotation provides an example of sharing for those who follow, as it allows another A.A. member the privilege of service to the Fellowship. It is also a surefire way to "... catapult us out of our self-centeredness and into a more other-centeredness." In addition: "Rotation brings a new excitement, like Springtime!"

Yielding a service position to another trusted servant—a position that we first began in a state of doubt and insecurity, and now find ourselves very comfortable with—is a beneficial exercise in humility. We are reminded through the process that it's not important who does the job, only that the job gets done. We are made aware that we do not own a position. It is through rotation that



Alcoholics Anonymous avoids entrenched power and stagnation, which helps us to remain united and available for those to come.

Rotation can be seen as an act of faith and trust in a Higher Power, requiring "...our reliance on, instead of defiance of, the spiritual principles of A.A." It keeps our egos in check, letting us know that no one individual is indispensable to the task. Many also experience that deep need to "pass it on," so as to continue to grow spiritually, both on a personal level, and mindful of A.A. as a whole.

Among other great benefits to A.A. noted in the practice of rotation are: a reduction in rigidity, as we allow for fresh input, and opportunities to see service work—and through it our A.A. Fellowship—stay vital and fresh; a demonstration of the willingness of others to volunteer for service work; the joy of seeing new trusted servants grow in service; the development of a healthy detachment from "ownership" that enhances our sober maturity; and an increase in realization for faith and trust in others and a Higher Power, as we let go and trust our trusted servants.

In preventing stagnation, rotation allows us to move on in other ways in our A.A. program, opening new doors to our personal spiritual growth and sense of trust. When we rotate, whether it be as delegate, area officer, D.C.M., trustee, G.S.R., coffee maker or any other service position, we acknowledge that we are just one among many, taking our turn to serve. We are first and foremost members of our A.A. groups, grateful to be at our A.A. meetings. Before too long, we will be needed to serve again in some capacity, be it greeter, sweeper and cleanup person, interim sponsor or some other job; there is always more service work to be done.

In the spirit of Tradition Nine, rotation helps A.A. as a whole to continue to grow and flourish, and provides valuable opportunities for us as individual members to meet new challenges, walking through the fear and pain we so often experience when facing changes in our A.A. journey.

2 Group Conscience

Upholding the informed group conscience is putting Tradition Two into action by following up on the voice of A.A. The group conscience, which is "...in a sense, always in session," is one of our important safeguards in A.A. Among the essential ingredients for an informed group conscience are: relevant information; patience; tolerance; an open mind; a willingness to listen; and a trust in the process. With these in mind, we can be confident that whenever we arrive at and abide by a group conscience decision, we have affirmed spiritually that, for our group purpose, there is "but one ultimate authority—a loving God expressed in our group conscience."

We are well aware in A.A. that our trusted servants do not drive by mandate—they do not govern. The trusted servant who has acquired a measure of humility leads by example, and is well aware that he or she is just a part of a democratic and ongoing process, which hears and respects various opinions on whatever issue the group is seeking to arrive at by substantial unanimity.

Perhaps a group conscience may need further deliberation or more information before going to a vote. When this situation occurs, most agreed that it is appropriate and prudent to wait and pray for direction on an issue, revisiting the issue at the next meeting or at a later date. Lack of information or deliberation on an issue does not lead to an informed group conscience.

Reaching an informed group conscience requires a constant recommitment to patience and a loving attitude, both with each other and with the process. It is crucial to keep an open mind, practicing tolerance of the views of others. We ought to remember that it is often wise to avoid immediate "yes" or "no" responses, particularly on important or sensitive matters. We need always

work on becoming good listeners in group conscience discussions, doing our best to be fair and respectful of the minority opinion, which, as we know, can often awaken the group to new possibilities or options. In accepting the group conscience, we not only cultivate personal humility, but the A.A. Fellowship as a whole grows in unity. The informed group conscience is one of our great protections in Alcoholics Anonymous.

3 Carrying the Message Around the World

All agreed that the suffering of alcoholism knows no barriers or boundaries. We are responsible to extend the hand of A.A. whenever anyone, anywhere reaches out to us, wherever in the world he or she may be. Because we are responsible, we have an obligation to carry the A.A. message of hope and help, not just here at home, but all across the globe. In some situations, we may be able to help carry the message around the world through direct contact. In other situations, we may help spread the message through our financial support of A.A. services worldwide. There are many who look to our U.S./Canada structure, the first formed, for the shared experience and practical help that they need to develop A.A. in the places which they call home.

In our U.S./Canada structure we are, for the most part, blessed with plentiful and available A.A. groups to attend, and we need to be always thankful for this great bounty. We can show our gratitude by being responsible to reach out to those less fortunate than ourselves.

In carrying the message around the world, we need also to be mindful and sensitive to different approaches to spirituality in places that are culturally and ethnically different from our own. The hope and zeal demonstrated by other countries in learning about the life-saving spiritual program of A.A. is invigorating for all of us, and a reminder of how much needs to be done, with gratitude and humility. As the A.A. horizons continue to expand and nourish others, practically and spiritually, we must continually support and encourage these A.A. members around the world. We need always remember to "let it begin with me."

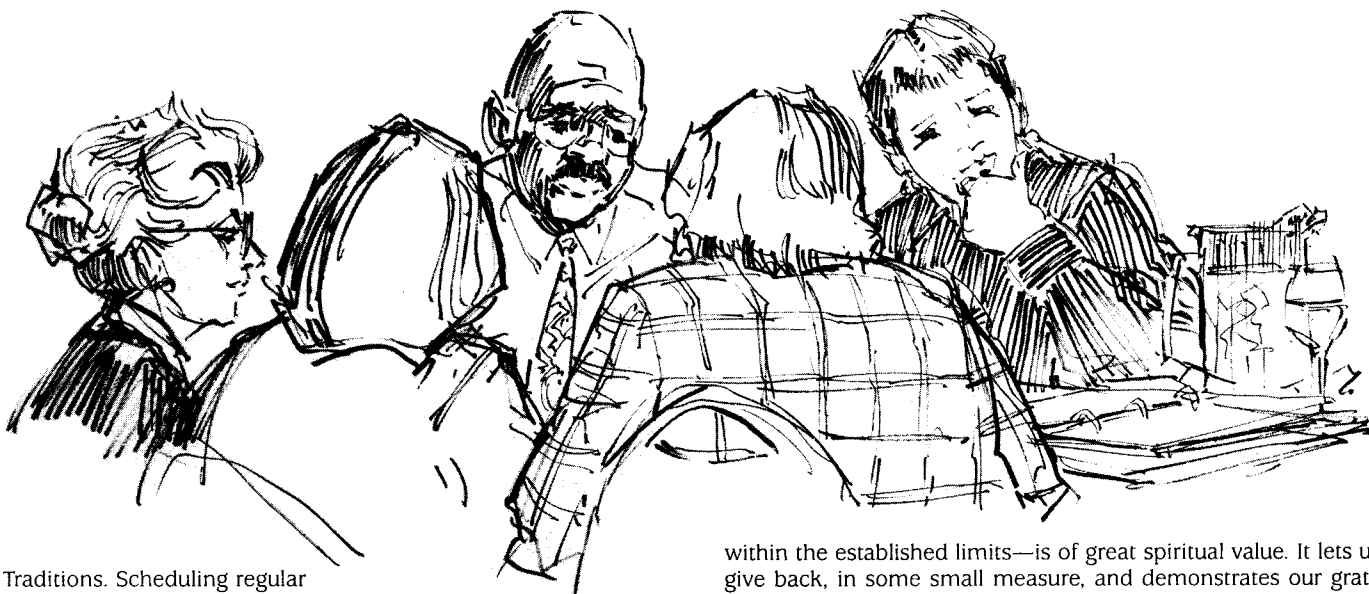
4 Unity

When it comes to our cherished quality of unity "...we are only as strong as our weakest link." While we uphold the individual rights of every A.A. member, we know that without unity the Fellowship cannot survive. Our common welfare comes first. "We must hang together or we hang separately!" We need also keep in mind that it is possible to disagree without being disagreeable. As the Twelve and Twelve reminds us "Without unity, the heart of A.A. would cease to beat; our world arteries would no longer carry the life-giving grace of God."

Safeguarding unity comes about as each member grows in understanding that the good of the group and the good of Alcoholics Anonymous as a whole comes first; that what we may personally feel, may not be a good thing for A.A. as a whole, and that we need to keep an open and loving mind and trust the process. We need to repeatedly surrender our personal ambitions and wishes for the greater good.

Among some of the challenges to A.A. unity that we need to meet are the following: attendance at A.A. meetings by those who continue to identify themselves as "drug addicts" only; our own tendencies to compare rather than to identify with another member; our closed minds on a cherished individual opinion; practical group problems like nonsmoking/smoking issues; and our resistance, at times, to accepting the group conscience with grace and humility.

Beginning in the home group, and at all other levels of A.A. service, unity usually flourishes in direct proportion to increasing understanding and application of the Twelve Steps and Twelve



Traditions. Scheduling regular Step and Tradition meetings is of enormous benefit to group unity. We can never afford to take our unity for granted. It is a gift to be cherished with love and discipline.

Loss of unity in Alcoholics Anonymous could mean that the many, many suffering alcoholics still looking for us would not have the chance for a wonderful new life of sobriety. We are, indeed, responsible and "... only our very best is good enough." We need only to exercise that compelling love for our fellow A.A.s and our beloved A.A. principles to ensure our unity for the future.

5 A.A. Finances

"What allows us to carry the message beyond existing groups, and pays for services at every level? Our contributions to A.A., including our financial contributions." Spirituality is reflected in our willingness to share our financial resources so that the A.A. message can be brought to all who seek the A.A. way of life. We need to be willing to "... pass it on through our wallets." We need "... to share our money with those who can benefit, giving it along with the A.A. message." Beginning in our home groups, we can set an example by being generous when the basket is passed—demonstrating through our group treasury a spirituality in action.

It is important that A.A. members understand about A.A. finances — that they know what happens to contributions made beyond the group expenses. We all need to stay informed about the work of other A.A. services, and their efforts and needs, including financial needs. Holding regular Seventh Tradition meetings, and reporting on the wider world of A.A. helps A.A. members to be more aware and alert to the widespread financial needs, and to see the value of their own participation in helping to carry the A.A. message, both at home and around the world.

The group needs to be shown how "... the funds we put into the basket do not remain money, but turn into a pamphlet to help someone stay sober for one more day." From taking the message into institutions, to C.P.C. and P.I. work, to intergroups and central offices, to world services. As we become more aware of the needs, we better understand that spirituality and money mix "in the hat." What a difference it makes when we come to realize, for example, that our contributions help to get literature translated into other languages, or to carry the message into remote communities.

Being diligent and generous in supporting carrying the A.A. message through our financial contributions to our districts and areas, to our central offices and intergroups, and to our G.S.O. — keeping in mind that we can also make individual contributions,

within the established limits—is of great spiritual value. It lets us give back, in some small measure, and demonstrates our gratitude for our sober lives. Our "... contributions are for our own survival through the survival of Alcoholics Anonymous."

6 Serving with Love

Alcoholics Anonymous is a society in action, and we have to carry the message in order to live. Sharing our precious gift of sobriety with a compelling love is a fine demonstration of our gratitude and thankfulness for the great gift so freely given to us. Love, the essence of spirituality, is found when we truly serve others, and it always brings us so much in return.

When we reach out to a newcomer and to other A.A. members, without thought of our own comfort, and without seeking reward — "not looking for distinction" — we are involved in spirituality in action. We are in the active process of working toward being one among many, sharing the gift of sobriety that was so freely given to us, and truly practicing the A.A. way of life.

To grow in our capacity to be loving and open does, of course, mean continual work on ourselves through the Steps. We need to constantly work on being courteous and tolerant of others, identifying not comparing, and being honestly aware that we are often wrong about things. Every time we make an honest effort in these areas, we grow in our understanding of what love for our fellow A.A. members really means. "We put our personal needs and anxieties second to our service to A.A." We may also, upon occasion, receive or give "tough love" that some respond to, or we may receive or give a simple act of kindness that makes all the difference in the world to our day or to the day of another.

Often we are graced with being able to help where another cannot, simply because we are A.A. members, sharing our experience, strength and hope in recovery in our life-giving program. Thus: Whenever we accept responsibility — whether in our home group or in our lives as a whole; whenever we agree to abide by the informed group conscience; whenever we try to keep an open mind; whenever we pray "... only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out;" and whenever we seek to practice the A.A. principles in all our affairs, we are, indeed, serving with love.

Through serving with love we become open to having love and service returned to us in many forms, often beginning with the sense of joy and privilege we experience when we have reached out to help another. As expressed in the workshop: "We engage in prayerful thought, realizing that, like the seasons, we are constantly being reborn. We come to learn that spirituality is not a belief, but an experience of love."

Conference Advisory Actions

Conference Advisory Actions represent recommendations made by the standing committees and approved by the Conference body as a whole or recommendations discussed and voted on by all Conference members during general sessions. The group conscience of the Fellowship in the United States and Canada was expressed in the Following Advisory Actions, which the General Service Board accepted in its legally required annual meeting following the 1997 Conference.

AGENDA

It was recommended that:

- 1 The theme for the 1998 General Service Conference be: "Our Twelfth Step Work."
- 2 The following be presentation/discussion topics for the 1998 General Service Conference:
 - a) Our Twelfth Step Work:
 - 1) Reaching the Newcomer
 - 2) Carrying This Message
 - 3) Back to Basics
 - b) Tools for Twelfth Stepping:
 - 1) The A.A. Member
 - 2) Sponsorship
 - 3) Literature
 - c) Diversity of Twelfth Step Work:
 - 1) Home Group
 - 2) Service Structure
 - 3) Around the World
- 3 The following be the workshop topic for the 1998 General Service Conference: Our Twelfth Step Work:
 - a) In the Home Group
 - b) In the Service Structure
 - c) Around the World

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

It was recommended that:

- 4 The following statement regarding Singleness of Purpose be added to the C.P.C. pamphlets: "Alcoholics Anonymous in Your Community," "A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs," "A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional," "How A.A. Members Cooperate With Professionals," "If You Are a Professional," and "Members of the Clergy Ask About Alcoholics Anonymous" under the title "Singleness of Purpose and Problems Other Than Alcohol," at the next printing:

"Alcoholism and drug addiction are often referred to as 'substance abuse' or 'chemical dependency.' Alcoholics and non-alcoholics are, therefore, sometimes introduced to A.A. and encouraged to attend A.A. meetings. Anyone may attend *open* A.A. meetings. But only those with a *drinking* problem may attend *closed* meetings or become A.A. members. People with problems other than alcoholism are eligible for A.A. membership *only* if they have a drinking problem."

- 5 The following items be added or replaced under the title "What A.A. Does Not Do" to the following pamphlets: "Alcoholics Anonymous in Your Community," "If You Are a Professional" and

"Members of the Clergy Ask About Alcoholics Anonymous," at the next printing:

A.A. does not: Furnish initial motivation for alcoholics to recover; solicit members; engage in or sponsor research; keep attendance records or case histories; join "councils" of social agencies; follow up or try to control its members; make medical or psychological diagnoses or prognoses; provide drying-out or nursing services, hospitalization, drugs, or any medical or psychiatric treatment; offer religious services; engage in education about alcohol; provide housing, food, clothing, jobs, money or any other welfare or social services; provide domestic or vocational counseling; accept any money for its services or any contributions from non-A.A. sources; provide letters of reference to parole boards, lawyers, court officials, social agencies, employers, etc.

- 6 The C.P.C. Kit and Workbook be designated as service material rather than "A.A. General Service Conference-approved literature."

CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

It was recommended that:

- 7 The video on encouraging more A.A. members to participate in carrying the A.A. message into correctional facilities be completed and brought back to the 1998 Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities for review. (Note: the additional cost of completing the video would be approximately \$41,000.) The following should be reflected in the video footage:

- a) Singleness of purpose.
- b) Correctional Facilities workshops.
- c) Reaction from men and women inmates attending A.A. meetings at their facility and from outside members who carry the message inside.
- d) Inmate speakers at an A.A. event.
- e) Unpredictability and roadblocks of carrying the message inside.
- f) How to improve communication within A.A. and with prison administrators.
- g) Once A.A.s are involved, how do we keep them involved.
- h) Emphasis on the outside members' participation and perspective.

- 8 The name of the pamphlet, "A Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators" be changed to "A Message to Correctional Professionals," and that the following two paragraphs from the pamphlet "If You Are Professional," be included: "A.A. Wants to Work With You," and "What A.A. Does Not Do."

FINANCE

It was recommended that:

- 9 The phrase "Any suggested prudent reserve for a group should be dependent on local needs. A suggested prudent reserve for central offices, intergroups, and area committees could be one to twelve months' operating expenses, depending on local needs." be substituted for: "At the group level, this usually means approximately two months' worth of group expenses which can be used to help the group through any unforeseen circumstances. Districts, areas and central offices/intergroups also maintain some percentage of their operating expenses in a prudent reserve fund." as the definition of a prudent reserve in the current Self-Support pamphlet. This would appear on page 9 of the September '96 printing of F-3.

10 The area contributions for delegates' expenses for the Conference be increased from \$600 (U.S.) to \$800 (U.S.) and that, in the spirit of the Seventh Tradition, areas continue to be encouraged to make contributions over and above this requested amount to help cover a greater portion of the Conference costs.

GRAPEVINE

It was recommended that:

11 Information about La Viña be included in the 1997-98 edition of *The A.A. Service Manual* (Chapter XI: "The A.A. Grapevine").

12 The manuscript providing basic information on the A.A. Grapevine magazine and its place in Alcoholics Anonymous be produced as a pamphlet.

13 The Grapevine use mailing lists to provide introductory information about the Grapevine and La Viña to correctional facilities and treatment facilities.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/REGIONAL FORUMS

No recommendations.

LITERATURE

It was recommended that:

14 Some video taping of a facsimile of the 47th General Service Conference, as well as of a Conference committee, be permitted, keeping in mind the preservation of our Traditions of anonymity. (For possible inclusion in the video on G.S.O., the Grapevine and the service structure.)

15 After reviewing with appreciation the rough cut of the video on G.S.O., the Grapevine and the service structure, that a final cut of the video be prepared by the trustees' Literature Committee and forwarded to the 1998 Conference Literature Committee for approval, accompanied by its service piece and including modifications provided to the trustees' Literature Committee.

16 A draft Fourth Edition of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, be developed and a progress report be brought to the 1998 Conference Literature Committee, keeping in mind the 1995 Advisory Action that:

"The first 164 pages of the Big Book, Alcoholics Anonymous, the Preface, the Forewords, 'The Doctor's Opinion,' 'Dr. Bob's Nightmare,' and the Appendices remain as is."

17 A publication of stories dropped from the First, Second and Third Editions of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, be developed, and a progress report be brought to the 1998 Conference Literature Committee.

18 The following material from the Sixth Warranty be added to the section "What is An A.A. Group?" on page 15 of "The A.A.

Group" pamphlet so that section could now include:

A section from Warranty Six found in the Twelfth Concept on page 73 of *The A.A. Service Manual*:

- "no penalties to be inflicted for nonconformity to A.A. principles;
- no fees or dues to be levied—voluntary contributions only;
- no member to be expelled from A.A.—membership always to be the choice of the individual;
- each A.A. group to conduct its internal affairs as it wishes—it being merely requested to abstain from acts that might injure A.A. as a whole; and finally
- that any group of alcoholics gathered together for sobriety may call themselves an A.A. group provided that, *as a group*, they have no other purpose or affiliation."

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

It was recommended that:

19 The delegate from Area 9, Mid-Southern California, Nick Murray, Panel 46, be seated as a Conference member in place of the delegate, Lona Wright-Parker, Panel 46, who resigned.

20 Michaela Klimanova Trizuljakova, from Slovakia, be granted permission to attend the 47th General Service Conference as an observer.

21 The 50th General Service Conference be held April 30-May 6, 2000, since these dates do not conflict with any major religious holidays.

22 The name of Area 72 be changed from Western Washington State Area to Western Washington Area.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

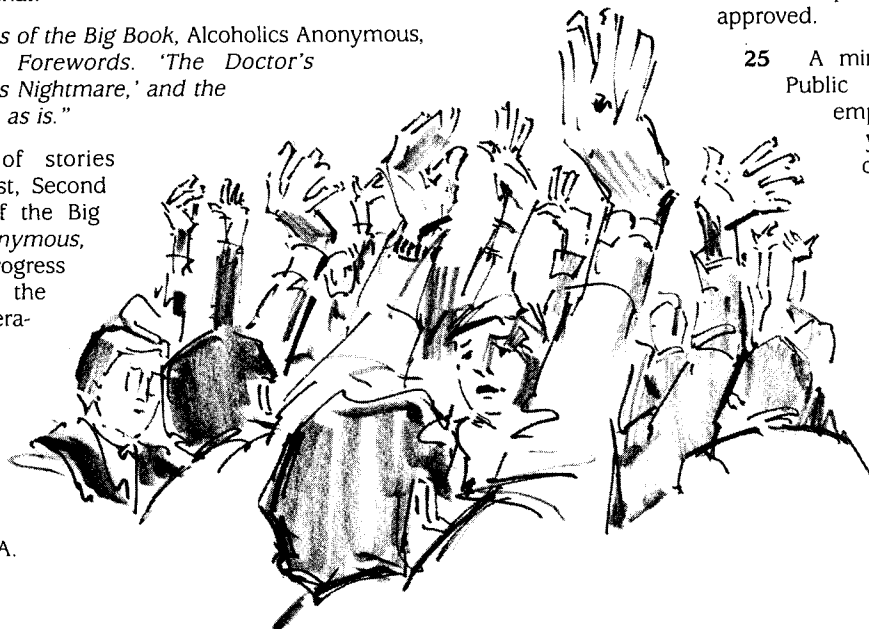
It was recommended that:

23 The Membership Survey pamphlet and the one-way Membership Survey display be updated to reflect the findings from the 1996 Membership Survey.

24 The draft of the revised 1998 Membership Survey Questionnaire be approved.

25 A minimum of three television Public Service Announcements emphasizing membership of young people, membership of minorities and generic A.A. information be produced (cost not to exceed \$40,000) and be presented to the 1998 Conference Public Information Committee for approval.

26 The Public Information Service Kit and Workbook be designated as service material rather than "A.A. General Service Conference-approved literature."



REPORT AND CHARTER

It was recommended that:

27 The selected diagram, as modified, illustrating the Third Legacy Procedure be added to the next edition of *The A.A. Service Manual* adjacent to page S41 to help people new to general service understand the process described on pages S41, S63-64 and S118 of the 1996-1997 edition of *The A.A. Service Manual*, and that each description of the Third Legacy Procedure in the next edition of *The A.A. Service Manual* refer to the diagram.

28 The paragraph on page S41 of the 1996-1997 edition of *The A.A. Service Manual* reading "After the second ballot (assuming no candidate receives the necessary two-thirds on the first ballot), any candidate having less than *one-fifth* of the total vote will be withdrawn *automatically*, except that the TWO TOP CANDIDATES must remain. (In case there are ties for second place, the top candidate and tied second-place candidates remain.)" be replaced by "**Withdrawals start after the second ballot. If any candidate has less than one-fifth of the total vote, his or her name is *automatically* withdrawn—except that the top two candidates must remain. (If there are ties for second place, the top candidate and all tied runners-up remain as candidates.)**"; that paragraph (i), page S64, be replaced with the same language; and, that a sentence be added to the description of the Third Legacy Procedure on page S118 at the beginning of item 1 "**The first candidate to receive two-thirds of the total vote is elected.**"

29 Because of the importance of this principle to A.A. unity worldwide, there be no change to Article 2, paragraph 4 of the Current Conference Charter.

30 A thorough review of *The A.A. Service Manual* be undertaken by the Publications Department of the General Service Office for the purpose of increasing readability, consolidating and clarifying the text, and that a preliminary draft be sent to the 1998 Conference Committee on Report and Charter no later than February 1, 1998 for consideration.

31 On-line A.A. meetings that request to be listed in A.A. directories be added to the "International Correspondence Meetings" in A.A. directories, that each listing include the internet address of the on-line meeting, and that each on-line meeting requesting to be listed in our directories furnish G.S.O. with the name and physical address of a member willing to serve as "mail" contact.

32 An intergroup serving on-line A.A. meetings should be listed adjacent to on-line A.A. meetings in the section on "International Correspondence Meetings."

TREATMENT FACILITIES

It was recommended that:

33 A concise and streamlined version of the Treatment Facilities Workbook (three-ring binder) be accepted with minor changes.

34 The final draft of the soft-cover Treatment Facilities Handbook be accepted.

TRUSTEES

It was recommended that:

35 The slate of trustees and officers be referred to the annual meeting of members of the respective corporate boards in April 1997 (see page 00; the Conference and board approved the slate approved by the trustees' Nominating Committee).

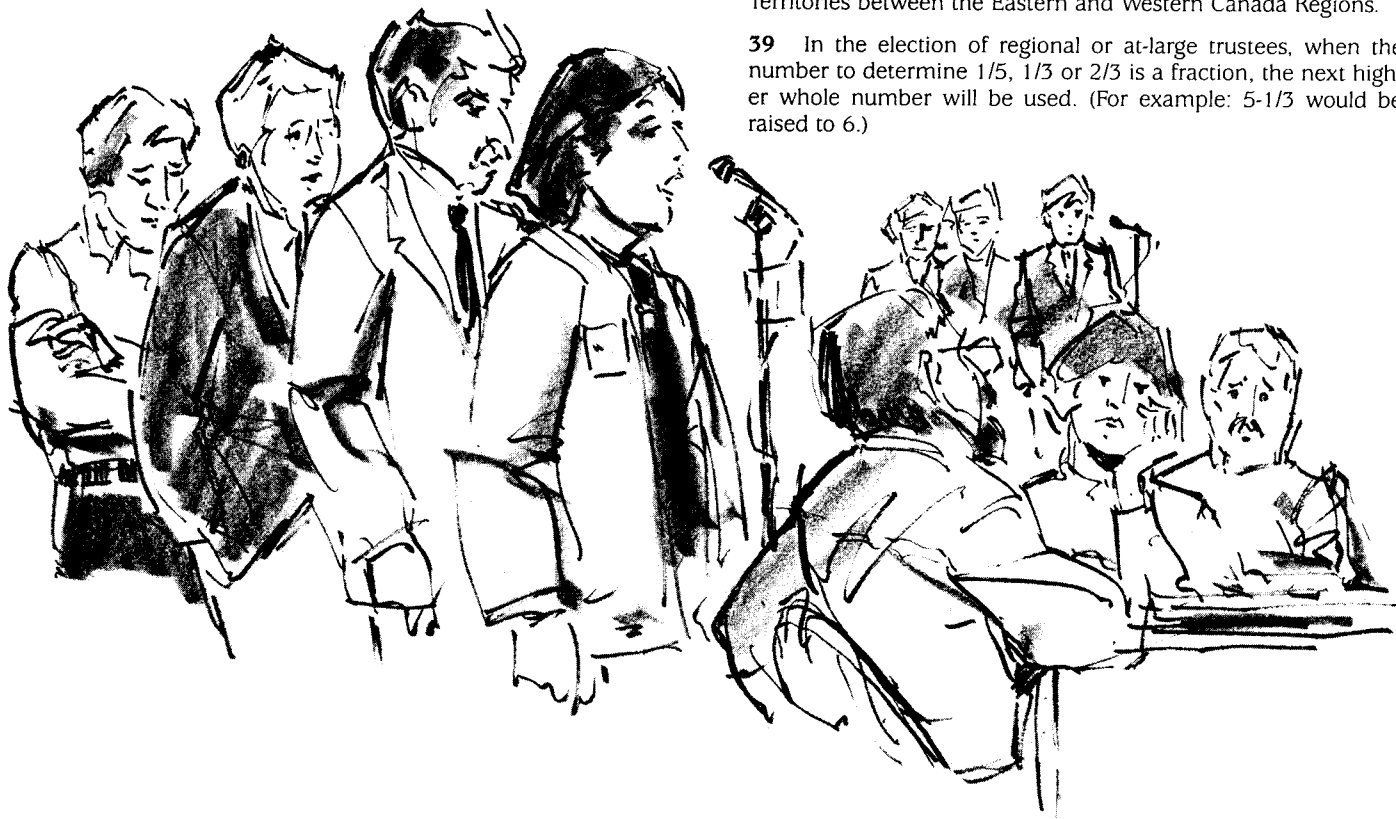
Note: General Service Board to operate short one general service trustee between April 1997 and April 1998.

36 The slate of directors be elected to the A.A. World Services Corporate Board (see page 00; slate of directors approved).

37 The slate of directors be elected to the A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board (see page 00; slate of directors approved).

38 The 90th Meridian be the dividing line in the Northwest Territories between the Eastern and Western Canada Regions.

39 In the election of regional or at-large trustees, when the number to determine $1/5$, $1/3$ or $2/3$ is a fraction, the next higher whole number will be used. (For example: $5-1/3$ would be raised to 6.)



Presentations and Reports

REPORT: FINANCE

Monday afternoon the Finance report was given by Donald Meurer, G.S.O.'s controller and assistant treasurer of the General Service Board. The report was followed by questions and sharing. For more details please see the Finance section of this Report.

What I realize this year, more so than in the past, is that it's not so much the dollars and cents of what we say, but how we say it.

You will find in the Finance section, in the back of the Conference Report, the Audited Financial Statements of The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc. This includes an independent auditors report in which the auditors say our financial statements are okay. You have Exhibit A, which is now called The Combined Statement of Financial Position for the General Fund, the Reserve Fund, the Capital Projects Fund, A.A. World Services, Inc., and the Grapevine. Exhibit B is now called The Combined Statement of Activities, also for the General Fund, the Reserve Fund, the Capital Projects Fund, A.A. World Services, Inc., and the Grapevine, both English and Spanish. This Statement of Activities is what the Higher Power in the accounting world now calls what used to be known as the Income Statement. Following this is Exhibit C, the Combined Statement of Functional Expenses, which describes all the various expenses—such as salaries, payroll, postage, selling expense, stationery, etc.—by the various functions, such as group services, Fellowship services, General Service Conference, etc. Following this is a Combined Statement of Cash Flows, Exhibit D. This tells you where our cash came from and what happened to it. Then you have the notes to the Financial Statements, which in the Auditors' bound copies are approximately seven and a half pages of text.

If you want to read these things, by all means be my guest. If you really want to know what's happening, in a condensed, easy-to-read format is the G.S.O. 1997 Operating Budget (includes '96 results), the Grapevine '97 Budget (with '96 results) and a one-page write-up entitled Budget Highlights. There is also the complete treasurer's report.

For our purposes, we will make it even simpler, a few basic lines with round numbers. G.S.O. gets money from two sources: contributions and the sale of literature. And we spend money on two things: providing services and producing literature. Last year we had net sales of \$8.3 million from books, booklets, and pamphlets. It cost us \$5.1 million to print, ship, and pay royalties on these items, leaving us with a gross profit from literature of \$3.2 million. The expenses of running the office at 475 Riverside Drive, \$2.3 million, is allocated to publishing, which leaves a net income from publishing of \$898,000. Both gross profit and net income from literature for 1996 were approximately equal to 1995. You might recall that when A.A.W.S. lowered prices and increased discounts in 1994, in order to return to

the Fellowship the excess amount in the Reserve Fund, they expected to cut literature income by about \$1 million. This has been accomplished for the past two years.

The second part of the G.S.O. financial picture is contributions and services. Contributions last year were up \$250,000, to \$3.9 million. We spent \$6.1 million on service-related expenses, which was \$2.2 million more than we took in from contributions. Contributions covered 64% of services expenses last year, compared with 65% in 1994. Literature income and a Reserve Fund reduction covered the balance.

There are 56,000 groups listed with G.S.O. Services to the Fellowship costs us \$108 per group. The average contribution per group was \$70, counting both groups that contribute and those that don't. If each group listed at G.S.O. contributed \$39 more per year—that is 74 cents per week *per group*—contributions would have entirely covered the expense of providing services.

Use of literature profits to pay for services does not present us with a Traditions problem. Bill W. covered this very well in the Second Warranty: "This net income to the groups and to A.A.'s General Services is actually the sum of a great many contributions which the book buyers make to the general welfare of Alcoholics Anonymous. The certain and continuous solvency of our world services rests squarely upon these contributions." (*Twelve Concepts for World Service*, p. 66) We should be concerned, however, if contributions should shrink too far. I don't know what "too far" is, but it is something we should talk about, and if we keep talking about it things will be okay.

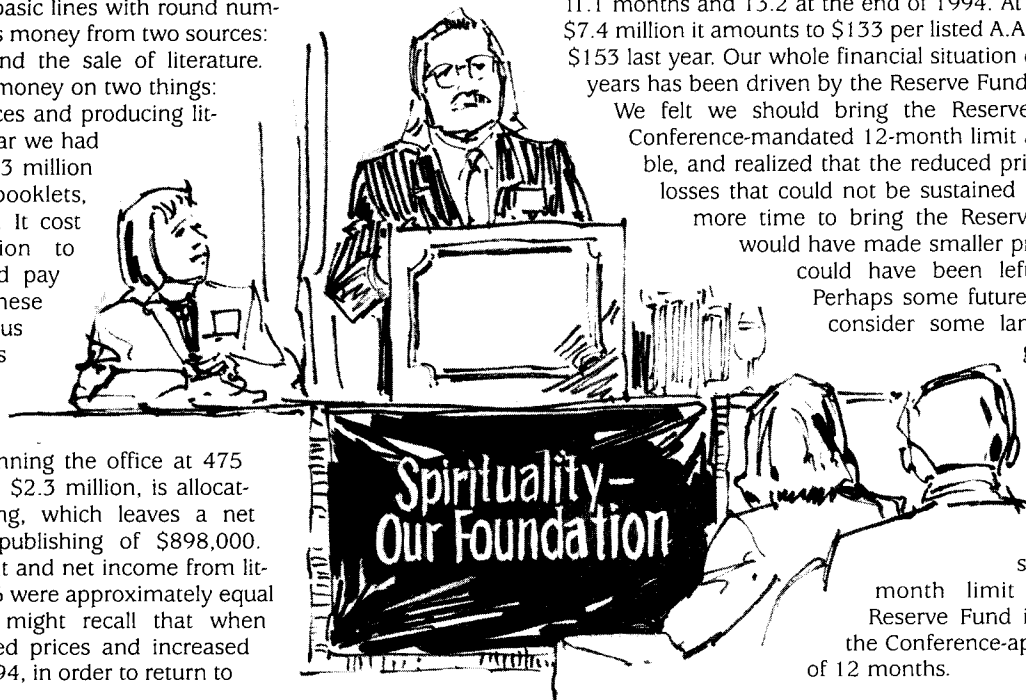
Adding the \$898,000 profit from literature and the \$2.2 million loss from services together gives us our net loss for G.S.O. of \$1,264,000. This actual loss is \$153,000 less than our budgeted loss of \$1,417,200.

Gross sales were approximately \$370,000 below budget. After allowing for decreased cost of manufacturing, royalties and shipping and warehousing directly associated with these reduced sales, gross profit for the period was approximately \$76,000 less than budgeted. Offsetting this, contributions were \$175,000 higher than budgeted. Expenses were actually \$50,000 below budget.

Our Reserve Fund finished the year at nine months of combined G.S.O. and Grapevine operating expenses. A year ago it was 11.1 months and 13.2 at the end of 1994. At the current level of \$7.4 million it amounts to \$133 per listed A.A. group, down from \$153 last year. Our whole financial situation during the past few years has been driven by the Reserve Fund.

We felt we should bring the Reserve Fund below the Conference-mandated 12-month limit as quickly as possible, and realized that the reduced prices would result in losses that could not be sustained for long. If we had more time to bring the Reserve Fund down, we would have made smaller price reductions that could have been left in place longer.

Perhaps some future Conference might consider some language that would give us more time to get below the 12-month ceiling, while keeping in place the understanding that it is not a good idea to stay above the 12-month limit indefinitely. The Reserve Fund is now well within the Conference-approved upper limit of 12 months.



As those of you who were here last year may recall, during the finance presentation the expectation to increase prices this year was discussed. As described more fully in the treasurer's report, this year's budget calls for an increase in the cost of the hard-cover Big Book by a dollar, other books will go up between 60 cents and \$1.50, and there will be some adjustments in the Spanish pricing.

It is interesting to note that since 1990, our unit sales on books have been declining at an average rate of 4½ % per year. What this means is that now we are selling approximately 25 % fewer books than we did in 1990. The 1997 Budget assumes a 5 % decline in unit literature sales, a 3 % increase in contributions and flat operating expenses. A loss for 1997 of \$139,000 is projected.

Why were we faced with raising prices or cutting services? Let's look at some history. A.A. grew rapidly during the 1980s and, at least when measured by book sales or contributions, has declined in the nineties. We don't have the growth umbrella to pay the bills the way we did in the eighties. Take for example unit sales of the Big Book. Sales grew from 300,000 in 1979 to 1.2 million ten years later. That's a growth rate of 15 % per year. Growth in sales of the Twelve and Twelve was the same 15 %. *Living Sober* grew at 13 %, and so on. With unit sales like that, literature income was growing so rapidly that it was easy to support services. During the '90s, sales of all of our books have fallen off by anywhere from 18 to 40 percent.

Contributions in the '80s were growing at 13 % per year, which helped pay for services. Notice, by the way, that contributions peaked at \$4.4 million in 1990; last year, they were just over \$3.9 million.

Despite the decline in sales and contributions, and despite the rising costs of printing, we have been able to maintain services and cut prices since the peak years by careful control of costs and by drawing down the excess in the Reserve Fund. Drawdown from the Reserve Fund has gone as far as it can without, in my opinion, putting us in conflict with the Second Warranty's promise of "Sufficient operating funds, plus an ample Reserve..." (*ibid*, p. 63)

So, the three reasons we have been able to maintain services without raising prices are no longer available to us. The rapid growth of the 1980s is probably behind us. Cutting costs without affecting services is likely to be much more difficult. And we no longer have an excess Reserve Fund to spend.

How much should raising literature prices bother us? Our books are very inexpensive. If the price of the Big Book had kept pace with inflation, it would sell for \$30.00 today. When first published the Big Book sold for \$2.50/\$3.50—now we're going to \$6.00. What did it cost when you came to A.A.? By any measure or comparison, A.A. literature is a great value.

The Grapevine has already faced a similar dilemma a year or so ago and had a price increase to keep itself financially healthy, while increasing services by making all of its issues 64 pages long. Another point to make about the Grapevine is to assure you that considerations about the Reserve Fund include the commitment to fund the initial Spanish Grapevine project, so it hopefully may go on to be a successful part of carrying A.A.'s message to Spanish-speaking alcoholics. After an interesting start-up period, the Grapevine is reviewing the project and will present a revised plan to the trustees' Finance Committee in July.

We understand expenses are up all around; however, we hope that A.A. can increase the level of contributions, not just to G.S.O., but to the wider world of service entities, and not just because it would make our financial situation at G.S.O. easier. It has been said that our emphasis should be on spiritual principles—the recognition that each group is part of something

much bigger than itself and has the opportunity to help carry the A.A. message around the world—in effect, Twelfth Step work at a level that the groups can't do alone. A group contribution, no matter how small, represents more than money. It represents a group's understanding of and desire for the services it pays for. It represents a contribution toward A.A. unity.

I would like to conclude with comments about a trip I made recently. I was invited to the Washington, D.C. Area's 24th Annual General Service Assembly. Several points come to mind: First, I had some trepidation, as this was my first solo service event. Second, I believe there were six past delegates in attendance, and I was truly impressed at the answers they gave to questions from the Ask-it-Basket. (I guess I thought past delegates just went back to making coffee.) Third, I walked into the church meeting room at 8:30 on Saturday morning and was greeted by men and women, or I should more accurately say boys and girls, who were in fact my children's ages. These people were so young that I was afraid some of my comments would not be understood in the context in which I lived them. Later I inquired as to the age of the youngest person, without knowing the length of sobriety—she was now 16 years old.

Lastly, a phrase I heard at one of the workshops sticks in my mind—it is "*Remember, we don't know how to do it, you have to show us.*" I believe this, more than anything I've come across in my 25 years of association with A.A., explained sponsorship to me.

Donald W. Meurer, G.S.O. controller

REPORT: AD HOC SITE REVIEW COMMITTEE

Following the Finance Report Monday afternoon, the chairman of the Site Review Committee presented the Report, which Conference members had received earlier in the day.

1996 Ad Hoc Site Review Committee

I want to share with you some comments about the people, the process and the recommendations this committee made with unanimity. First, the people. Bob Pelot, Quebec; Wendy Zaparaniuk, Saskatchewan; Joycie Wren, Georgia; George Dorsey, New York; Carolyn Hammond, Kansas; Robbie Sullivan, Montana and Julian Rhinehart (our vice-chair), Pacific regional trustee.

I purposely mentioned where the committee members were from. Following last year's Conference, our chairman, Jim Estelle, selected this geographically dispersed committee and asked me (from Chicago) to chair it. While I had met most of the delegate committee members at last year's Conference, I really didn't know any of them well but, in my opinion, Jim couldn't have given me a better group to work with. Each came to the task, having studied the background material, fully prepared and ready to contribute to the process. Each took an active role in the process—and the process clearly worked, judging from the fact of our unanimous report. Having chaired more than my share of meetings, I can tell you that this was a different experience, and I want to go on record recognizing this fine committee and the diligent and spiritual work it did.

Additionally, and most importantly, Don Meurer, G.S.O.'s controller, acted both as our secretary and our continual fountain of facts and figures—in fact, he almost drowned us in the fountain of data provided. And, finally, Ames Sweet, executive editor of the Grapevine, gave us significant insight into the operations and needs of the Grapevine.

A few words about the process. Our committee was charged to complete an initial review of the current site of the offices and report to the General Service Board on their suitability, any recommendations for change or improvement and any other options the committee might wish to present to the trustees for further consideration. In other words, a pretty broad scope to enable us to evaluate our physical site.

You might wonder why Jim would want us to consider this matter in 1996, given that our lease doesn't expire until 2001. Well, first, we all know that things don't happen at the speed of light in the A.A. process. And, second, if our investigation would have ended with a recommendation for a move of the offices, as happened in 1992, then it would be none to soon to start the planning.

The process we followed took several steps. We all did a significant amount of prework, reading prior site review reports and generally familiarizing ourselves with the history of the offices prior locations. Then, with Don Meurer's fine help, we learned about the financial aspects of our current location. This exhibit summarizes the pertinent facts:

- We lease about forty thousand square feet in the nonprofit Interchurch Center.
- Our rent, including utilities, cleaning and parking, as well as the use of common facilities, is \$14.00 a square foot. This is substantially less than we were paying at the former location (about \$20.00 a foot) and much less than commercially available space in New York or other metropolitan areas of the country.
- Our total occupancy costs in 1996 were a little over \$600,000, as you can see in our audited financial statements, discussed earlier, and that represents about 6% of our total 1996 expenses for all services, including G.S.O., publishing and the Grapevine.
- We also considered the cost of our last move, about \$3.3 million in all, and the fact that the professional studies done some years ago estimated the cost of a move somewhere between \$2 and \$3 million dollars. Even if we could cut our occupancy costs in half (highly unlikely in New York or anywhere else, in my opinion, for comparable kind of space) we would have a significant drain on our Reserve Fund and a lengthy ten-year payback to justify another location.

Having done our pragmatic financial review, and lead by Bob Pelot, who rightfully reminded me that there was much more to our deliberations than the financial aspect, we turned our discussion to the history and heritage of Alcoholics Anonymous. Quoting from

our Final Report, because these words say it so well: "The history of A.A. surrounding the New York area provides an anchor point for our Fellowship. The further we grow away from the days of members who knew our founders, the more we need roots. The taproot is in New York."

Finally, and I'll let you draw your own conclusion from this, just as John D. Rockefeller helped this Fellowship in its early days by teaching us the need for self-support, his hand still is at work in the Fellowship. You see, the nondenominational, nonprofit Interchurch Center that we occupy today was built and funded by the Rockefeller Foundation.

Having completed our review, we made the following recommendations to the trustees at the February 3rd meeting, and they were unanimously accepted.

First, that the site remain in New York City where we have historical roots and a heritage for our spiritual foundation.

Second, that the current site at the Interchurch Center be retained, with investigation into early renewal of our lease at current rates. In other words, locking in the favorable rent for a longer period of time.

Third, that the general manager of the G.S.O., the editor of the Grapevine and the staff all continue to look for opportunities to reconfigure office activities and space for further economic savings.

Arthur L. Knight, Jr., Class A trustee

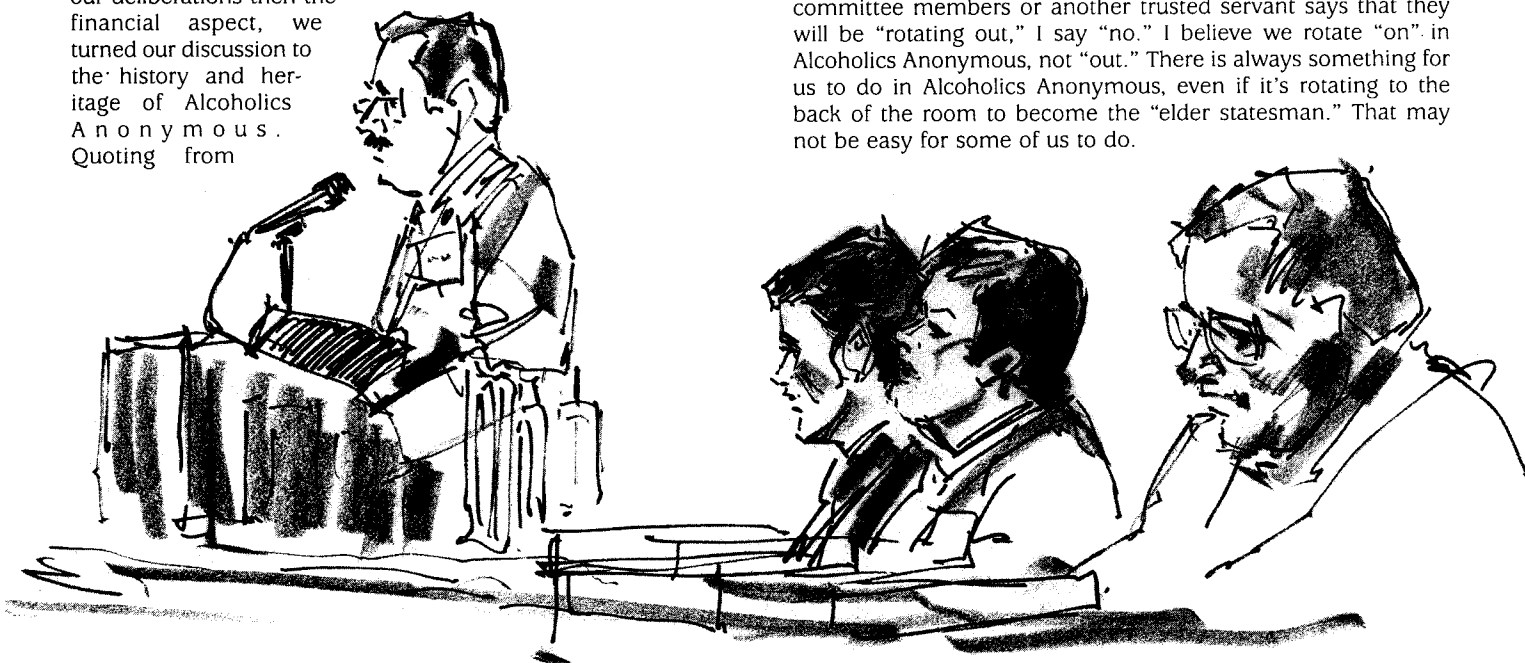
SPIRITUALITY—OUR FOUNDATION

Monday evening's presentations addressed the Conference theme. *Spirituality—Our Foundation*. Eva Sanchez, G.S.O. staff, served as moderator.

Spirit of Rotation

First of all, I must admit I did not jump with joy when I received the invitation to share with you this evening. It had never entered my mind that I would be one of the presenters here at the Conference. Believe me, I would rather be sitting with you than standing here. Perhaps this is part of the spirit of rotation. This is my last Conference and I will be rotating on, and next year one of you will be standing here.

I said I would be "rotating on." In my area, when one of my committee members or another trusted servant says that they will be "rotating out," I say "no." I believe we rotate "on" in Alcoholics Anonymous, not "out." There is always something for us to do in Alcoholics Anonymous, even if it's rotating to the back of the room to become the "elder statesman." That may not be easy for some of us to do.



I went to Mr. Webster's Dictionary, as many of us do. Let me share his thoughts. "Rotation—the action or process of rotating on or as if on an axis or center (b): one complete turn: the angular displacement required to return a rotating body or figure to its original orientation."

So we continue to rotate "on" and not "out," and perhaps I may end up back where I originally started in A.A.—making coffee, wiping off tables, working with more newcomers and helping them to rotate on.

It was through the examples of my sponsor and older members as they rotated on that I began to understand the spirit of rotation, and they encouraged me to become more involved and active in Alcoholics Anonymous. I saw some of them rotate on graciously; others had a little difficulty letting go. But, as time went on, I saw the healing experience come about as they began to understand the spirit behind it. They gave me the opportunity to serve. They allowed me to make mistakes. They gave me the right to be right and the right to be wrong. By doing this, they gave me the opportunity to grow; I hope, perhaps, to grow more in His likeness. They gave me what had been given to them. They were passing it on.

I believe the spirit of rotation, which has become one of our A.A. customs, is one of the principles that keeps our Fellowship alive and growing. We need new eyes or perhaps a new pair of glasses at times. Sometimes I can look at something so long that I can't see the forest for the trees. Or perhaps I start thinking I know best or have all the answers. On page 267 in *Best of the Grapevine*, Vol. 1, Bill said that "... it [rotating] mercifully helps solve the seniority problem we older members can inflict on newer ones. ..." New trusted servants are just as important to the future of Alcoholics Anonymous as newcomers are to the group. Sometimes we can be somewhere too long and become stagnant. We may stop growing, as well as prevent growth. I also believe rotation has helped me to grow and allowed me to want and seek humility in my life's journey.

Many of us here will be rotating on this year and facing another turning point in our journey. The Panel 46 delegates will step aside for the Panel 48 delegates. A few of our trustees, our chairman of the board and even the general manager will soon be standing at the same turning point. Hopefully, we will lead by example as we move aside and allow someone else the opportunity to be of service to God and those about us.

I believe the axis or center for me in my rotation has been God's grace. Through this grace a foundation was started and a triangle built which came together with recovery, unity and service. This triangle rotates for me around God's grace within the circle of God's arms and Alcoholics Anonymous. So I look forward, with a great deal of enthusiasm and eager anticipation, to coming full circle in my journey of rotation. I look forward to experiencing the great joy of working with newcomers more than I have been able to in the last few years.

On page 110 in *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* it says, "To watch the eyes of men and women open with wonder as they move from darkness into light, to see their lives quickly fill with new purpose and meaning, to see whole families reassembled, to see the alcoholic outcast received back into the community in full citizenship, and above all to watch these people awakened to the presence of a loving God in their lives— these things are the substance of what we receive as we carry A.A.'s message to the next alcoholic." For me, to be involved in this aspect of the rotation process is the greatest of all.

As a result of members practicing the spirit of rotation, I have had a journey filled with new mysteries, joys and experiences I could never have dreamed. I am ready to step aside and let someone else experience the same joys in their journey, and I'm ready to continue to carry the message to the next alcoholic—just as it was carried to me.

Joycie Wren, Georgia

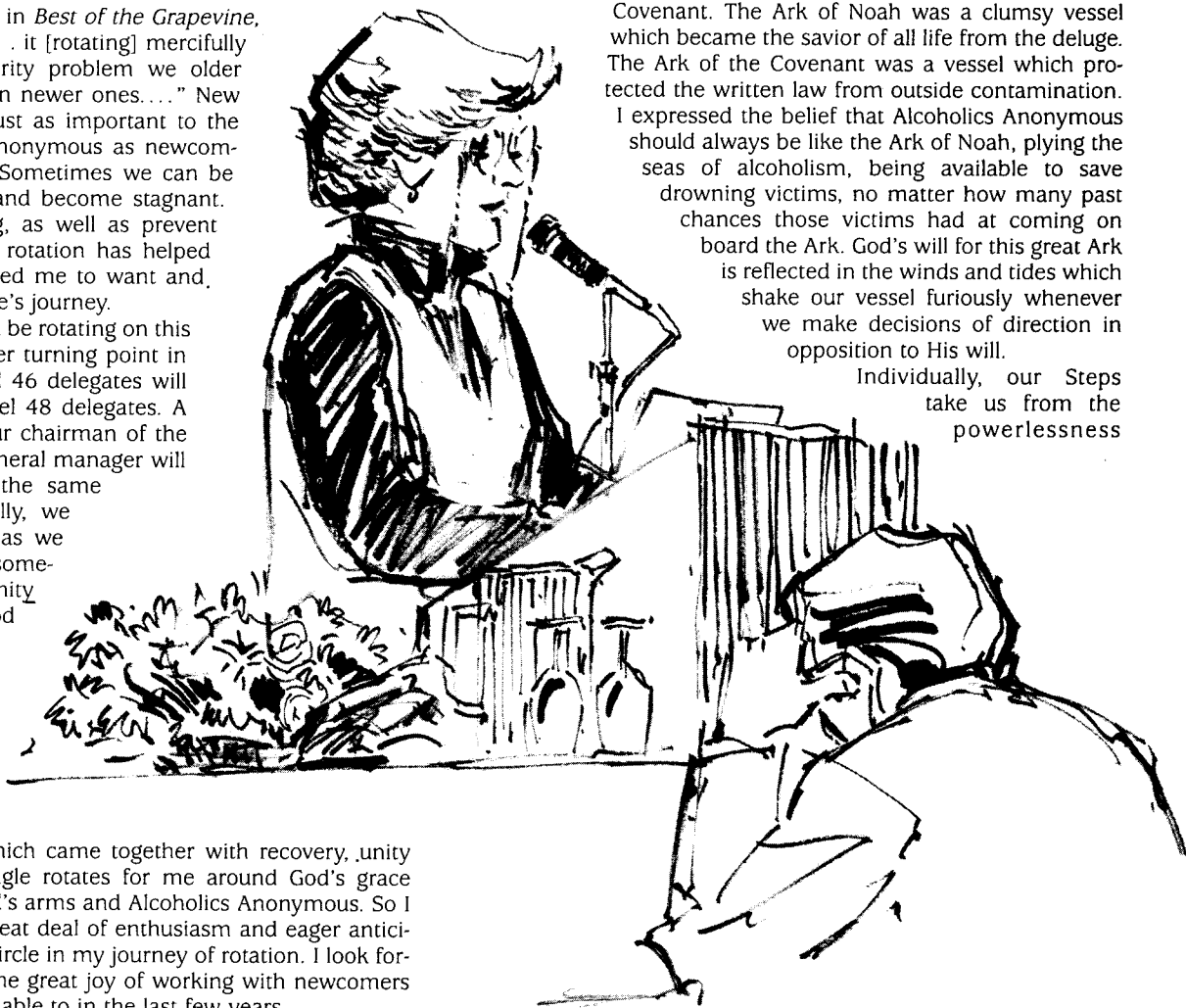
Group Conscience— Seeking Our Ultimate Authority

In making my report to my area after last year's Conference, I used an analogy comparing Alcoholics Anonymous with a great spiritual ark. I like to think of arks as vessels whose existence

was inspired by God Himself. The most famous Arks are the Ark of Noah and the Ark of the Covenant. The Ark of Noah was a clumsy vessel which became the savior of all life from the deluge. The Ark of the Covenant was a vessel which protected the written law from outside contamination.

I expressed the belief that Alcoholics Anonymous should always be like the Ark of Noah, plying the seas of alcoholism, being available to save drowning victims, no matter how many past chances those victims had at coming on board the Ark. God's will for this great Ark is reflected in the winds and tides which shake our vessel furiously whenever we make decisions of direction in opposition to His will.

Individually, our Steps
take us from the
powerlessness



of the First Step to the power of the Eleventh Step, where we seek knowledge of God's will for us through prayer and meditation. "Therefore we of Alcoholics Anonymous are certain that there is but one ultimate authority, a loving God as he may express himself in our group conscience." (*The Language of the Heart*, p. 78) Of all of our literature, Concept X appears to address this idea most deeply: "The principle of ultimate authority runs clear through our structure. This is necessary, because all of our service affairs and activities have to head up *somewhere* for final responsibility. Ultimate authority is also needed so that each worker or each classification of servants knows where and who the final boss is.

"If however, ultimate authority is not qualified by delegated authority, we then have the reverse result. Where there is no delegated authority, the groups would be directing their delegates on every important vote, the delegates would similarly turn the trustees into a timid committee which would receive point-blank direction on just about everything; the trustees would then install themselves as the sole directors of the service entities and commence to run them by directives. The corporate executives would become small czars, pushing the working staffs about. In short, such a misuse of ultimate authority would add up to a dictatorship wherein nearly every classification of A.A. servants would have large responsibilities but no real or certain authority, and hence no capability of effective decision and leadership with which to operate." (*The A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts for World Service*, p. 44) Our Tenth Concept then tells us, "All of this is fully implied in A.A.'s Tradition Two. Here we see the 'group conscience' as the *ultimate* authority and the 'trusted servant' as the *delegated* authority. One cannot function without the other. We well know that only by means of careful definitions and mutual respect can we constantly maintain a right and harmonious working balance." (*ibid*, p. 47)

I believe that I was privileged to be present at one of the most historic moments in the annals of Alcoholics Anonymous. Clearly reflected by the unanimous selection of "Spirituality—Our Foundation" as the theme for this Conference, Alcoholics Anonymous, in the group conscience of the Fellowship as a whole, faced its own fears last year and "made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him." It reaffirmed that our Fellowship is an Ark of Recovery for the alcoholic who still suffers, not an Ark for the Preservation of Doctrinal Rigidity. At the 46th General Service Conference, the miracle of continuing spiritual awakening became tangible; our bonds to one another were freshened and strengthened as Alcoholics Anonymous listened to the language of its own heart and took the Third Step.

A.A.'s spiritual nature was expressed by the former chairman of the board, Bernard B. Smith, "...I regard the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous as the outstanding spiritual phenomenon of our century. I see in the concept of living which is embodied in Alcoholics Anonymous a glorious hope for all of mankind. For the members of this Fellowship are truly witnesses of the living truth that man can live the life of the spirit and still function in a materialistic world." (Letter from Michael Alexander)

I fully support that vision for those of us who have gotten the message. I have had the privilege of being a sponsor to several members whose lives ended prematurely. One died of a stroke which took him suddenly and instantly; two died slowly and sadly of AIDS; and one died unexpectedly and violently of a self-inflicted gunshot wound. The first three were sober at their deaths, but the suicide victim was drunk when he shot himself in the head with a handgun on a street corner. I identified his body in the morgue and, as I looked on his countenance, I knew that alcohol had pulled the trigger and that he had not found the

peace he sought by ending his life. I know that God loves him unconditionally. I also know that my friend never got our message. Although we can't carry the drunk, we can ask ourselves if our message was less attractive to him than it should have been. We can ask if it was denied to him and millions like him by what we of this Society have either done, or failed to do in achieving our primary purpose.

Our book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, "makes clear three pertinent ideas: a) That we were alcoholic and could not manage our own lives. b) That probably no human power could have relieved our alcoholism. c) That God could and would if He were sought." (p. 60)

We seek our ultimate authority because we must. "There is God, our Father, who very simply says, 'I am waiting for you to do my will.' The other authority is named John Barleycorn, and he says, 'You had better do God's will or I will kill you.'" (*A.A. Comes of Age*, p. 105) At the group level, the level from which our whole Society receives its direction, we seek Him in the group conscience which contains the voices of our newest members. We hear Him in the whispered voice of the drunk who says, "Help me!" We respond by offering complete freedom, the most awesome gift of a God who could have made us perfect, but who values freedom more than perfection. As expressed in Warranty Six of the Twelfth Concept, "Freedom under God to grow in His likeness and image will ever be the quest of Alcoholics Anonymous. May our General Service Conference always be seen as a chief symbol of this cherished liberty.

"To a man [and woman], we of A.A. believe that our freedom to serve is truly the freedom by which we live—the freedom in which we have our being." (*Twelve Concepts for World Service*, p. 74)

Can our Society whose members are "not cured of alcoholism..." but who "...have a daily reprieve contingent on the maintenance our spiritual condition" handle a foundation of spirituality? If we follow the advice of Dr. Bob in his last address and remember that "none of us would be here today if somebody hadn't taken time to explain things to us," and also recall his last words to Bill, "...let's not louse this thing up, let's keep it simple!" we can. Groups are charged with the conduct of daily maintenance on their foundation of spirituality in order to "keep on the firing line of life..." so "God will keep you unharmed." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 102) The group must always be the heartbeat of love and service.

I think that we of Alcoholics Anonymous know that a loving God has saved us from ourselves in order that we might do His will. The method of knowing His will for us is the group conscience. The method by which our ultimate authority expresses Himself is essentially captured in this little poem which I have taken the liberty of adapting to our needs, and whose author happens to be anonymous:

"I sought my soul, but my soul I could not see.
I sought my God, but my God eluded me.
I sought [another alcoholic], and I found all three."

John Kane, Southern New Jersey

Unity—We Are Responsible

Any time I talk about unity in Alcoholics Anonymous I find myself referring back to the Twelve Traditions. The First Tradition points out clearly that my recovery depends on A.A. unity. The next six Traditions tell me about unity as it refers to my group and the rest of the Traditions explain about hiring special workers, creating boards and committees that are directly responsible to those they serve, as well as giving us directions on what are outside issues

and the importance we must place on our anonymity. Why should I give any thought to any of this when, after all, the Third Tradition tells me that "the *only* requirement for membership is a desire to stop drinking."

That is where our responsibility begins. It will be very difficult to maintain a spirit of *unity*, if we just say we are members and yet do not know what we are members of. Is A.A. a place where I can come occasionally, say a few words about how the world isn't doing what I expect it to do for my happiness, drop a dollar in the basket and leave, knowing that in a few days, if nothing changes, I can come back and do the same thing again? Or is A.A. a place where, after I work the First Step, I realize I have made a commitment to work the other twelve? How am I going to know this if there is no one around to share their experience, strength and hope as it is explained in the Big Book of Alcoholics Anonymous? Where am I going to find a loving sponsor that will take the time to walk me through the Steps so that I may better understand the reason for doing the work required for my recovery? It is then and only then that I will come to realize that the Twelve Traditions are not something someone reads at the beginning of a meeting, but that they are part of my recovery and must become my way of life.

If I am to be a responsible member of Alcoholics Anonymous then I must *know what I belong to!* How am I going to do that if all I am willing to do is go to an occasional meeting and say I am a member because the Third Tradition says so? The important point I am trying to make is that we should all know more about the Fellowship that has given us back our lives. A Fellowship that has given us back our self-respect and, yes, our families and our jobs but, more important, it has given most of us back our God!

How do we go about learning more about this Fellowship? I suggest we start by rereading the Big Book of Alcoholics Anonymous and trying to identify with the sameness of every-

one on every page. From there I suggest moving to *A.A. Comes of Age*. What better way to get a feel of the person Bill Wilson really was? Meet his family in "*Pass It On*," and find out how he did other things besides talk to drunks. And there is *Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers*—there you will meet the other founder and his family, learn his way of life and be introduced to some of his helpers, like Sister Ignatia. Now don't stop there! Reach out for *The Language of the Heart*. Bill had a way with words and they come through on each page of the book, which is comprised of Grapevine articles he wrote through the years. *The A.A. Service Manual* is a wonderful work of spiritual directions and I encourage everyone to read it through and through.

Armed with all that history one cannot help but be in love with the Fellowship, and it becomes very clear that we are all charged with the responsibility of working together in the spirit of unity that is set forth in these books.

To quote from *The Language of the Heart* (p. 333): "Some of our more obvious perils will always attach to money, to controversies within A.A., and to the ever-present temptation to scramble within A.A. and outside it for distinction, prestige, and even power."

If we are not armed with the dedication of those that have gone before us, how can we possibly expect to protect the Fellowship with the unity that was passed on to us? The responsibility is truly ours. We cannot step back and let only those involved in the general service structure be responsible for carrying the message. Each of us as a member of this Fellowship must be willing to do some of the footwork required to be sure our message is delivered with the same dedicated spirit with which it was passed on to us. I say to you all—work the Steps, live by the Traditions, carry this message as it was passed to us. That is our responsibility. Let us all accept the torch and carry it as if our life depended on it—because it does.

Betty Piatt, New Mexico

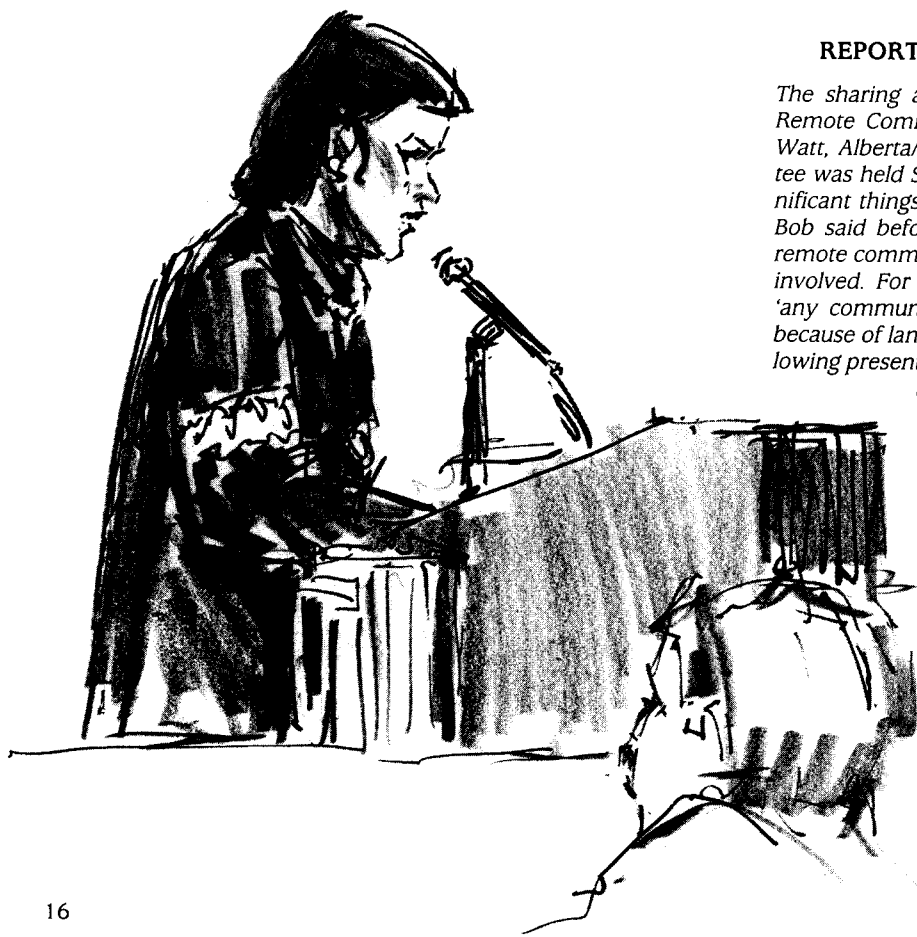
REPORT: REMOTE COMMUNITIES COMMITTEE

The sharing and question session following the report of the Remote Communities Service Committee was chaired by Bob Watt, Alberta/NWT. The second official meeting of the committee was held Sunday of Conference week. "One of the most significant things that we came up with at our inaugural meeting" Bob said before introducing the speaker, "was a definition of remote communities that would fit the varied needs of each area involved. For our purposes a remote community is defined as 'any community to which it is difficult to carry the message because of language, culture or geography.' After hearing the following presentation we should have a few minutes for discussion and sharing from the floor. I would now like to introduce you to my fellow committee chair, Robert Pelot, delegate—Area 90, NW Quebec."

Where We Were—Where We Are Now—Where We Are Going

I would ask a moment of silence to listen to the Serenity Prayer recited in Inuktitut. The intent is to place you in the proper mood for the presentation I have been asked to make pertaining to the project entitled Remote Communities Working Service Committee.

Where we were—In the fall of 1993, Noah, an Inuit from Salluit, Quebec, contacted Michel G., Panel 42 delegate, Area 90, Northwest Quebec and, after a long phone discussion, asked Michel



to send him confirmation of their conversation so he could read it at his business meeting. In the spring of 1994, Noah sent a thank you letter to Michel for his phone call and memo, which was brought to the General Service Conference by Fernand L.

At the beginning of April 1994, there were reports from Tom H. and Don S., past delegates, Eastern Ontario, regarding their contacts in the far North, such as an A.A. group in Pond Inlet, or contacts in Cape Dorset, Igloolik, etc. As a result of all this information coming together in one place it was decided at the 1994 General Service Conference to form a committee of five delegates. Information started circulating concerning this project, and during the Eastern Canada Regional Forum, in Thunder Bay, Ontario, September 1994, a special meeting was held attended by G.S.O. staff members, trustees and delegates. Area 90 assigned Marc-Andre G. as the delegates' representative in the North Western part of Quebec, and Marc-Andre made contacts with several people, A.A. and non-A.A., in the communities.

The Native people we were dealing with were identified as Inuit, Cree, Montagnais. On July 8, 1994 a meeting was held with the Amos Detention Centre Personnel, Marc-Andre G. Fernand L. and myself, to discuss where we were and where we were going.

A subsequent meeting was held on October 31, 1994 at the same centre, but this time a judge was present, along with a law enforcement representative, social workers, and the chairman of the Kativik Regional Administration and A.A. representatives from our area. This Northern Territory covers approximately 600,000 sq. km.

I can not begin to explain the interesting sharing that transpired between A.A. members and non-A.A. personnel—all speaking with the same spirituality. What could we do to help the still-suffering alcoholic living up here in the land of the Perma-Frost? When the judge stood to leave he looked at us and stated "I hope A.A. doesn't let us down this time."

It was obvious that we "southern" A.A. members were not about to go up there and transmit the A.A. message. We had to find some way to help some of these natives get sober, so that they in turn could open up A.A. groups in their communities. In July 1996, the committee met in Toronto to discuss once again where we were. The original committee of five members had increased to include the 14 Canadian delegates, as well as the delegate from Alaska, our Eastern and Western Canada trustees, the trustee-at-large/Canada, and Linda B. from the Bellwood Treatment Centre in Toronto, who had spent several years with the Inuit people. Two Inuit A.A. members were present and shared with us their A.A. experiences. Objectives were set. It was also decided that the interpretation of "Remote" would be extended to Natives living in communities other than the North, such as Algonquin and Mohawk. It was felt that this was necessary due to their culture, language and, in some cases, difficulties in mixing with the "white" members.

Where are we now—Since September 1996, Quebec Native inmates now serve their sentence in the St-Jerome Correctional Institution. Two other A.A.s, Robert M. and Peter M., and myself have been attending an English-speaking A.A. meeting in this institution since October 10, 1996. At this first meeting there were only three natives. The contact was not easy; the confidence was not there. Area 90 had some A.A. literature in the Inuktitut language which we gave them, and that sort of broke the ice. Since then, the Inuit members of the group have translated the Serenity Prayer, our Public Information poster, the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions.

There are two Inuits who translate A.A. literature, which is then reviewed by other Natives. The assignment of copyright forms have been signed by the translators to protect A.A.'s rights.

An Algonquin member from Lac Simon has translated the Slogans, Serenity Prayer, Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions and "Is A.A. for You?" into Algonquin. These translations are available through G.S.O.'s Literature desk.

A.A. literature on how to open a group is made available to the Natives prior to them leaving the centre. To date, Area 91, Saskatchewan, has obtained a Native story in Dene, Area 90 obtained a story in Inuktitut, and Area 89 in Montagnais. These audio cassettes are available through G.S.O.

Where are we going—In our part of the world, we have groups either functioning, or in the process of functioning, in Kuujuaq, Aupaluk, Kangirsuk, Quadtaq, Salluit, Ivujivik, Umiujaq, Kuujuarapik (Inuit), Chisasibi, Waskaganish, Nemisca (Cree) and other native communities further south. One of the suggested ways to share the A.A. message was to hold a Special Forum up North. A request was made and approved by G.S.O., and the date scheduled is August 22-23, 1997, in Val d'Or, Quebec, at the Confortel Hotel. Although all A.A. members are welcome, we are hoping to be able to share the A.A. services with Native A.A. members so they in turn can return to their communities and transmit the message.

The information received from G.S.O. is that we can now find A.A. in 146 different countries and 34 languages. In *A.A. Comes of Age*, (p. 85) Bill Wilson said "I shall forever remember that early bilingual provincial meeting where I first heard the Lord's Prayer in French." Well, we have come a long way in the last 50 years or so.

I think now we can add a few new languages to our count. The seed was planted some 20 years ago to share our A.A. message with our Native alcoholics, but I guess our Higher Power decided that we must be where we are at this time. I thank you for being there.

Robert Pelot, NW Quebec

REPORT: THE A.A. GRAPEVINE

Wednesday afternoon a report on the state of the Grapevine was presented by a general service trustee who is also a director on the Grapevine Corporate Board. A question and sharing session followed.

This presentation is about the Grapevine's situation with regard to its circulation—or lack thereof. I'm going to do it in broad strokes, just to give you an idea of the bind we on the board and staff feel that we are in when it comes to this issue.

I'm not going to beat you over the head with the historical significance the Grapevine has to our Fellowship. You know that it was in the Grapevine that the Preamble was first published. And that Bill used the Grapevine, after he had been invited off the board, to continue to communicate with the Fellowship, and that he published the Traditions first in our pages. You know, too, that we've been making a little history in our own time with the publication of *La Viña*, the Spanish edition of Grapevine.

A year ago we put a 20% increase in the subscription price into effect. Just prior to the increase we offered a number of discounts to existing subscribers to mitigate any immediate drop-off in circulation. We also instituted a new three-year subscription option which we hoped would give us additional stability through the later stages once the price increase began to kick in. We did this because of our experience with the last two price increases: i.e., there were substantial circulation drops in their wake. Magazine industry standards for this are as high as 15% drop-offs, but we were pretty sure we wouldn't have to face anything *nearly* that high.

And the strategy worked. At the beginning of 1996 we enjoyed quite a little growth spurt, so that going into the price increase in April we had an average circulation of 130,000—and for seven months, into the fall of '96—circulation held at that level. And then—as expected—at the beginning of 1997, we began to see the drop-off as subscriptions purchased at the old price came up for renewal. At this point we've got a subscription base of about 125,000—which is only about a 4% drop. (We have a very loyal readership, friends. We have a 65% renewal rate—which ain't bad.)

Now, at the same time, we are beginning to realize some of the increased income from the new subscriptions and active renewals at the higher price. So, even though our subscriptions have gone down, our income has actually gone up. So in terms of numbers, we are pretty sure that once we work our way through all the subscriptions purchased at the old price, we will, in fact, be in a positive financial position through the year 2000. That said, we still took a \$188,000 hit this year which we had to recoup from the Reserve Fund.

So that's where we are now. But there's more to us than a subscription base. I know I can safely speak for all the board members and staff here, that though we worry and struggle so over circulation and being self-supporting and so forth, that's not the bottom line; that's not our mission. Carrying the message is the bottom line. Carrying the message with live voices of members of A.A. talking directly to the reader about their sobriety, their experience, strength and hope. *That's* what the Grapevine is about. It is an open meeting welcoming anyone who cares to listen.

I want to read the Grapevine's Mission Statement. What we are and what we are not.

The A.A. Grapevine Mission Statement: The purpose of the Grapevine is to carry the A.A. message to as many people as possible, both inside and outside the A.A. Fellowship, through publication of a monthly journal and related items which reflect the experience, strength, and hope of individual A.A. members and friends of A.A. on topics related to recovery, unity, and service. Further, our purpose is to provide such service in a manner consistent with the Twelve Traditions and without soliciting monetary contributions from A.A. members or groups to fund operating expenses.

One other thing. The Grapevine Charter specifies that we will strive to be self-supporting. The Grapevine is not like A.A.W.S. in that we do not accept group contributions. Let me repeat that. The Grapevine is not able to accept group contributions. I'm making such a big deal out of this because it is at the crux of our problem. Our only, *only*, income is from subscriptions and from those items related to the magazine that we sell: *The Language of the Heart* and its Spanish edition, *El Lenguaje de Corazón*; audiotapes of Grapevine articles; the *Best of the Grapevine* anthologies; the little Preamble; the Slogans; the "Man on the Bed"; and so forth. I know that over the years numbers of people have taken issue with the related items—but I've always felt, and still do—that they are the magazine in another form, and that they carry the message exceptionally well in their own right.

The bottom line here is that if our subscription base rose to 150,000 we would be able to pay for ourselves. We would be self-supporting on an ongoing basis. And that is our goal. For its part, management has implemented a number of efforts to bring the subscriptions up, we've increased reader participation and involvement in the magazine. As I said earlier, we've developed an additional three-year subscription term and additional terms are still under consideration. Not every effort pays off; we

also tried to introduce consignment offers to central offices/intergroups, but had to give it up because of a lack of response. But we've had good success with our efforts at getting people to renew their already existing subscriptions.

Because we all feel so strongly about making some coherent, focused effort at achieving this eminently achievable goal of 150,000, we've made Tom McGuire the head of a new subcommittee, which is made up of GV directors Ray Stiver and Greg Tobin; they met just prior to the March planning committee meeting. Some of their thoughts are that the Grapevine Board needs to make its commitment to increasing circulation tangible by asking management to draw up a position description for a new job of Circulation director—a person whose sole responsibility would be to increase Grapevine circulation—for presentation to the trustees' Finance Committee in July.

So that's what we're up to. And management clearly has its work cut out for it. But we don't work in a vacuum. We are part of this larger whole of the Conference, and there are things that all of us need to do together.

This circulation problem has been with us for a long time. Over the years the Grapevine and the Conference have tried to solve it by placing the burden of increasing circulation on the delegates through many Conference Actions:

In 1959 state and area conferences were to urge GvRs to encourage subscriptions by individuals and groups, using materials prepared by the office.

In 1965 it was recommended that the Grapevine use the services of area committees in promoting (yes, friends, the word is "promoting" and it is in a Conference Action) the sale of the Grapevine at the group and individual level.

In 1969 it was recommended that all delegates consider it part of their responsibility to inform the Fellowship about the Grapevine as a tool of sobriety, either through their own efforts or by recruiting others.

In 1975 it was recommended that all delegates make A.A. members aware they could subscribe to the Grapevine as individuals.

In 1976 we recommended that A.A. groups or individuals send Grapevine subscriptions to local libraries.

In 1978, that P.I., C.P.C., Correctional and Treatment Facilities committees explore the use of the A.A. Grapevine in their endeavors.

It goes on:

1983: recommended that making the Grapevine available to outside agencies be left for area service structures to handle, in the spirit of autonomy.

1984: recommended that delegates explore the possibility of utilizing alternates throughout the service structure as Grapevine representatives.

1985: recommended that Grapevine committees seek ways to work with P.I., C.P.C., Correctional Facilities, Treatment Facilities and other service committees with the aim of increasing the use of the Grapevine as a tool in carrying the message.

You get the idea. This problem has been with us for a long, long time.

And those Conference Actions have not solved the problem. In fact, they put one in mind of that marvelous Al-Anon saying, "If it isn't working we do it harder."

I think we have a difficult, serious conceptual and philosophical glitch here in the way we have been thinking about the problem. In A.A. we do service to live. "The only way to keep it is to give it away." I certainly believe that, and I'm willing to bet the larger part of a year's salary that virtually everyone in this room believes that too. Putting out chairs, making coffee, chairing meetings, speaking, sponsoring, twelfth stepping, answering phones at

intergroup, volunteering to be a G.S.R. are all very clearly and easily understood as "service work." We do it to stay sober.

Then we come to "selling the Grapevine." Somehow it has a different cast. We talk about "boosting circulation" in a way that we don't talk about increasing the distribution of A.A. pamphlets. It's boggy territory right in here, and I think it's where we come a cropper. On the one hand, we want the service structure to take the lead in increasing the subscription base of the Grapevine; and, on the other, it's just not able to do that because the GvRs and the delegates are not a sales force. And, God knows, shouldn't be.

But it is the mission, spiritual as well as financial, of the magazine to make itself known to people who may find it useful, as well as to those of us who have miraculously made it into the safe harbor of A.A. So, how to do it?

This is what I propose for our discussion: Within the framework of the Traditions, and with the input of the Conference, that we be able to contact directly a whole universe of people who have not yet been exposed to the A.A. Grapevine, but who have a vested interest in recovery and the A.A. program. We would like to use the same resources that G.S.O. uses to introduce correctional facilities administrators, treatment facilities administrators, library personnel, etc. to the benefits of a subscription to the A.A. Grapevine. This would greatly enhance our ability to reach alcoholics who might be in need of the A.A. message, and would move us closer to fulfilling our mission of carrying the A.A. message to as many people as possible.

Jane Murphy Schulberg, Grapevine director

CARRYING A.A.'s MESSAGE AROUND THE WORLD

Thursday morning's presentation/discussion session was chaired by Jose (Junior) Gonzalez, Puerto Rico.

How The World Service Meeting Carries the Message

In the wake of his spiritual experience in Towns Hospital, Bill W. received true spiritual inspiration which he described in these words: "...the thought came that there were thousands of hopeless alcoholics who might be glad to have what had been so freely given me. Perhaps I could help some of them. They in turn might work with others." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 14) Later he wrote in the Big Book: "Some day we hope that every alcoholic who journeys will find a Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous at his destination." (*ibid*, p. 162) Earlier in the same chapter, he expressed the same hope: "Many, we are sure, will

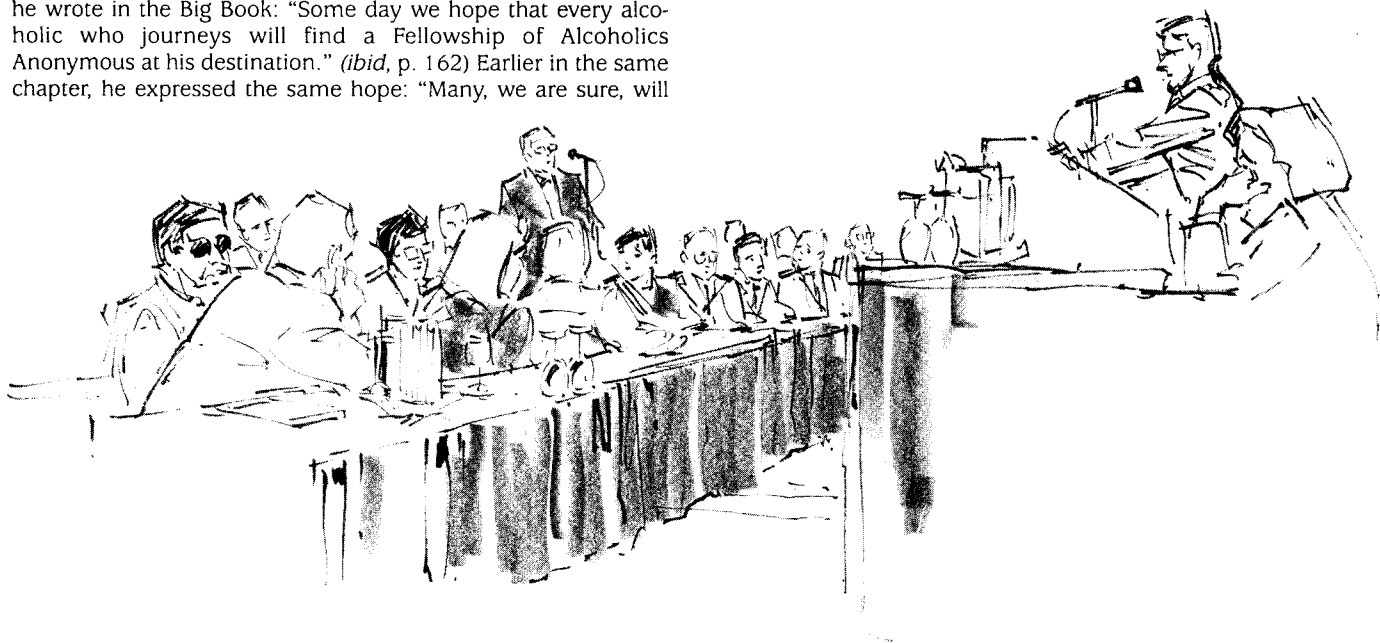
rise to their feet and march on. They will approach still other sick ones and fellowships of Alcoholics Anonymous may spring up in each city and hamlet, havens for those who must find a way out." (*ibid*, p. 153) Bill's words of hope already expressed personal experience and reflected spiritual inspiration that would lead to the World Service Meeting.

Basic to Bill's leadership were the qualities of experience, vision, and action. With his added tenacity and focus, Bill would continue to prompt us to new and more effective work. Just a few accomplishments were the Alcoholic Foundation and our first office; "Twelve Points to Assure A.A.'s Future;" the change in the ratio of Class A and Class B trustees; the General Service Conference; and the first World Service Meeting in New York City.

Bill knew the need for translations of our literature. He knew as well, that shared experience and increased understanding of our Traditions and Concepts could shape unity and the future for alcoholics in foreign lands. He saw strong parallels between the problems being experienced overseas and our own pioneering time. One of Bill's last and finest projects was the World Service Meeting. The plan was approved enthusiastically by the General Service Board and General Service Conference in 1968, and delegates from 16 countries attended the first World Service Meeting in 1969.

The first Conference Charter described "Sections" that might come into being in foreign countries. By 1967 Bill saw a different pattern developing in which countries formed their own autonomous service structures. Today, most service structures are more or less patterned after our U.S./Canada model, and all are autonomous. The World Service Meeting can provide a forum for sharing information and understanding on matters that may have far-reaching effects. There are 40 G.S.O.s outside the U.S./Canada, and the last World Service Meeting included representation of 42 delegates from 26 countries or zones.

Midge M., former G.S.O. staff member, described the first World Service Meeting by saying, "It isn't possible to adequately put into words the wonderful feeling of love and unity that existed between us all." I've searched for words to describe the essence of the two meetings I've attended—awe for the recovered lives in our respective lands; feelings of love, admiration, respect for the work of our Conferences and members; identification—finding once again that the problems others describe and their solutions are as our own. The heartfelt humor, the parting tears, the joy of reunion with returning second year dele-



gates—a spirit that our Higher Power provides. It is everlasting and deep. To serve as a delegate from our structure is the most tremendous A.A. privilege I can imagine.

Francisco Oliveira, delegate from Brazil, shed a new light on unity for me when he referred to Bill W. as “our co-founder.” Though each land’s conference and fellowship has its founders and leaders, each feels that Bill and Bob are their co-founders. There is deep gratitude to our office and our Conference for the concerted efforts made throughout the years to facilitate this sharing of experience and, especially, for the literature with its integrity and example.

Please read and absorb The World Service Meeting’s Final Report, so beautifully prepared through the arduous work of our International desk and Publications department. The effects of this report travel round the world, and the message is carried in this way. Our report is published in English, but painstakingly translated, in full or in part, in most of the countries represented. For instance, Japan translates the full report and has it available through J.S.O. The World Service Meeting Report will be read by Michaela and Pavol, two leaders of A.A. in Slovakia. Polish members will share in the experience, as will Finnish, Norwegian, and Uruguayan members. Vladamir Bogotov will share the wonder of his experience with the Russian board and conference. So it is for each delegate and country. Shared experience will impact our conscience just when and where it is needed. God will provide.

Most clear in my mind are memories of the workshop for which I was secretary. All the participants spoke in Spanish, and I took notes as I listened to the simultaneous translation in English. The topic was “What are Our Responsibilities Regarding the Fourth Tradition?” Members felt self-support, self-sacrifice, humility, and thoughtful consideration of others were principles embodied in our Fourth Tradition. Countries experienced many problems, such as splintering and separation; groups performing functions that are not a part of our A.A. work; large funds held back for conventions; entities operating outside the Fellowship and using the A.A. name. Problems were described, but there were no words of disrespect or antagonism expressed; all were looking for solutions. Continued efforts are being made for dia-

logue and solutions to problems, and in each case there is hope. One delegate summed up by saying, “The Fourth Tradition includes all Twelve Traditions and the spirit of sacrifice they require, which may most accurately be expressed as humility. The message is more important than the messenger.” These words and the feeling of common suffering and hope are indelibly etched in my mind.

I served on the Literature Committee during two World Service Meetings. The 1994 Literature Committee made this recommendation: “That A.A.W.S. continue to grant exclusive licenses to only one service structure in each country. Granting licenses to two entities in a single country could weaken A.A. unity in that country.” The recommendation was approved with complete unanimity. Copyrights were discussed in the 1996 Literature Committee meeting, with reflection on each country’s responsibility in maintaining the integrity of the A.A. message. Both years the committee shared extensively on literature needs in neighboring countries and the sponsorship and support of countries where A.A. is new and struggling.

The World Service Meeting carries the A.A. message to the alcoholic wherever in the world he/she may be, whatever language he/she speaks. Shared experience provides solutions, direction, inspiration and understanding, reaching every corner of the earth, from the tip of the Amazon road to the cold North of Russia, to meetings in rural Japan, Irish villages, the Andes, Scandinavia, the Slovak Republic and the hills of Uruguay. What hath God wrought! He brings it about through the hands of thousands who now know the joy of A.A. service. The World Service Meeting’s role will continue to increase as our Fellowship expands.

The fourteenth meeting’s theme of “Love and Gratitude in Action” permeated last October’s board weekend as delegates remained to enrich our committees, the sharing session, and corporate meetings.

As we contemplate our future we see the responsibility of Bill’s leadership falling upon the shoulders of each A.A. member. God, let Your grace continue in us; hold us in unity around Your world. Sustain us as our outstretched hands reach for those yet to come.

Larry Nelson, trustee-at-large/U.S.



A.A.'s Growth in Eastern Europe

Bill Wilson often spoke of A.A.'s beginnings, our "once upon a time." He told the tale to A.A. groups, to doctors and clergy, he told it at Conferences and Conventions, and at G.S.O.'s employees Christmas parties. And he told it, more formally, in *A.A. Comes of Age*. The story became so comforting and familiar that Bill affectionately dubbed it "The Bedtime Story." He told it often, but the Fellowship never tired of hearing it.

I suppose many of us might feel that the scope of the bedtime story widens each twenty-four hours, as one more drunk suspends disbelief and decides to give A.A. a try. By the time Bill died, in 1971, it was clear that A.A. could "transplant" and that cultures very different from ours could accept the A.A. message. But even then, the distance between Moscow and Akron, Ohio was far greater than the geography alone suggests. Because of the social and political climate in the USSR there was little A.A. to be found, yet A.A. was being introduced, gradually, over a number of years.

Poland was probably the first Eastern European country to see an A.A. group. In the early '70s, Maria Matuszewska, a psychologist specializing in alcoholism, wrote G.S.O. in New York for some information about Alcoholics Anonymous. She was put on the mailing list to receive our newsletter *Box 4-5-9* which she could not read but, as luck, or the Higher Power, would have it, she had a patient who could read some English. Maria gave her patient, Raymond, a job translating this newsletter. This job helped get Raymond sober and helped get A.A. started in Poland.

However, Maria was very clear that her own A.A. experience was an academic one, and she felt that some critical factor was missing. In 1996, she related an incident that forever altered her understanding of the A.A. way of life and would have great impact on the future of A.A. in Poland, where the professionals were in charge of the meetings: "There was a great stigma attached to alcoholism and my patients who attended our weekly abstinensky club meetings were very self-conscious. They were ashamed of being alcoholics and they did not want anyone to know or see them coming to the meeting.

"One night, a young man who was very drunk and had been trying to come to our meetings, showed up again. We did not want to let him into the meeting, because we did not want him to bring shame upon the group.

"We also had a special visitor that night, an A.A. member, Frank, from California who brought the Big Book, and I asked him to speak at our meeting. When Frank saw that we did not want the drunk to come into the meeting, he said that we should let him attend. When the meeting started Frank said to this drunk 'You sit next to me.' Frank read what I now know as the Preamble and the first thing he did was turn to this drunk, that no one wanted to have around, and he said to him 'Thank you for coming. You are the most important person in this room. You are the reason we are here.'"

And Maria exclaimed: "Then, I got it, then I could actually see it happening—the Twelfth Step! I realized then, that without Step Twelve, A.A. could remain an academic experience."

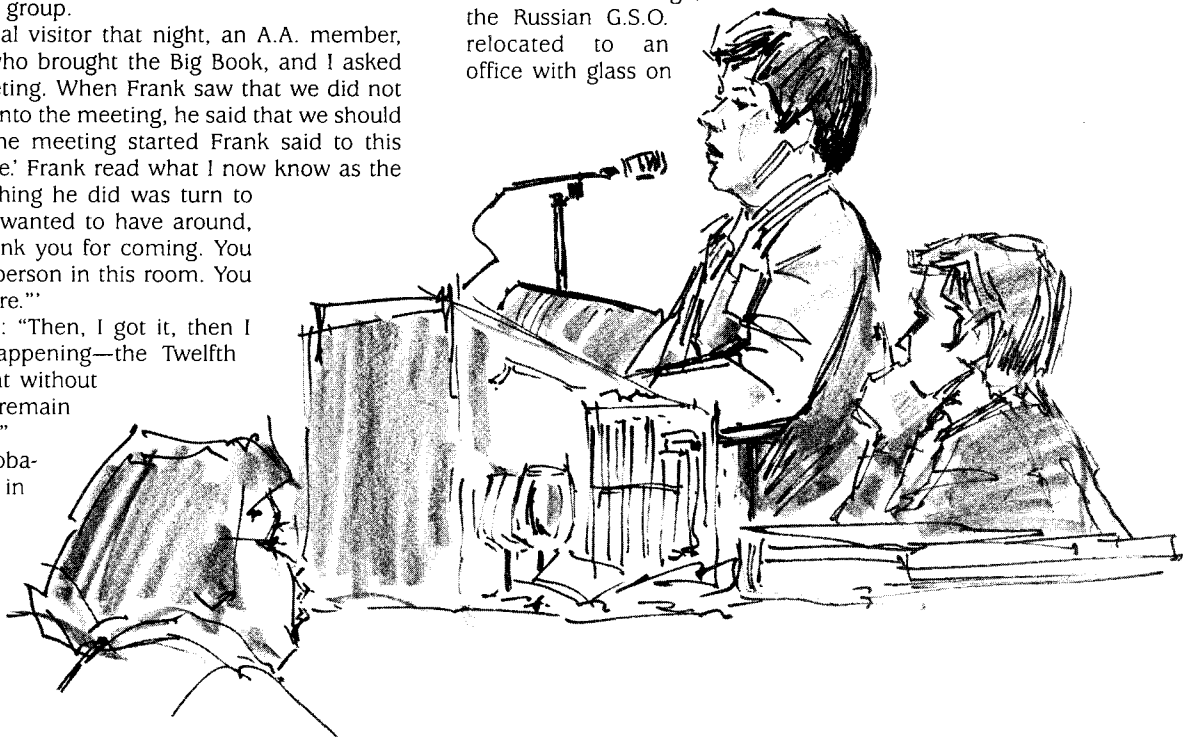
A.A. in Poland has probably grown faster than in any place on earth. The Poles started translating the literature right away with the help of a typewriter donated by A.A.s in

Belgium and with foreign literature assistance provided by U.S./Canada. What we, here, did not know was that they were operating illegally. They could have gone to jail for printing literature, but they were not to be stopped! Today, the Poles "sponsor" A.A. in Belarus and have invited individual A.A.s from other Eastern European countries to attend their annual Conference.

Meanwhile, back at the Kremlin. . . Finnish A.A.s, at great risk to themselves, were quietly taking literature into the Soviet Union for many years. In 1977, 50 of them took a bus to a Leningrad clinic to speak, only to be told when they arrived that the USSR had no alcoholism problem. With the change of the political situation A.A. found another way into Russia—through the visits of individuals from the United States traveling as part of a group named "Creating a Sober World." I can vividly recall the staff meeting at which we learned about this organization and their intention to bring A.A. into Russia and to translate the Big Book into that language. My own thoughts were that they best translate "It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell," because I thought that is where they would end up. I had no faith.

Two years later our A.A. World Services Board published the Big Book in Russian, and since 1989 another ten titles have been translated and continue to be distributed as gifts from A.A. members in the United States and Canada. One Russian member wrote to G.S.O. "the literature we have received is so dear to us as a new born baby." However, as many would predict, it was only a matter of time before the typical A.A. growing pains appeared and disagreements arose as to the best application of A.A. tradition. What came out of this, thanks to the open-minded Russians, and the help of visiting A.A.s from West Germany and from the US/Canada structure, was that the fledgling groups accepted some shared A.A. experience that, so far, has stood them in very good stead. Thanks to the "resentment and a samovar" syndrome, more groups were formed throughout this vast country. They learned it is possible to disagree without being disagreeable and their relationship with the medical community is becoming more effective. In a letter to Lois Fisher, G.S.O. staff member, Ivan from St. Petersburg requested some experience on doing better Twelfth Step work. And, he assured her that "our group finally has good problems—there is a chronic shortage of chairs at our Sunday meetings!"

A few months ago, the Russian G.S.O. relocated to an office with glass on



the windows and locks on the doors where the literature can, at last, be stored safely. We have sent what we believe to be our last large shipment of literature to their G.S.O. —they feel they are now ready to print it themselves.

A Czech named Stanislav was in the grip of an horrendous drinking problem when he was transferred to Toronto on business. His Canadian friends took him to some A.A. meetings but Stanislav did not take to A.A. After he returned home, sicker and more desperate, he contacted a boyhood friend, now living in California. He asked his friend, Vladamir, if he would know the name of the organization that helped alcoholics stop drinking. He remembered going to meetings in Canada but could not remember "Alcoholics Anonymous."

His friend responded, not only telling him our name but also sharing that he, Valdamir, had been an A.A. member for some years. Thus begins the story of A.A. in the Czech and Slovak Republics.

Following the "Velvet Revolution" in Czechoslovakia, many American A.A.s of Czech and Slovak origin visited the country, sought out alcoholics, physicians and clergy and were instrumental in translating our basic literature into the Czech and Slovak languages. However, in the absence of public information, telephones and intergroup offices, information about Alcoholics Anonymous spread mostly by word-of-mouth.

I hope you have all had the pleasure of meeting our Slovak observer, Michaela, this week. During a 1995 visit to the Slovak Republic, staff member John Grant and I were encouraging the A.A.s to write to G.S.O. and to read our literature. One member asked how U.S./Canadian members really felt about "supporting Slovakian A.A." When we explained that we were simply passing on what had been given to us, and that someday Slovakian A.A.s would be helping A.A.s elsewhere, the group seemed pleased. This past year, the Bratislava A.A. members covered some of the expenses of the Slovak Twelve and Twelve, which Michaela brought with her this week. And now an intergroup is forming in Prague.

Once upon a time in Budapest, a physician who had taken some alcoholism courses in California, gave A.A. literature to a patient who had been in treatment several times, unsuccessfully. Laszlo, told the following story: "I had been hospitalized many times, and I could not stop drinking. My wife was threatening to leave me so I went back to my doctor and I asked him to give me the "patch." [An implant, similar to Antabuse, which makes one physically ill should he or she drink.] Dr. Pal said to me, 'I could do that, Laszlo, but there is another way.' And, he reached into a desk drawer and placed a copy of the English Big Book on the desk."

Laszlo sobered up, visited A.A. groups in Austria and Germany, and returned home to form Hungary's first A.A. group in 1986. And, again, the help of A.A. visitors from the West

cannot be overestimated. A number of Hungarian-American A.A.s formed a translations committee and helped the Budapest members get an intergroup office started. Last year, an Hungarian member, writing on behalf of Budapest Intergroup, wrote to us on receiving his copy of the newly translated *As Bill Sees It*: "This is a great help for us, and I can only react with awe that I am reading in Hungarian the words of the man whom I can thank for my life. On behalf of all of us, and on behalf of A.A. in Hungary, I express our thanks with a grateful heart and friendly greetings."

Today, there is an A.A. presence in 146 countries and the stories cited here represent only the tip of the iceberg. Throughout Eastern Europe there are Dr. Bobs, Bills, Sister Ignatias and Dr. Silkworths with names like Rodica, Yuri, Witek, Romas and so many other individuals who are "on fire" with the A.A. message. Since 1989 we have sent great quantities of translations to these countries. This is wonderful and it is unlikely that A.A. could survive there without it. Yet, in working with the G.S.O. staff members on our Overseas desk and in being privileged to visit A.A. in Eastern Europe, it has become so clear to me that we can send tons of translations, but little happens until individuals start working with each other. As one alcoholism patient in rural Slovakia said to our trustee, Larry Nelson, "I have your book. But, I have no one to help me."

To be continued.

Vinnie McCarthy, Publications director, G.S.O.

THE HAT—WHERE MONEY AND SPIRITUALITY MIX

Friday afternoon's presentations on the Seventh Tradition were moderated by Ben Biegler, Washington State East delegate.

Seventh Tradition: Its Spiritual Significance to a Group

I reached the doors of A.A. after many years of shuttling through mental wards, hospitals, emergency rooms and finally a treatment center. When I got there, I was firmly convinced that the Fellowship was designed for folks who knew they could drink no more and simply spent a lot of time in meetings commiserating with each other and complaining about the unfairness of life. I readily placed a dollar in the basket when it was passed, knowing that it was a small amount to pay for an hour that was supposed to help me through the rest of that day without a drink. All the hospitals, doctors, medications and treatment expenses had certainly done nothing but get me to this place called A.A., where one dollar was obviously my contribution for a place to hold meetings.



Shortly after arriving at what was to become my home group, I was asked by one of the oldtimers if I would like to be involved with a coffee committee for an upcoming conference to be held at one of our larger hotels. Having nothing else to do, and just more than a little perplexed about a group our size hiring space at an expensive facility to hold a meeting, I agreed to take the coffee pot over to the hotel very early the morning the conference was to begin. I took it up to the room, along with the supplies, and was convinced more than ever that my group had really become more than a little grandiose. And if my dollar was being used for such a fancy environment to hold a meeting, then I was going to select another group that knew how to spend my money wisely. When the basket was passed in the meetings I attended, there certainly was not enough money to pay for this expensive hotel and have enough left over to pay the rent. I went down to the hotel desk and asked where my group was going to hold their meetings. The clerk informed me that my group had not booked meeting rooms for that weekend. However, the Sunflower Roundup was scheduled for meetings that would be starting at 2:00 p.m. in the ballroom down the hall from the main lobby. He told me it was set up, but no one had arrived yet and I was free to go in to see where the meetings were to be held. As I walked down the hall, I was really disturbed that my group, not more than 125 strong, had really committed to an expense it couldn't possibly handle and had even changed its name for these meetings.

When I opened the big double doors and stepped into the meeting room it was as if I had been struck by lightning. I stared into a huge expanse filled with row after row of chairs. A platform had been erected at one end with a podium at its center, and on each side large banners with the Steps and Traditions hung from the ceiling. A.A., in those few thunderstruck seconds, had grown beyond my wildest dreams. My perception of A.A. had been built within a "self-centered fog" that had envisioned A.A. groups as autonomous franchises where the "theys" of each group determined how income was to be acquired and ultimately spent. I suddenly realized that my group was not alone nor isolated in its program for recovery, that the decision to be a part of this gathering was rooted in the foundation of A.A., and for me to become well was to learn and become part of, not just my home group, but the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous. I came away from that room and the weekend with a new perception of A.A. and a new beginning for me.

Consequently, when I received the letter from Richard giving me the opportunity to share on the sacrifice of the Seventh Tradition and its spiritual significance to a group, I was eager to share what was revealed to me by my first experience of an A.A. committee. I was awakened to the world of A.A. by an invitation to participate in my group's contribution to a conference weekend. Not only did my group pay for our hospitality room that weekend but, as I was to discover later, the rent was also paid that month—all from our A.A. basket.

Passing the basket took on a different meaning. I decided to attend business meetings and discovered how the group spent its money, and was amazed to discover that we sent money to a place called Intergroup, the Kansas Area Assembly, and to G.S.O. We also had our own answering service. As the group grew over the months and our basket grew heavier, our contributions and other expenses also increased. Early on as treasurer I decided to use my power to order non-A.A. approved literature to fill our bookcases. Later, in my position as treasurer, our group conscience voted to spend our A.A. money on only A.A. Conference-approved literature. Power is not holding the A.A. checkbook, and I learned that as an alcoholic I must gratefully contribute to the basket, but only the group, through an informed group conscience, can allocate it properly.

Business meetings grew when the agenda concerned financial matters and decreased in attendance when less important matters were to be discussed. I was always amazed, during some rather heated discussions and disagreements, how following the Traditions and Concepts of A.A. brought our group together, even though the outcome did not necessarily satisfy us all. I was and am so fortunate to be surrounded by members of the Fellowship who are grounded in these principles and who freely share them when the need arises. Over many years and through countless business meetings, groups all over the world have dealt with the same problems my home group has faced. These problems dealing with the Seventh Tradition range from the source of our funds and how we spend it, to how much should be placed in reserve for emergencies. The Prudent Reserve is a never-ending topic for debate as to whether it should exist at all or how much is too much or too little. When broke, we deal with questions on raffles, dances, and donations. When the baskets are full, we ponder the propriety of donating books to institutions, libraries or giving seed money for a local conference, hoping for a generous return. Sometimes, in our eagerness to reach the still-suffering alcoholic, we can rationalize a questionable source of our income and be comfortable that the end justifies the means.

Being responsible for ourselves and planning for the future so that others will find the door of hope open for them—these are the things that feed the spirit and soul of the group. This makes it possible for the group conscience to reason and understand to the fullest our primary purpose without compromising our Seventh Tradition.

Carolyn Hammond, Kansas

Taking Financial Responsibility Beyond Our Home Group

I would like to begin by returning the focus for a moment to the subject of "The Hat—Where Money and Spirituality Mix." Though the subject which I have received is concerned with financial responsibility, I believe that whatever I will say in regards to financial responsibility is germane to our spiritual responsibility for the Twelfth Step. Most of what I have to say on most A.A. subjects has been formed on the anvil of experience in my home group, and this presentation should be no different. It was at the Wednesday night meeting of Sobriety and Beyond that I found out about my problem—me, and my solution—God. It was also there that I was to understand that Alcoholics Anonymous had accepted me, a thirty-year-old bed wetter, as a member. I discovered this when I was able to put my two dollars into the basket. It was not that they made me pay, but the group had stated that they "accepted no outside contributions, but relied on the voluntary contribution of its members." I belong to A.A., and for two bucks it belonged to me. It was the best two dollar investment I had or would ever make. It was a financial gesture, but a truly spiritual experience.

To paraphrase the Elizabethan poet John Donne, I believe that no group is an island, entire of itself; every group is a piece of the Fellowship, a part of the whole. The bridge which links us together is the Twelfth Step and the mortar of this bridge is our contribution to the Seventh Tradition. When this former bed wetter became their G.S.R., the members of my home group were an eclectic lot, from the single mom struggling to reeducate herself, to the presidents of home entertainment firms which catered to the alcoholic audiophiles throughout the city. We were able to grow from seven young members meeting around a table, to a group which had three meeting rooms going on simul-

taneously, with discussions about sobriety and oftentimes about the beyond. We were what Bill W. would have called, "a society of alcoholics in action."

We had a rocky start getting registered at intergroup and G.S.O., because we were, for the most part, young and familiar with other substances in addition to alcohol. We participated in the intergroup meetings to insure that we got into the meeting list, but had little interest in New York or General Services, which we considered "Corporate A.A." and, those involved, as the bureaucrats of sobriety. As G.S.R., I began to attend the district meetings; my eyes began to open and I began to change my opinion. But it took a more radical event to effect the change on the heart and soul of the group. In 1985 Montreal welcomed 50,000 recovering alcoholics to the 50th Anniversary of A.A. The members of my home group and their twisted servant were transformed. From the moment we worked as hosts and hostesses, with those goofy and unhip straw hats, through the flag ceremony, to the closing ceremony, where the silence of 40,000 testified to the fact that A.A. was a great deal more than our Wednesday night discussion, we were touched by the power and the glory of A.A.

This experience catapulted us into action. We had been transformed by the fellowship of the spirit. The members of the group began to get involved in public information and we began to give regular contributions to both intergroup and the General Service Office. Before long the group and its members had started correctional facilities meetings in two youth detention centers. The group grew and the vibrancy of its membership testified to the fact that we were indeed no longer apart from, but a vital part of Alcoholics Anonymous.

The group members had taken their Twelfth Step responsibility beyond the group level. We did this through our physical involvement in the district and area committees. More interestingly, we did this through our financial contributions to the district, the area and beyond. Accordingly, we also became much more interested in what was going on at the district, the area and beyond. We had developed a proprietary attitude and interest in the doings of the Fellowship and were not going to let anyone break the lifeline to the still-suffering alcoholic. How far this lifeline would be extended depended upon us as group members and our financial, physical and spiritual involvement outside the confines of our home group.

In 1989 just how far this lifeline of recovery could go was brought home to the group by the story of the visit of trustees of the General Service Board to Russia. The *Conference Final Report*, which we were getting because our G.S.R. attended the delegate's report, contained an account of this visit and Class B trustee Webb Johnson's immortal words, "...Alcoholics Anonymous was a fact in Russia, and you can't unring a bell." (1989 *Conference Final Report*, p. 29) We were ecstatic. We had had a hand on the rope that rang that bell. We were regular Quasimodos of Sobriety. This was possible because we were joined to the whole through our spirit and our dollars.

As a delegate, I have been privileged to see firsthand the effects and

the process of the ever growing hand of A.A. At the Conference and throughout the year, I am in contact with G.S.O. and the other members of the Conference and I am constantly refreshed and reaffirmed by the great work that is being done in our name around the world. It is my job to pass on not just the information but the dynamism of this work.

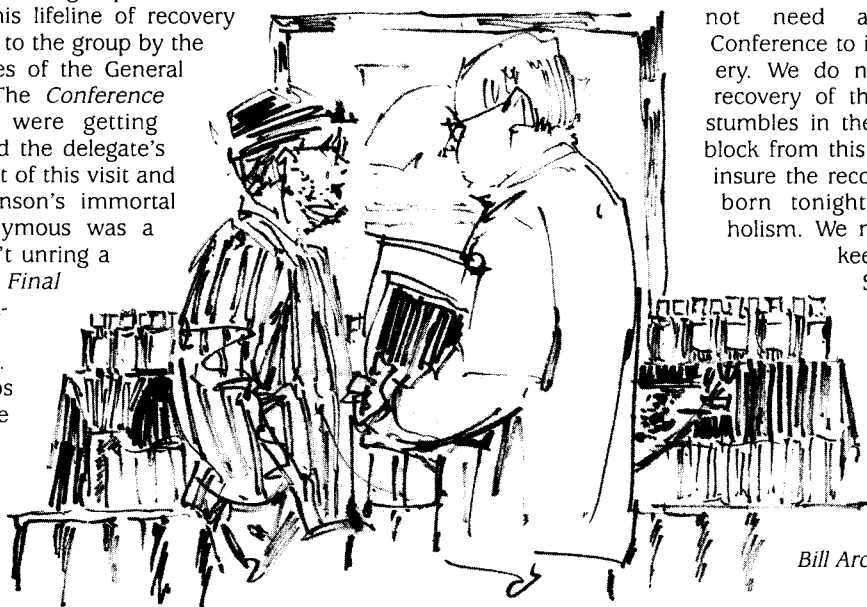
I am a member of the Remote Communities Committee, which is made up of members from concerned areas who have formed a working committee to try to improve the transmission to communities, who by virtue of location, culture or language, are not receiving A.A.'s life-saving message. The aboriginal communities of the far north fit all of the above criteria and are particularly affected by our fatal malady. Our committee is in the process of gathering translations of basic A.A. literature in Native languages. I have spent every second Wednesday night since January bringing a Step meeting into a half-way house for aboriginal offenders. I brought with me the translations which had been distributed through the staff member responsible for Native Americans at G.S.O. I gave out the Twelve Steps and Traditions in Inuktituk to the Inuit men present and something happened. They devoured the photocopied sheets and in their eyes a light shone that had not been there before. It was the light of hope that the message of Alcoholics Anonymous brings. I will not pretend that we have found the answer to carrying the message by simply translating the words. We have to translate the actions of Alcoholics Anonymous, and to do this we need all the help we can get. It is not solely the responsibility of the New Dawn Group in Iqaluit, Northwest Territories to do this. It is the responsibility of all our groups, whether in Prince George, Palm Springs or Peoria. They can fulfill this responsibility by taking their financial responsibility beyond their home group.

The Conference structure is the vehicle for the myriad of groups throughout our nations to take ahold of the rope of the bell. It is here that we come together to renew and reaffirm our Fellowship's commitment to carrying the message. This work gets done not just here in this lovely hotel, but in the trenches of the A.A. groups. These trenches and the members' contributions are the lifeblood of the Conference. It only gets here when the groups get outside themselves.

I would like to end with Bernard Smith's most eloquent statement on the Conference: "We may not need a General Service Conference to insure our own recovery. We do need it to insure the recovery of the alcoholic who still stumbles in the darkness one short block from this room. We need it to insure the recovery of a child being born tonight, destined to alcoholism. We need it to provide, in keeping with our Twelfth

Step, a permanent haven for all alcoholics who, in the ages ahead, can find in A.A. that rebirth which brought us back to life." (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. S42)

Bill Archer, SW Quebec



Reports from the General Service Board, Trustees' Committees and G.S.O.

These annual reports are submitted to each Conference—via its committees in cases where there are counterparts to the board entities; directly, where there are no counterparts. Unless the Conference as a whole takes some action to the contrary, acceptance of the reports indicates Conference approval of the activities and recommendations included.

GENERAL SERVICE BOARD

Trustees' report: I am happy to report a busy and most productive year for the General Service Board and its committees. In June of 1996, La Viña, A.A.'s new magazine in Spanish, came off the press with an initial circulation of nearly 11,000, which were distributed to subscribers in the U.S. and Canada, Mexico, Central and South America, and Europe. Many subscriptions have been received from correctional and treatment facilities committees, and the magazine has been well received throughout the service structure. So far five issues have been published and, like its English counterpart, the Grapevine, La Viña has already received an international presence, with subscribers in 28 countries. Mexico, Spain, Ecuador, El Salvador, Brazil, Argentina, Colombia, Costa Rica, Venezuela, and Canada lead the list in terms of numbers of copies ordered, but there are even a few subscriptions from Israel, Italy, Sweden, and Poland.

In Spanish "La Viña" means "the vineyard"—a place where caring, cooperation, and hard work result in healthy growth—and it is our hope that this "vineyard" of A.A. experience and sharing will continue to grow and prosper for many years to come.

In July, a Site Review Committee was appointed to complete an initial review of the current site of the General Service Office and report on its suitability, any recommendations for change or improvement, and any other options the committee might wish to present to the trustees for further consideration. In November, the Site Review Committee chairperson reported that the committee had conducted a full review of all previous site selection studies, comparative historical financial data concerning G.S.O. site costs, and current lease cost information. Additionally, the committee conducted an extensive tour of the current offices and met with both the general manager of the General Service Office and the executive editor of the Grapevine to hear their views on the suitability of the current site.

The 14th World Service Meeting was held in New York City, October 27-31, 1996. The participation of Grapevine staff at this particular World Service Meeting was a first and we hope the practice continues. The board hosted 42 W.S.M. delegates from countries around the world at our own General Service Board weekend, November 1-3, 1996, which followed the conclusion of the World Service Meeting. We appreciated the World Service Meeting delegates participation in trustees' committee meetings. The eight days of world-

wide sharing was a spiritual experience that will always be remembered.

As there is in the United States and Canada, there is still much work to do in carrying the A.A. message internationally. In the past year, visits by trustees, staff and the general manager have been made to Australia, Costa Rica, Cuba, Dominican Republic, Germany, Hungary, Ireland, Mexico, Nicaragua, New Zealand, Slovakia and Thailand. Many of our books and pamphlets have been translated into several languages and the Big Book is now published in 34 languages.

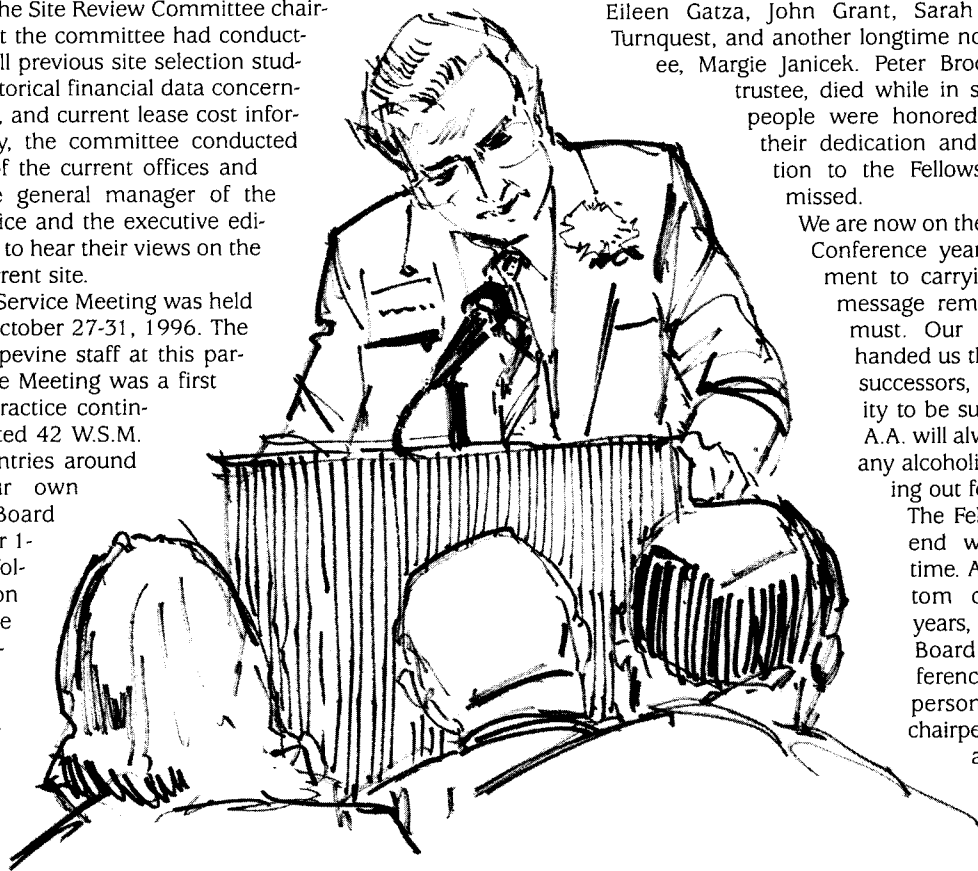
In November, the board received a report from the Ad Hoc Web Site Committee and their recommendations were approved by the board and forwarded to the Conference. The following were the recommendations approved by the board, that:

- all future additions to the A.A. Web Site be available in English, French and Spanish;
- the content of the A.A. Web Site be limited to information for the general public, and consideration of adding A.A. service material and service information and Grapevine information to the A.A. Web Site be deferred until there is sufficient time to gather "collected experience" from the Fellowship, service committees and the A.A.W.S. and Grapevine Boards;
- the A.A.W.S. Board be responsible for determining future content of the A.A. Web Site, with the General Service Office being responsible for A.A. Web Site operational functions;
- the A.A. Web Site link to the A.A. Grapevine Web Site when one is created;
- this report be presented to the 1997 General Service Conference for disapproval if any;
- through their opportunity to review this report, the General Service Conference is also made aware of the editorial changes included in the A.A. Fact File as it appears on the A.A. Web Site.

In 1996, we bid farewell to four longtime staff members, Eileen Gatz, John Grant, Sarah Price and Helen Turnquest, and another longtime nonalcoholic employee, Margie Janicek. Peter Brock, general service trustee, died while in service. These good people were honored by the board for their dedication and valuable contribution to the Fellowship. They will be missed.

We are now on the threshold of a new Conference year and our commitment to carrying A.A.'s lifesaving message remains resolute, as it must. Our predecessors have handed us this gift and, as their successors, it is our responsibility to be sure that the hand of A.A. will always be extended to any alcoholic, anywhere, reaching out for help.

The February board weekend was a very upbeat time. As has been the custom over the last few years, the General Service Board invited the Conference Committee chairpersons to attend. All chairpersons were encouraged to attend their corresponding trustees' committees, as



well as other trustees' committee meetings, including the whole meeting of the board. This practice, we feel, helps our Conference run in a smoother fashion due to better communication between staff, trustees, directors and delegates.

During my recent trip to Cuba, with Danny Mooney, Raul Marin and board members from Mexico, the need for Alcoholics Anonymous in all countries became more clearly apparent. While there I attended the first-ever A.A. meeting in a small Cuban village, which was another spiritual high for me.

Rotation will occur in April and I, too, will rotate from the position of your chairman. It's time to rotate because I'm beginning to think I know what I'm doing and am enjoying being your chairman. It has been a mountaintop experience and I thank you for this opportunity to serve. The greatest compliment paid me has been the mutual trust we have shared.

W.J. (Jim) Estelle, Jr., chairperson

A.A. WORLD SERVICES, INC.

Directors' report: Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. (A.A.W.S.) is a wholly-owned subsidiary of the General Service Board. It has the delegated responsibility to maintain oversight of the General Service Office (G.S.O.) which provides group services, including printing, distribution of Conference-approved and other service literature. The board met nine times since the last Conference to hear G.S.O. management and staff reports; review group services activity and progress on compliance with Conference and board recommendations; review budgets, expenditures, and salary policy; establish prices for literature and other materials; discuss publishing operations and matters of G.S.O. administration; consider requests from A.A.s and non-A.A.s for permission to reprint A.A. copyrighted literature; and address other matters as they arise.

There are nine A.A.W.S. directors; currently, five are trustees, including three regional or at-large trustees; two are nontrustee directors; one is the G.S.O. general manager; and one is the staff coordinator. Also attending board meetings, but not voting, are the services director, G.S.O. staff members, the controller, publications director, information services manager, human resources director, the board secretary, and a Grapevine staff member. The board has welcomed guests, trustees, appointed members of trustees' committees, delegates and other A.A. members to its meetings during the year.

The committees of the A.A.W.S. Board are: Services, which addresses the needs of all service assignments; Finance and Administration, which concerns salary and budget, audit review, and retirement; Publishing, which addresses reprints, foreign literature and publications concerns; and Nominating. Long-range planning is done within each committee and by the board as a whole. During the past year, the following significant items are noted:

Services: During 1996, 2,499 new groups were registered, compared to 2,695 in 1995. The board continued to evaluate ways to convey the message of self-support to the Fellowship. The most practical manner to accomplish this objective appeared to be through development of a service piece directed at group treasurers. A final draft document will be presented to A.A.W.S. for review during the spring of 1997.

A sample video to encourage A.A. members to participate in carrying the message behind the walls was completed and ready for consideration by the trustees' and Conference Correctional Facilities Committees. Distribution of the quarterly, *Sharing From Behind the Walls*, to inmates in correctional facilities began with the Summer 1996 issue. Feedback from both inmates and "outside" A.A. members has been very positive.

The total cost of foreign literature assistance in 1996 was \$136,800, against a budget of \$146,500. Projects included: Armenian *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, Bulgarian Big Book, Romanian Big Book, Czech "A Newcomer Asks," Slovak *Living Sober*, Croatian Group Guidelines, and Amharic (Ethiopian) pamphlets. During 1996, over \$27,700 in contributions from eight countries and several miscellaneous donations were received toward the International Literature Fund. The board approved a request from the General Service Board of Poland for a \$10,000 advance to print 5,000 copies of the softcover Big Book in Polish. (The Polish board anticipates repaying this amount.) The new G.S.O. in Lisbon, Portugal recently sent the final payment on an advance which had allowed them to publish the (European) Portuguese version of the Big Book.

The A.A.W.S. Board's Services Committee was asked to take over responsibility for G.S.O.'s Web Site from the trustees' Ad Hoc Web Site Committee. The committee recommended—and the board approved—that information on central/intergroup offices and answering services in the U.S./Canada should be included on G.S.O.'s Web Page. Guidelines will be prepared for use by central/intergroup offices on planning their Web Sites and how G.S.O. will relate to them electronically.

Regarding the possibility of implementing a generic e-mail address for G.S.O., the board determined that this should not be instituted at this time. The subject will, however, be revisited regularly. (The use of e-mail has been especially helpful in overseas situations where we are now able to reach people who are normally very difficult to reach by phone. All G.S.O. staff and management have e-mail addresses.) The board recognized that, with the growth in the use of electronic communication, it is important that G.S.O. implement a strategy to permit a step-by-step expansion in electronic communication. To move this process forward, a "pilot project" was approved requesting that G.S.O. take the following steps: a) With the guidance of G.S.O.'s Information Services manager, implement the interactive response vehicle for C.P.C. in the letter for professionals; b) Over the next few months, develop a plan for the A.A.W.S. Board's review that would lead to the next steps to make it more and more possible to carry the message and to communicate inside and outside the Fellowship electronically.

A.A.W.S. directors and G.S.O. staff participated in the following Regional Forums since the last Conference: Pacific, in Salt Lake City, Utah, June 28-30 (357 attendees); Eastern Canada (Bilingual), in Sherbrooke, Quebec, September 6-8 (519 attendees); and Southeast, in Asheville, North Carolina, December 6-8 (617 attendees).

The 11th Annual Intergroup/Central Office/A.A.W.S. Seminar was held in Minneapolis, Minnesota, November 8-11, with representation from about 90 central/intergroup offices around the U.S. and Canada. A total of 132 managers, delegates, intergroup committee chairs, etc. were in attendance.

A very enlightening and helpful Remote Communities weekend meeting was held in Toronto, Ontario, July 19-21, attended by all Canadian delegates and the Alaskan delegate, all Canadian trustees, Pat Rosenstiel, George Dorsey, as well as two A.A. members from the Arctic Native American community.

International: The World Service Meeting took place, October 27-31, in New York City, and was attended by 42 delegates, representing 26 countries or zones. The net expense/loss of this meeting came to \$23,700, or 15.3 % of total cost. This compared with net expense of \$35,200 in 1994, and \$35,300 in 1992.

Hans Prussky, manager of G.S.O. Germany, and his assistant Maxi Kowalczyk, visited the G.S.O. in New York, June 22-26. The benefits of this visit cannot be overestimated in terms of mutual sharing and coordinating matters related to our mutual efforts

to assist A.A.s in countries in Eastern Europe and the former Soviet Union. In August, Jim Keeney, manager of Great Britain's G.S.O., visited G.S.O. with sharing of mutual experience with staff as well as with the publishing, data processing, and finance departments. Hannu Saarilahti, Finland's G.S.O. manager and second term World Service Meeting delegate, visited the office for two days prior to the start of that Meeting in New York City.

General Service Board chairperson, Jim Estelle; Raul Marin, Southwest regional trustee; and Danny Mooney, G.S.O. staff member on the Spanish Services assignment, traveled to Cuba, January 18-25.

August 30-September 2, Raul Marin and Danny Mooney attended the 24th Anniversary Conference in Santiago, Dominican Republic, and later in September, Jim Estelle and Danny Mooney attended a C.P.C. International Forum, Central Mexicana, Mexico City. The 26th Anniversary of A.A. in Monterrey, Mexico, June 14-16, was attended by Jim Estelle, Raul Marin and Danny Mooney.

Publications director Vinnie McCarthy visited Poland, March 17-20, in order to advise the Polish General Service Board about status of copyrights, licensing agreements, printing, distribution and discounts. (As a matter of information, Poland has been helping to sponsor the former Soviet Republic of Belarus.) General manager George Dorsey traveled to Poland, August 25-September 2, in order to attend the Sixth National Congress and Service Conference in Warsaw. George reported on the remarkable growth of A.A. in Poland, from a handful of groups 12-15 years ago to over 1,100 groups with 25,000 members at present. At the meeting, Poland adopted a formal "Conference Charter." G.S.O. received an exciting report from Romania on that country's Second A.A. National Convention.

Michaela Klimanova Triulakova, of Bratislava, visited G.S.O. and brought news of the progress of A.A. in Slovakia. John N. Chappel, M.D., Class A trustee; and Larry Nelson, trustee-at-large/U.S., visited Slovakia during October, met with treatment professionals and attended a psychiatric congress, where Dr. Chappel was the featured speaker. We also received news that the first A.A. service office in Slovakia has opened in Nave and is serving A.A. members and groups. A.A.s in Ukraine shared that they have moved forward to establish a structure, the Ukrainian Council, which is expected to evolve into a General Service Conference. Ukraine's A.A. Service Center has been modeled after that of G.S.O. U.S./Canada.

Preparations for the 2000 International Convention to be held in Minneapolis, Minnesota, are on target. Site-selection trips, in preparation for the 2005 International, were made to St. Louis, San Antonio, Atlanta and Toronto. The announcement of the selection of Toronto as the site for the 2005 International Convention appeared in the Holiday Issue of *Box* 4-5-9. By the end of January 1997, 9,000-10,000 hotel rooms were committed to this Convention.

Finance: The board received, approved and forwarded to the General Service Board, mid-year 1996 budget adjustments totaling \$168,000. This included Conference Advisory Actions from the Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities of \$20,000 for a film and \$6,000 for a newsletter. The balance of the adjustment, \$142,000, covered the cost of early retirement severance benefits. After recording these amounts, the budgeted loss for 1996 was \$1,417,160. In accordance with its 1996 Budget, the board removed the 5% across-the-board discount and reduced, from 30% to 20%, the discount on selected items. These changes took effect August 12, 1996, thus bringing A.A.W.S. back to the same position where it was in September 1994 regarding discounts.

A brief summary of the financial results for 1996 is as follows: Sales were approximately 4% under budget, contributions

approximately 5% over budget, total expenses approximately on budget (.6% under), and net loss for the year was \$1,264,175. This loss compares with a budget that—after midyear adjustments—called for a \$1,147,400 loss and was \$153,000 less than anticipated.

Through its Finance and Administration Committee, the board prepared, reviewed and recommended the 1997 G.S.O. budget to the trustees' Finance Committee. This budget provided for increases of \$1.00 on most of A.A.'s large-selling books, \$1.50 on the high-quality hard cover Bill and Dr. Bob biographies, and 75¢ on booklets, as well as adjustments in Spanish literature prices, to be effective in May 1997. It was noted by the board that this was the first price increase since 1991 and there have been actual price decreases in recent years.

The board greeted with satisfaction and gratitude the news that contributions finished the year 1996 at approximately \$248,000, 6.76% better than in 1995, and \$176,000, or 4.7%, better than budgeted.

Publishing: We published the following items: Soft-cover edition of *As Bill Sees It*; Braille edition of *Daily Reflections*; Spanish pocket *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*; video of *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* in American Sign Language; and the archival "Scrapbook (1943)."

We also published six translations: Bulgarian Big Book; Czech "A Newcomer Asks"; Hungarian *As Bill Sees It*; Lithuanian *Came to Believe*; and Slovak *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*.

During 1996, the board granted permission/did not object to 209 requests to reprint from A.A. literature. During the same period, 37 requests were denied.

A.A.W.S. received a total of 17 requests for new formats of existing publications during late 1996 and early 1997. An evaluation form (matrix) was presented at the March 1997 meeting and will be modified to help determine the need and feasibility of these requests in order to evaluate and prioritize action on them. Production of an audiotope album of *Living Sober* was approved.

By mid-April 1997, a new English catalog, with revised prices, will be available, along with a separate catalog for special needs. In connection with the new prices of Spanish language literature, we have produced a new Spanish catalog with a fourcolor cover.

Nominating: After receiving resignations—due to illness—from both Peter Brock, general service trustee, and Jacques Filteau, nontrustee director, the board voted to select Michel Girard, trustee-at-large/Canada, and Arthur L. Knight, Jr., Class A trustee, to serve as interim directors for one year, beginning in May 1996. Michel Girard was subsequently selected to serve an additional year as interim director, beginning in May 1997. (The board received word that Peter Brock passed away peacefully on August 2, 1996.)

Susan Ulseth was elected as a director in September 1996, to complete the remainder of the term of John Grant, to expire at staff rotation in September 1997.

In order to maintain a valued system of "staggered terms" for general service trustees on the A.A.W.S. Board, the board requested that the General Service Board operate short one general service trustee for an additional year, from April 1997 to April 1998. Therefore, one general service trustee and two non-trustee directors were selected to serve on the A.A.W.S. Board, beginning in May 1997, as follows: Richard Roughton was selected to serve as a general service trustee, replacing Michael McPherson. After interviewing seven highly-qualified applicants, Jacqueline J. Johnston and John C. Koster were selected to serve as nontrustee directors, following the 1997 Conference, replacing Jacques Filteau and Richard Roughton. All of the above recommendations were forwarded to the trustees' Nominating Committee.

Other Board Actions: On May 23, 1996, the board, acting as a "committee of the whole," elected its officers to terms expiring at the end of the April 1997 Conference. Beginning in May 1996, MaryJane Roy replaced rotating regional trustee director Gay Garner. The board requested that the trustees' Nominating Committee approve Garry McAuley to replace Julian Rhinehart as a regional trustee director, following the 1997 Conference.

At year-end 1996, G.S.O. had 82 full-time employees, down from 103 at year-end 1991, a reduction of 20.4%. The board welcomed new G.S.O. staff members: Doug Richardson (Correctional Facilities), replacing Sarah Price; Eva Sanchez (C.P.C.), replacing Eileen Gatzka; and Adrienne Brown (Treatment Facilities/Loners), replacing Susan Ulseth who moved over to the staff coordinator position replacing John Grant for the balance of this rotation.

The early retirement "window" offer to eligible employees, originally effective March 31 through September 30, 1996, was extended by the board through September 30, 1997.

By the end of December 1996, G.S.O. had welcomed 1,361 visitors for the year.

The board was given a demonstration of the new release of the Delegate Area Database. Approximately 82 areas are now receiving their data via diskette, and—of these—half are returning their changes on diskette.

The board heard a report regarding the phenomenon which will occur throughout the information industry in the year 2000 because computer programs, historically, have used dates whereby the year was represented by only two digits, e.g., "95" rather than "1995." Therefore, arithmetic operations, computations, comparisons, sorting, etc. will yield incorrect results when working with years outside the range of 1900-1999. Since G.S.O. deals mostly in legacy (existing) applications, our problem extends across all applications except for Group Records and Grapevine subscriptions, which are new modules. The planning and methodology necessary to effect the change from two to four digit years is considerable, and the magnitude of the project enormous. An estimate of \$35,000 was given for the lease of additional hardware and software, to which must be added hours/salary—for a minimum of 1,000 hours. The modifications should be well underway by the end of 1997.

Julian Rhinehart, chairperson

ARCHIVES

Trustees' committee: Our committee met four times since last year's Conference; one of these meetings was held at the General Service Office Archives, to provide a hands-on experience for committee members.



The committee approved the preparation and production of a Second Archival Scrapbook covering the year 1943. A draft of the proposed Archival Guidelines was reviewed by the committee, and also circulated among the area archivists and archives chairpersons for their input. Currently we have 93 persons on our mailing list, and continue to ask the delegates to send us updates to keep our list current.

Preparations for a reproduction of "Markings on the Journey" are on the way. The original item was created in 1979 in a film-strip format, and it has lost some of its cohesion in the change. Additionally, the sound track seems to have deteriorated; in some sections it is virtually inaudible. The narrative and the visual could be updated to reflect the current office location and present personnel. A budget has been approved by the General Service Board for these expenses.

William Bungay, chairperson

Archivist's report: Since our report to last year's Conference much activity has occurred within our A.A. archival community. During the summer a small band of hot historians ventured for a second time to video the first home of Works Publishing, 17 William St., Newark, N.J., and Bill's commute to it from his home at 182 Clinton St. in Brooklyn Heights. The restored downtown Newark Post Office, now a Historical Registry site, was one of the highlights of the tour. It was to a box in this building, where the pitifully few replies were received in response to a mailing offering the newly-published Big Book to physicians.

Interest in our Prepublication Manuscript of the Big Book continues to be high. After an article on the availability of this historical document appeared in the A.A. Grapevine, we've been inundated with nearly 500 requests. In a related endeavor, two of our members, working independently, have produced computer discs of the textual alterations between this manuscript and the first edition.

In response to a mailing to all area delegates, we've been able to update partially our listing of area archivists. Sadly, our previous listing had been lost in our computer department redesign. We'd appreciate any additions or corrections to this list.

Finally, maybe someone can help us locate the source of this alleged quote by Bill W.: "A.A. is not a success story; rather it is a chronicle of our colossal human failure turned to usefulness by the divine alchemy of a loving God."

Frank Mauser

CONFERENCE

Trustees' committee: The committee met three times since the 1996 Conference. We reviewed the 1996 Advisory Actions pertaining to the General Service Conference, and approved the theme for the 47th General Service Conference, "Spirituality—Our Foundation." We also reviewed the Conference Evaluation Questionnaires and noted there were several suggestions to cut down on the length and number of presentations, to shorten board reports and even to shorten the Conference. An Agenda Planning Subcommittee was appointed to study these further and to bring suggestions for the 1997 Conference back to the committee. In October, the committee heard and unanimously accepted the report of the Agenda Planning Subcommittee, which included a recommendation to formally open the Conference on Monday morning. The committee also reviewed a draft of the preliminary Conference agenda and, in reviewing the proposed 1997 Conference budget, noted the substantial savings that had been realized last year in the publication of the *Conference Final Report* and the *Box 4-5-9 Early Bird Edition*.

In January, we forwarded a revised Conference Evaluation form; reviewed a draft of the final Conference agenda; discussed and disposed of unassigned agenda requests, and delayed until July discussion on a request for guidelines for observers attending the Conference and a report on the future growth of the Conference. The committee also asked the Conference coordinator to find two whisper translators to respond to requests for translation from two Quebec delegates and approved an invitation for an observer from Slovakia to attend this year's Conference, subject to Conference approval.

Michael McPherson, chairperson

Staff report: The Conference coordinator is the contact for Conference members. The General Service Conference is a year-long process and the Conference coordinator corresponds regularly with delegates and alternate delegates in a cooperative effort to make the annual Conference responsive to the needs of the Fellowship. The coordinator's desk also is the contact for area and district committee members and past delegates of the 92 areas throughout the U.S. and Canada.

All A.A. members are asked, through the area committees, to submit items for the Conference to address. These may be brought to

the appropriate trustees' committee for consideration and referral to a Conference committee. The Conference coordinator assumes responsibility for:

- Assembling suggestions for the Conference theme, presentation/discussion and workshop topics, which are then reviewed for selection by the Conference Agenda Committee and recommended to the trustees' Committee on the Conference for approval.
- Serving as secretary for both the Conference Agenda Committee and the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.
- Working with the general manager and G.S.O. staff in planning and coordinating each phase of the Conference.
- Scheduling and assembling reports and all material for the Conference Manual, Early Bird edition of *Box 4-5-9* and the *Conference Final Report*.
- Reviewing all area and district newsletters, as well as minutes and reports received from area and district committee meetings and assemblies.

Richard Bush

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

Trustees' committee: The work of the Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community reflects guidance given through the actions of the General Service Conference and the General Service Board. The service it provides is based on A.A.'s primary purpose, the Twelve Traditions and the Twelve Concepts. The committee's focus is to assist local C.P.C. committees in providing information about A.A. to professionals who may come in contact with the alcoholic and seeks to create mutual understanding and cooperation between the Fellowship and those professional groups and individuals concerned with alcoholism and the sick alcoholic.

The committee reviewed the 1996 C.P.C. Conference Committee Response Report on the trustees' C.P.C. Literature Review, which included comments and suggestions encouraging A.A.'s "Singleness of Purpose," eliminating unnecessary duplication and redundancy, seeking opportunities to simplify and clarify C.P.C. information, reviewing titles off existing C.P.C. items. Subsequently, the chairperson established a subcommittee to begin work based on the Conference Committee input. The subcommittee explored the possibility of combining



two or more existing pieces of C.P.C. literature and proposed that a draft be prepared, following a suggested outline, to combine the pamphlets "If You are a Professional...", "A.A. in Your Community" and "A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs." The draft was tabled for further discussion at the August 1997 meeting. As requested by the 1996 Conference Committee, a final report was prepared for review by the 1997 Conference Committee on C.P.C.

We discussed the possibility of adding current information about introducing A.A. to students of professional schools for possible inclusion in the C.P.C. Workbook and Guidelines. After considering the opportunities this form of C.P.C. service continues to provide to prospective professionals who may come in contact with the sick alcoholic, the committee requested input from local C.P.C. committees.

We discussed and approved the updated lists of C.P.C. exhibits at national professional meetings for 1996/1997, and committed to 21 exhibits in 1996 with participation from local C.P.C. committees in staffing the booths. We also reviewed and accepted the proposed 1997 budget of \$38,500 and forwarded details to the trustees' Finance Committee.

Following a review of the report by the ad hoc committee on the A.A. Web Site, the committee recommended that the proposed general letter to professionals seeking information about A.A. be added to the A.A. Web Site. The chairperson suggested that the committee continue to think of ways the A.A. Web Site could be utilized in C.P.C. service work.

In September the chairperson and the trustee-at-large/U.S., visited the Republic of Slovakia and were given the opportunity to carry the A.A. message to nonalcoholic professionals and share on how A.A. cooperates with the professional community.

John N. Chappel, M.D., chairperson

Staff report: The purpose of the C.P.C. assignment is to provide information about A.A. and establish good communication with those outside A.A. who may have direct contact with the still-suffering alcoholic through their professional work. These professionals include physicians, nurses, attorneys, correctional personnel, the clergy, social workers, counselors, employers, educators, and those working in the field of alcoholism. The staff member on this assignment maintains communication with C.P.C. committee chairs throughout the U.S. and Canada. New chairpersons are sent a welcome letter and receive the C.P.C. Kit containing the C.P.C.

Workbook, Guidelines, History and Actions, A.A. pamphlets and Literature Catalog, *Box 4-5-9*, and a current issue of *About A.A.* Upon request we assist C.P.C. committees by sharing C.P.C. experience and providing material. Currently there are over 560 area, district and central office/intergroup C.P.C. committees. We receive minutes from several of these committees and encourage all to share their experience for possible inclusion in *Box 4-5-9*.

G.S.O. receives calls and letters from professionals daily. In the past year the C.P.C. staff member has responded to over a thousand inquiries; several of these requests followed visits to our A.A. Web Site. Letters go out regularly to professionals, along with literature about A.A. We often provide a link to the local C.P.C. committees which demonstrate how valuable C.P.C. service is on all fronts. Many C.P.C. committee members can share that they have accumulated much experience through cooperating with professionals in ways that preserve the spirit of A.A.'s Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions.

Twenty-one exhibits were coordinated for national professional meetings in 1996, and staffed by local C.P.C. committees. Twenty-four invitations were referred to area C.P.C. committees for local professional events and A.A. literature and material was provided for 15 of these. In addition, we furnished C.P.C. material for several exhibits and events set up by local committees. Exhibits continued to be an affective tool in carrying the message to professionals and often result in requests for additional A.A. information, as well as requests to receive issues of our publication *About A.A.* Currently 17,767 professionals are receiving *About A.A.*, bringing the mailing list to 23,505. The summer issue of *About A.A.* featured "The A.A. Grapevine: A.A.'s Meeting in Print" and "A.A. Around the World" was the topic of the Winter/Spring issue, which included articles on the 14th World Service Meeting and a trip by two trustees to the Republic of Slovakia.

The C.P.C. staff member visited the professional exhibit booth at the U.S. Psychiatric and Mental Health Congress, which was attended by approximately 3,000 professionals. The staff member also attended the open house for Al-Anon/Alateen Family Group Headquarters in Virginia and two meetings of the National Institute on Alcohol Abuse and Addiction in Maryland.

Meetings with students from Cornell University Medical Center continue to be set up throughout the year at G.S.O. The students are provided with literature, see the video "Hope: Alcoholic Anonymous," and have a brief introduction to the A.A.



program and a tour of G.S.O. Following each visit the students thank us for the opportunity to know A.A. as a resource in their future professions. As well, we are grateful to them—knowing that, through God's grace, some day these professionals may help the sick alcoholic to a safer destination.

Eva Sanchez

CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

Trustees' committee: The purpose of the trustees' Committee on Correctional Facilities is to recommend more effective ways to carry the A.A. message to alcoholics in correctional facilities. Since the 1996 Conference, the committee completed the sample video on carrying the message behind the walls and forwarded it to the Conference Committee for their consideration.

The 1996 Conference Committee on C.F. suggested the trustees' C.F. Committee prepare copy on youth detention centers, women's institutions and short-term facilities for possible inclusion in the Correctional Facilities Workbook. A draft of suggested guidelines for youth detention centers and short term facilities was written and forwarded to the Conference T.F. Committee as a "work-in-progress" for their input. Based on responses from C.F. committee chairpersons, it was felt that, although problems other than alcohol might be different in women's facilities, the basic method of carrying the message was no different than carrying it into an adult men's institution, and, therefore, no additional material was required for the workbook on this subject.

Additional considerations forwarded to the Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities: Adding "Twelve Steps Illustrated," to the C.F. Workbook Literature Guide; adding the Grapevine, La Viña and *About A.A.* to the material listed on the back of "A Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators"; expanding the *Sharing From Behind the Walls* mailing list to include A.A. groups that meet in correctional facilities; and consider six suggestions to better inform professional correctional personnel, groups and associations about A.A.

At a trustees' committee meeting, each committee member shared about current correctional activities in their area. Some of the subjects reviewed included some states' restrictive rules regarding ex-offenders carrying the message into correctional facilities; the value of inmate G.S.R.s being allowed to attend "outside" A.A. functions as a method to encourage A.A. members to carry the message "inside"; the remoteness of some prisons,

which can create a burden on the local A.A.s; and the importance of continuing to carry the A.A. message no matter what reasons an inmate may have for attending an A.A. meeting.

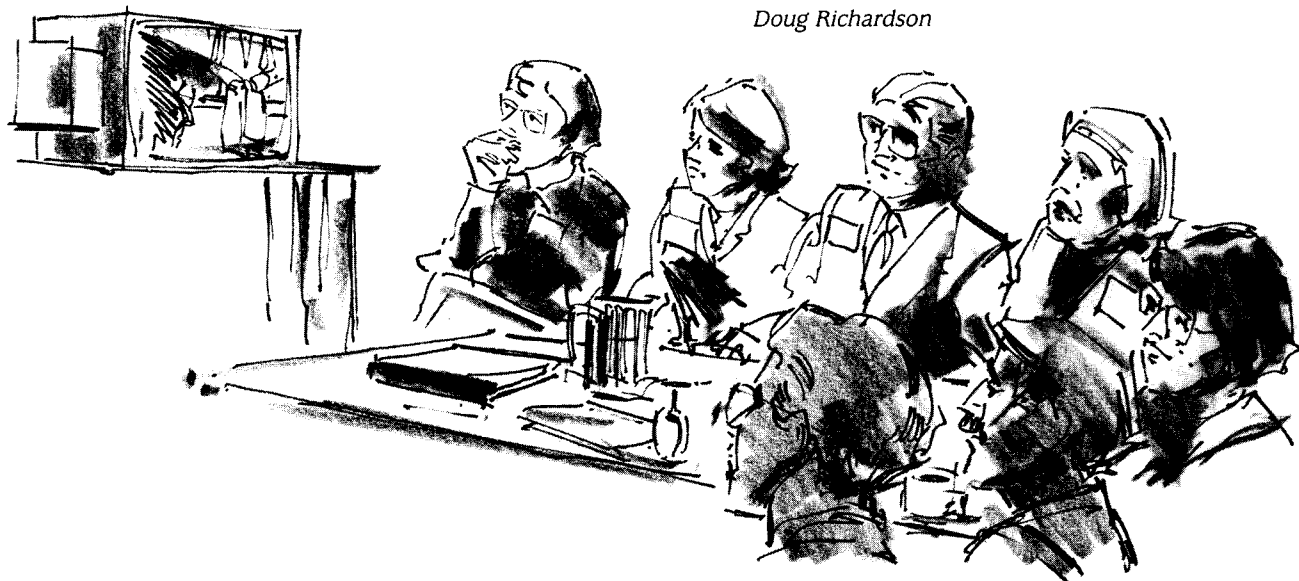
Don Weaver. chairperson

Staff report: The Correctional Facilities assignment is responsible for carrying the A.A. message to alcoholics confined in correctional institutions. Over 500 letters a month arrive from inmates, most asking for free literature, many asking for names of outside members with whom to correspond, or for help in making contact with A.A. upon release. We try to facilitate these requests, primarily through our network of area, district and local Correctional Facilities committees. The newsletter, *Sharing From Behind the Walls* is also a responsibility of this assignment.

The Corrections Correspondence Service (CCS), coordinated by this desk, continues as one of our most valuable efforts. Many inmates are looking to turn their lives around and crave outside support in this effort from experienced A.A.s with whom they can share their strength, hope and experience. There is an ongoing need for "outside" A.A. members, particularly men, to participate in this service. A service piece about our CCS (F-25) is included in new group packages and can be ordered for group literature stands.

One of the more persistent questions asked by A.A. members involved in corrections service is how to get their fellow members on the "outside" to commit to speaking or sponsoring a meeting in a correctional facility. The fear of not having the inmate identify with an A.A. member who has not been to prison, and the amount of time states and institutions require for orientation seminars to qualify to go into correctional facilities are commonly pointed out as impediments to Fellowship participation. During the production of the sample video to encourage A.A. members to take part in correctional service, these same fears and bureaucratic challenges were shared by all those A.A.s who helped make this video. At first "terrified," they have grown to become deeply committed to this important Twelfth Step work. "There but for the grace of God, go I," was often the phrase they used. Over and over again, these members expressed how richly enhanced their sobriety in A.A. had become through this type of service; how it kept *them* sober a day at a time. To quote one woman who leads a meeting in a women's facility in a large city: "For people who really want to carry the message, who really want to get involved with A.A. and who really want to keep their sobriety up front, I think that I have to say my commitment in a correctional facility is definitely the place I keep my sobriety up front."

Doug Richardson



FINANCE AND BUDGETARY COMMITTEE

Trustees' committee: We are pleased to report that contributions in 1996 increased by \$248,000, or 6.7%, to \$3,913,000. This is the highest level of contributions we have seen since 1992, and we hope it is the start of a trend. Net sales of \$8,261,000 were down 2% compared with 1995. Manufacturing, shipping, and royalty costs all declined more than sales, so gross profit from literature actually increased by \$94,000 compared with 1995. Gross profit from literature was \$75,000 below budget. Total G.S.O. revenue increased by \$333,000, or 5% compared with last year and was 1.5% ahead of budget.

G.S.O. operating expenses were \$50,000 below budget and \$450,000, or 5.6% higher than they were in 1995. Approximately \$230,000 of the increase in operating expenses were attributable to an early retirement program that will save money in the future. G.S.O. had an operating loss of \$1,264,000, which was \$117,000 greater than 1995's loss, but was \$153,000 less than budgeted.

In 1994, G.S.O. lowered prices and increased discounts on literature. These changes were undertaken to lower the Reserve Fund, which was approaching the upper limit established by the General Service Conference. The Conference-approved limit is 12 months of combined G.S.O. and Grapevine operating expenses. We have accomplished the objective of lowering the Reserve Fund. It now stands at 9 months, which is a little lower than it should be in normal times. Our projections show that the Reserve Fund would be in the 9 to 9.5 month range at the end of 1997. At \$7,421,000, the Reserve Fund amounts to \$133 per listed A.A. group. Some of the discounts that were increased in 1994 were rolled back to 1994 levels on August 1, 1996. At last year's Conference, I reported that literature price increases were possible in 1997, and we have since determined that price increases are required for us to continue our current level of services. The General Service Board has approved a budget recommended by A.A.W.S. that will increase literature prices on most books and pamphlets. The hardcover Big Book will cost \$1.00 more, and other items will go up by \$.60 to \$1.50, depending on the book. The pocket editions of *Alcoholics Anonymous* and *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* will remain at \$3.50. This is the first price increase we have had since 1991. Since 1990, our unit sales of books have declined at an average rate of 4.5% per year. We are now selling one-quarter (25%) fewer books than we were selling in 1990. Despite excellent cost control—our operating and shipping expenses were actually lower in 1996 than they were in 1991 when we last raised prices—we simply have to raise prices if we are to continue to provide the Fellowship with the current level of services.

Estimates of Groups and Members as of January 1, 1997

	Groups	Members
United States	50,681	1,158,850
Canada	5,275	98,720
Correctional facilities ¹	2,276	59,174
Internationalists		133
Lone members		316
Total	58,232 ²	1,317,193 ²
Outside U.S. & Canada ³	38,765	642,636
Grand Total	96,997	1,959,829

1. U.S. and Canada only.

2. U.S./Canada data includes only groups which ask to be registered at G.S.O., and which provide us with membership information. Although G.S.O. encourages groups to register, the process is optional. As of '94, the total number of A.A. groups reported was no longer inclusive of entities described as A.A. meetings, which chose not to be considered as A.A. groups. Such meetings had been included in the total for prior years.

3. There is A.A. activity in approximately 144 countries, including 42 countries that have autonomous general service offices. Annually we attempt to contact all groups & G.S.O.s outside of US/Canada which are listed in our records. Where current data is lacking we use previous year's figures.

In addition to these price increases, G.S.O.'s 1997 budget assumes a 5% decline in unit literature sales, a 3% increase in contributions, and flat operating expenses. The loss for the year is projected at \$139,000. After the price increase goes into effect on May 1, G.S.O. would be operating at better than break-even levels for the balance of the year. In 1996, we spent \$5,925,000 on services to the Fellowship. Contributions provided 66% of this, and the balance came from the Reserve Fund. Services spending amounted to \$106 per listed A.A. group, while contributions were \$70 per group. The 1996 service dollar was spent on the following activities:





Group Services, which includes the Group Services assignment; Box 4-5-9; A.A. Directories; records and files; contributions processing; French services, 42.2%; C.P.C., 4.3%; Public Information, 3.6%; Treatment Facilities, 2%; Correctional Facilities, 4.3%; Loners Internationalists and Overseas Services, 9.5%; the General Service Conference, 11.3%; Regional Forums, 5.1%; Archives, 5.9%; trustees and directors' activities, 7.8%; Spanish Services, 3.4%; and .6% to cover the excess expenses of the World Service Meeting.

At the Grapevine, magazine income rose \$85,000 over last year because of the 25% price increase that took effect on new subscriptions beginning April 1, 1996. Gross profit on the magazine was \$853,000, which was \$24,000 higher than last year and \$16,000 higher than budget. Weak sales of some books and tapes caused Other Publishing Income to decline, both compared with last year and budget. Gross profit on Other Publishing Income was \$66,000 lower than last year and \$47,000 under budget. Total income, including interest income, was \$1,200,000, \$40,000 below last year and \$31,000 under budget. Costs and expenses for editorial, circulation and business, and administration were \$1,388,000. This was \$145,000 higher than last year and \$75,000 over budget. Much of this increase is attributable to an office reorganization that cost more than expected. The Grapevine reported a loss of \$188,000, \$105,000 greater than budgeted and \$185,000 greater than in 1995.

The Grapevine's 1997 budget, excluding La Viña, calls for a \$100,000 increase in magazine income to \$1,714,000, compared with 1996, and an increase of \$78,000 in magazine gross profit. Gross profit on Other Publishing Income will increase \$24,000, interest income \$3,000, and costs and expenses will decrease by \$23,000. The net effect is a budgeted decline in net loss, from \$188,000 in 1996 to \$60,000 in 1997. The Grapevine expects to return to being profitable in 1998. Although circulation at La Viña, the Spanish-language Grapevine approved by the 1995 General Service Conference, was considerably higher than budgeted, operating costs were higher as well. Net losses were \$138,000, compared with \$97,000 budgeted. For 1997, losses at La Viña are budgeted at \$98,000, compared with a loss of \$93,000 called for in the business plan approved by the trustees' Finance Committee in October 1995. In view of projected losses substantially higher than those foreseen in the original business plan for the years 1998 through 2001, the Grapevine will present a revised business plan to the trustees' Finance Committee at the July 1997 board meeting.

Gary Glynn, chairperson

GENERAL SHARING SESSION

Trustees' report: In 1996, three General Sharing Sessions were conducted: January, "Ways in Which We Can Improve How We Do Things"; July, "Participation—Our Spiritual Growth"; November, "The A.A. Program—How It Affected My Life." In January, chairperson Peter Brock decided that he would like to share some of his concerns about A.A. and some of his hopes for A.A. in the future. He said, "We are here to carry the message, not to advance ourselves or ensure the outcome of certain issues we feel strongly about. When we are in committee and discussing issues, it is not about winning or losing, but rather it is about serving. When we come to the table as servants, we all win. No one has the only answer, that is why we have group conscience. The answer we try to achieve is through a Higher Power."

Peter Brock, a general service trustee, died in August, and his service to A.A. will be remembered by all who served with him. He summarized the January Sharing Session by concluding that Alcoholics Anonymous was in good shape, that all we really have to keep in mind is that we are here to serve and carry the A.A. message and we can do it with love rather than rancor.

In July, two presenters spoke on "Participation—Our Spiritual Growth." Larry Nelson, trustee-at-large/U.S., shared of his inability as a child and teenager to participate with others. He was a loner and found it difficult interacting with others. When he entered A.A. he found a new meaning of participation, mainly showing up at meetings and wanting to share. He then spoke of his journey in general service and his participation in A.A. up to today as trustee. Northeast regional trustee, MaryJane Roy, followed with her presentation and shared that when she did her first Fourth Step she was told she was now participating in the A.A. process. From that experience she found it easier to participate in other functions of A.A., like coffee making, etc. This activity led to participation in general service which helped to foster "unity," the thrust of our First Tradition.

In November, chairperson Raul Marin welcomed all to the General Sharing Session, especially World Service Meeting delegates invited to attend the board weekend. Two trustees were invited to present on the topic, "The A.A. Program—How It Affected My Life." East Central regional trustee Don Weaver said, "The A.A. program has given me a lot of things—a way to live my life so that I am a useful human being to other people. It has allowed me to become honest in all my actions, not so much with others, but with myself. It has taught me that I don't have to live in the past, but I can grow if I am willing to put forth the

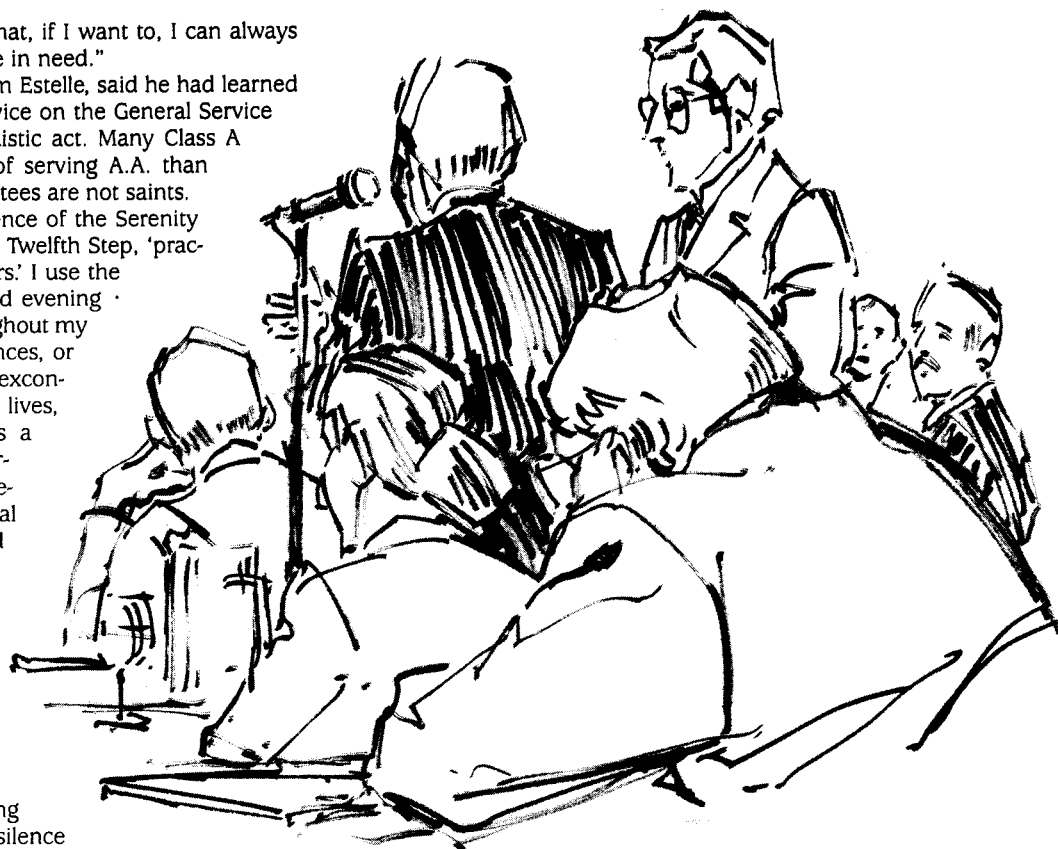
effort. It never fails to amaze me that, if I want to, I can always find time to do something for those in need."

Class A (nonalcoholic) trustee Jim Estelle, said he had learned to live the A.A. way of life. His service on the General Service Board has not been a wholly altruistic act. Many Class A trustees "get so much more out of serving A.A. than what we put into it. We Class A trustees are not saints. I try to live between the first sentence of the Serenity Prayer and the last sentence of the Twelfth Step, 'practice these principles in all our affairs.' I use the Serenity Prayer in my morning and evening meditation and several times throughout my day." At Regional Forums, conferences, or assemblies, Jim shared he had met exconvicts leading sober and productive lives, an experience he termed "always a payday for me." In closing, the chairperson said that although both presenters would rotate of the General Service Board next year, they would always be in the hearts of A.A.s around the world. There followed sharing from the floor on how A.A. had affected individual lives. Many present thanked the General Service Board for the opportunity to participate in this session and for the sharing from around the world.

The February 1, 1997, Sharing Session opened with a moment of silence for Raul Marin who was ill, followed by the Serenity Prayer. Elaine Johnson, Class A trustee and acting chairperson, read a paper on Convention Financial Incentives which was provided as a framework on the history of Convention financial incentives, up to this time. This topic was requested by the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums so that they could have the benefit of shared experience. Chuck Crist, general service trustee, was asked to present a "con" viewpoint; Michael McPherson, also a general service trustee, presented a "pro" viewpoint on the following topic: "Board policy regarding financial/cash incentives including monetary subsidies, in-kind subsidies, rebates, etc. in connection with bids to host International Conventions."

A spirited discussion ensued that evolved around A.A. Traditions and principles, policies, accepting cash incentives, definition of terms, "gifts," the issue of business practices versus spiritual practices. Concern was expressed with regard to whether this topic was a General Service Board matter or Conference matter, or both. Some felt that the current practice was in keeping with A.A. Traditions, while others thought it ought to be changed. Some thought a policy should be adopted regarding "cash incentives" at International Conventions. Others said we have a policy, which is the Seventh Tradition. Several participants expressed the view that the Seventh Tradition says A.A. may not accept contributions or "gifts" from outside sources. If they are not "gifts," then we may accept them. We can make this decision from knowledge and experience without the need to formulate policies. There was general admiration for everyone's civility in handling the subject matter at hand and a general expression of confidence that the solution to "cash incentives" would be resolved in keeping within the spiritual values of Alcoholics Anonymous.

Raul Marin, chairperson



GROUP SERVICES

Staff report: To assist groups, G.S.O. provides service material to the Fellowship, based on an indicated need, to provide information and share experience not found in Conference-approved literature. A four-page list describes the service items in detail. Examples of service material include: Regional Forum Reports; A.A. Guidelines; Referral List of Fellowships Similar to A.A.; Special Needs items, such as information about A.A. literature in Braille and audio cassettes and special literature for deaf alcoholics.

Current ongoing projects involving Group Services:

- Coordination and production of three A.A. Directories: Eastern U.S., Western U.S. and Canadian. The staff member on Group Services works closely with the Special Projects manager regarding group printouts and data bases to areas and central/intergroup offices' records.
- Supervision of G.S.O. Service files. There is a variety of service material available, upon request, to A.A. members, groups, and for service workshops.
- Supervision/production of service material such as A.A. Guidelines, Group Handbooks, and G.S.R. Kits.
- Liaison with intergroup/central offices, including serving on the Policy and Site Committees of the Intergroup Seminar, which will next take place in Columbus, Ohio, October 24-26, 1997.
- Liaison with Special Needs committees working to make A.A. more accessible to all alcoholics.

Lois Fisher

Marti Hooper (Panel 46) was the first delegate in Idaho to be allowed to give her delegate's report in prison.

INTERNATIONAL/WORLD SERVICE MEETING

Trustees' committee: This committee is responsible for suggesting policies and actions to assure that the A.A. message is available around the world, especially in areas where there is no established service structure. We provide shared experience, support translations of A.A. literature in other languages, and encourage the expansion of regional or zonal service meetings. The committee is a primary link between the international A.A. community and the General Service Board of Trustees.

World Service Meeting—Every two years delegates from countries with an organized service structure, and/or literature distribution center come together at the World Service Meeting (WSM). Last October, 42 delegates from 26 countries or zones participated in the 14th World Service Meeting in New York City. We welcomed the first WSM delegate from the Russian Federation, who joined us in celebrating the theme of "Love and Gratitude in Action." Especially heartwarming was the increase in financial responsibility of the participating countries. Delegate fees and contributions resulted in a 10% reduction in the final cost of \$23,700.

Literature Assistance—The 1997 Literature Assistance budget of \$120,000 will allow A.A. World Services to translate and publish a variety of service material. Some examples are: "A.A. Group Guidelines," several basic pamphlets and five books (Romanian *Living Sober* and Big Book; Slovak "Twelve Steps"; Czech *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*; and *As Bill Sees It* in Lithuanian). This service is partially underwritten by contributions of U.S./Canada groups, as well as support from the International Literature Fund of contributions from A.A. groups around the world.

Travel and Communication—Over the last three years, we have experienced a three-fold increase in overseas correspondence. During 1996, translations of routine correspondence cost \$24,000 compared to \$8,084 in 1993. New A.A. groups are meeting in the Canary Islands, Croatia, Estonia, Ethiopia, Kazakhstan, Latvia, Madagascar, Moldova, Namibia, Tanzania, Turkey, Uzbekistan and Zimbabwe. Central offices/intergroups have been established in Belarus, Bulgaria, Kenya and Ukraine; and, groups in Romania are meeting monthly to work toward setting up an office and structure. We welcomed a new general service office in Lisbon, Portugal.

Through invitations from A.A.s in other lands, trustees and staff have traveled to Costa Rica, Dominican Republic, Germany, Ireland, Mexico, Poland, and Slovakia.

Interim Service Meetings—We accepted an invitation from the biennial Meeting of the Americas for two trustees to participate as delegates in the next meeting, October 22-26, 1997, in Guadalajara, Mexico. U.S./Canada representatives will also attend the Asian-Oceania Service Meeting (March 1997) and European Service Meeting in October 1997.

Members of our board continue to carry the A.A. message into Cuba in cooperation with the general service board in Mexico.

Each week, G.S.O. welcomed visitors from overseas, including the managers of the general service offices in Finland, Germany and Great Britain, trustees from Ireland and India, and a founding member of A.A. in Slovakia.

We continue to be encouraged and inspired by the international A.A. community and General Service Boards in other countries, who carry our message to countless thousands in new regions and across difficult linguistic, cultural and economic barriers.

Larry Nelson, chairperson

Staff report: If you need reassurance that our Fellowship is thriving, come sit at the Overseas desk for a day. Letters from around the world arrive daily—from new groups asking for literature and the reassurance of identification and shared experience, or from professionals seeking information on how A.A. works, and from members staffing a new office that is struggling to stay afloat. Each request is answered with a letter, often accompanied by A.A. literature. Where there is a nearby office, we share the location and telephone number.

It would be easy to feel overwhelmed by the difficulties that our friends encounter in some countries where A.A. is new and sometimes misunderstood. Using the experience of A.A.'s beginnings in Akron and New York, we know that "two or more" can do what one cannot possibly accomplish. The Overseas staff member benefits by the experience of G.S.O. staff, cooperation with the Publications Department, and the support of the trustees' International Committee that he or she serves as secretary.

The staff member on the Overseas assignment also serves as secretary to the biennial World Service Meeting (WSM) and maintaining contact with delegates and their offices throughout the year. At the conclusion of the 14th WSM last October, we gathered in a circle to participate in the Serenity Prayer in 17 languages. The 15th WSM will be held in Auckland, New Zealand, October 4-8,



1998. The staff member also maintains close communications with our Publications Department on requests for new translations of literature (most touching are the unanticipated translations of the Big Book lovingly prepared by an A.A. member), and the beginnings of new central offices that may be able to distribute literature to local members and groups.

Each year, the A.A. World Services Board receives offers to translate our literature into a foreign language. Primary in consideration of each request is the need to ensure the integrity and authenticity of A.A.'s message. To that end, the Publications Department has the responsibility of checking each translation against the English original. In countries where there is a general service board licensed to publish A.A. literature, an approved translation is often financed and published there. Where a stable A.A. structure is not yet present, the A.A.W.S. Board undertakes the new publication when funds are available. The Big Book has been translated into 34 languages, and additional translations are pending approval and/or funding.

The General Service Office of the Russian Federation has recently assumed responsibility of warehousing and distributing the bulk of A.A. literature in their language. We look forward to that G.S.O. assuming responsibility for Russian language publications.

There is also close cooperation with the Spanish Services staff member who may first receive up-to-date details on A.A. in a country where Spanish is the primary language. We also are involved in communications related to overseas trips, including Interim Service Meetings, held biennially in the year between each World Service Meeting. Our board sends one or two representatives to the Asian-Oceania Service Meeting, the European Service Meeting and the Meeting of the Americas, (formerly the Ibero-American Meeting).

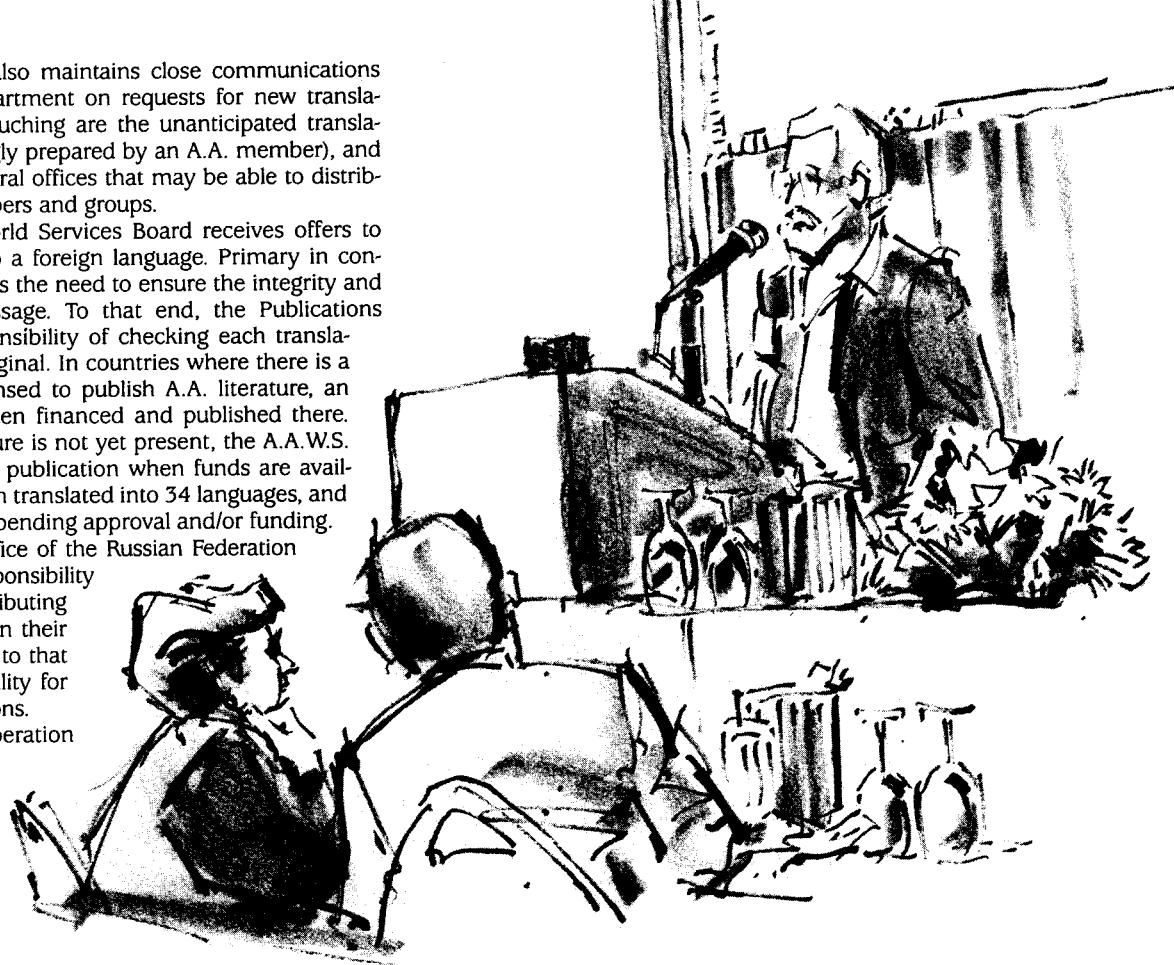
Two months ago, a Christmas card came from the chairman of the Union of Journalists in Bulgaria. He wrote "Merry Christmas and Happy New Year dear friends. I am no member of your club, but I congratulate your works and your help by your giving to many people all over the world." A new local A.A. office had impressed this man with the most basic A.A. public information. Perhaps there's a lesson in this example—"Keep it simple."

Joanie Moncrief

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ A.A. REGIONAL FORUMS

Trustees' committee:

International Convention—As our International Conventions now have a projected attendance of over 50,000 A.A. members, it is necessary to begin site selection nine years prior to the actual International Convention. In August 1996, a bid form was sent to all delegates so they could determine whether or not (1) their area was interested in participating in an A.A. International Convention and (2) there were cities in their area which met the basic criteria for hosting an A.A. International Convention. Some of these criteria are as follows: Convention center with a minimum of 250,000 gross square feet; stadium which seats a minimum of 55,000 people; at least 15,000 committable hotel rooms



within a 25-30 mile radius of the downtown/convention center; a covered stadium or an open stadium with an acceptable risk factor for weather; availability of approximately 4,000- 5,000 A.A. volunteers.

Of the thirteen bid questionnaires received, nine cities met the basic criteria and eight decided to participate in ten-minute presentations by the delegates and one convention bureau representative to a Joint committee of the members of the trustees' and Conference Committees on International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums on the Saturday prior to the April 1996 General Service Conference. During the General Service Conference, the joint committees met to recommend four finalist cities for consideration. The staff secretary coordinated site-selection trips to the following four cities: July 1996—St. Louis and San Antonio; September 1996—Toronto and Atlanta.

There was extensive planning to prepare similar itineraries with similar access to the site-selection team by the A.A. community and city, hotel and convention bureau personnel in each of the four cities. At each city, the site-selection team met to review the criteria used in evaluating each possible site city for the 2005 International Convention. The site-selection team consisted of seven members: G.S.O.'s general manager, the chairperson of the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums, the chairperson of the A.A.W.S. Board, G.S.O.'s controller, two convention management consultants, hired as a resource for site selection, and the coordinator of the 2000 International Convention.

In November 1996, the trustees' International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums Committee and the General Service Board accepted the recommendation from the site-selection team that

Toronto, Canada be the host city for the 2005 A.A. International Convention. The site-selection team presented a report to the trustees' International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums Committee based on the following criteria: major facilities (convention center/stadiums); city desirability; transportation and financial considerations; average cost to attendee.

Requests for proposals were sent to members of the Institute of Association Management Companies and to current and past Southern Minnesota delegates to invite proposals from convention management firms for a convention management consultant for 2000. Don Meurer, G.S.O.'s controller, was contacted by 20 management firms throughout the U.S. and Canada and received proposals from four companies, one from Colorado, one from Nebraska and two from New Jersey. After extensive review, the committee accepted G.S.O. management's recommendation to hire the Talley Management Group, Inc., New Jersey, as the convention consultant management firm for the 2000 International Convention.

Starting July, and continuing through 1997, there was extensive correspondence and sharing regarding A.A.'s policy of accepting financial/cash incentives to offset expenses of International Conventions. At the request of this committee and with the agreement of the General Service Board, the following was the topic at the February 1997 Board Weekend Sharing Session: "Board policy regarding financial/cash incentives including monetary subsidies, in-kind subsidies, rebates, etc. in connection with bids to host International Conventions." Historical information and research about site-selection procedures and past financial/cash incentives was shared with committee members. At their February 1997 meeting, the committee referred consideration of A.A.'s policy of accepting financial/cash incentives to offset expenses of International Conventions to the February 1997 meeting of the trustees' Finance Committee and the 1997 Conference Finance Committee.

Because of the increasing complexity and size of International Conventions, the committee suggested that the trustees' Finance Committee consider describing in greater detail discounts, rebates and cash inducements of individual cost items of International Conventions in future financial statements.

A.A. Regional Forums—Three regions have held Forums since the last General Service Conference: Pacific, Eastern Canada and Southeast. All were lively and well-attended with substantive sharing on important A.A. topics. The committee recommended approval of a request for a Special Forum in Alaska to be held at four sites: Ketchikan, Juneau, Anchorage and Fairbanks. The following Forums and Special Forums are scheduled prior to the 1998 General Service Conference:

1997		
May 9—12	Special Forum	Ketchikan, Juneau, Anchorage and Fairbanks, AK
May 30—June 1	East Central	Moline, IL
June 20—22	Northeast	Tarrytown, NY
August 22—23	Special Forum	Val D'Or, PQ
September 5—7	West Central	St. Paul, MN
December 5—7	Southwest	Houston, TX

Elaine Johnson, Ph.D., chairperson

Sunday afternoon the Pacific Area delegates enjoyed a boat trip around Manhattan — oblivious to the fact that it was pouring rain!

Staff reports:

International Conventions—This assignment involves coordinating every aspect of the many processes and plans that go to make up A.A. International Conventions, held every five years. These Conventions provide a wonderful opportunity for individual A.A. members to serve, celebrate and share sobriety. Very preliminary plans are already underway for the International Convention in 2000 to be held June 29—July 2 in Minneapolis, Minnesota. Preparations and logistics are being studied to plan for three stadium meetings, celebratory dances, accommodating approximately 250 workshops, panels, regional alkathons, topic meetings and marathons which will require about 1,000 speakers and moderators. Research has started regarding procedures for housing and registration. The advances in computer technology and access to the Internet worldwide will offer opportunities to incorporate the Internet as a communications tool.

In 1996, the International Convention coordinator was responsible for preparing reports on all site-selection trips, 2000 International Convention management selection, 2005 International Convention site-selection criteria and historical documentation and background information regarding financial/cash incentives for past International Conventions. Consistent planning and preparation continues so that future International Conventions, hopefully, will provide the same experience that A.A. members found in past International Conventions—a milestone A.A. event filled with gratitude and the language of the heart in a welcoming, friendly A.A. setting.

Valerie O'Neill

Regional Forums—The staff member handling Regional Forums is responsible for coordinating and following through on all arrangements necessary for holding Regional Forums in the U.S. and Canada. These sharing weekends help foster wider communication and understanding among A.A. service workers, the General Service Board, A.A. World Services, Inc., the Grapevine Corporate Board, the Grapevine staff and the General Service Office staff. Regional Forums are held at the invitation of a particular region every two years; there are four Forums annually.

The location and agenda for a Regional Forum are decided jointly by the regional trustee, area delegates and G.S.O. The responsibility for direct contact with the hotel is assumed by a local A.A. host contact working with the Regional Forums coordinator and regional trustee. The Regional Forums coordinator at G.S.O. distributes invitations and registration forms to groups and service workers throughout the region and, working with the host contact and regional trustee, coordinate the details of the Forum. The Regional Forums coordinator is also responsible for preparing and distributing a comprehensive report of the Forum to all who attend.

A region may request a Special Forum, which has fewer participants from the boards and staff over shorter time periods. Special Forums require the approval of the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums. They may be designed for remote, sparsely populated or urban areas. The Regional Forums coordinator works closely with the regional trustee and host contact tailoring each agenda to local needs. Two Special Forums are planned for 1997—one in Alaska in May and the other in Val D'Or, Quebec in August.

The staff member on Regional Forums also serves as secretary of the trustees' Nominating Committee, Conference Committee on Trustees and co-secretary of the trustees' and Conference International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums Committees. Under the present structure the staff member on the Regional Forums assignment is also responsible for Group Services.

Lois Fisher

LITERATURE

Trustees' committee: Following is a summary of the literature projects of the trustees' Literature Committee since the 1996 General Service Conference.

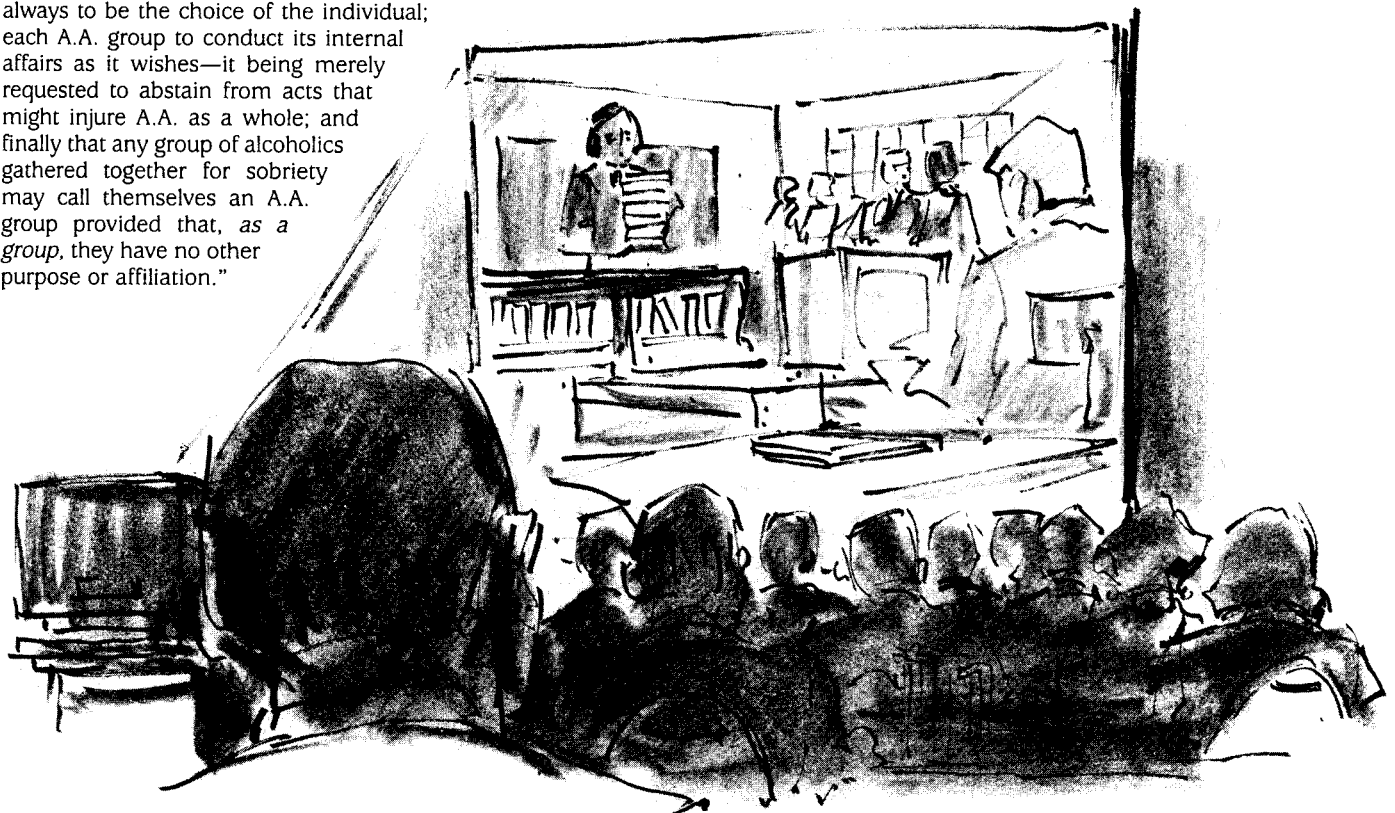
Projects Completed—The Concepts Checklist was placed in the General Service Office service files; an inaccuracy in the text of "Pass It On," was corrected at the next printing.

Projects forwarded to the Conference Literature Committee—

(1) The development of a draft Fourth Edition of *Alcoholics Anonymous*, keeping in mind the 1995 Advisory Action that: *The first 164 pages of the Big Book. Alcoholics Anonymous. the Preface, the Forewords, "The Doctor's Opinion," "Dr. Bob's Nightmare," and the Appendices remain as is,* and that a separate publication be developed to include stories dropped from the First, Second and Third Editions of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*. (Once developed, each of these drafts would be reviewed by the trustees' Literature Committee and recommendations would be made to the Conference through the Conference Literature Committee); (2) a recommendation that the word "never" be removed from page 14 of the pamphlet, "Questions and Answers on Sponsorship"; (3) a series of possible changes in *Living Sober* were sent to the Conference Literature Committee for their approval, including the consideration of adding material on A.A. in cyberspace; (4) background material on confidentiality, with the suggestion that the material not be produced. (Perhaps at some later time information could be included in existing literature during revision); (5) a suggestion that the following material from the Sixth Warranty be added to the section "What Is An A.A. Group?" on page 15 of "The A.A. Group" pamphlet, so that section could now include a section from Warranty Six found in the Twelfth Concept on page 73 of *The A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts for World Service*: "no penalties to be inflicted for nonconformity to A.A. principles; no fees or dues to be levied—voluntary contributions only; no member to be expelled from A.A.—membership always to be the choice of the individual; each A.A. group to conduct its internal affairs as it wishes—it being merely requested to abstain from acts that might injure A.A. as a whole; and finally that any group of alcoholics gathered together for sobriety may call themselves an A.A. group provided that, as a group, they have no other purpose or affiliation."

Ongoing Projects—(1) The chairperson of the Video subcommittee gave full reports on the progress of the Video project. Filming has taken place, with time spent at an area assembly election weekend and at groups of A.A., as well as at G.S.O. A rough draft of the video is hoped for at the joint meeting of the trustees' and Conference Literature Committees in April; (2) The committee discussed a request and agreed that a change should be made in the statement, "...Anyone who turns to A.A. can be assured that his or her anonymity will be protected" on page 19 in the pamphlet, "This is A.A." The committee turned the request over to the Literature Review subcommittee.

Additional trustees' Literature Committee Considerations—(1) The committee discussed the request that the Big Book be unchanged without approval of three quarters of the groups of Alcoholics Anonymous and took no action since it felt that the Conference has taken such action as it can in regard to protecting the Big Book; (2) correspondence regarding the preparation of information for the Fellowship regarding working with wet drunks was passed to the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee, since it is on their agenda; (3) discussed the publication of a pamphlet regarding what is Conference-approved versus Non-Conference-approved A.A. literature and felt that the current service information sheet entitled "Conference-approved Literature" responds to the need in the Fellowship; (4) heard the report of the subcommittee and approved changes to the trustees' Literature Committee's Composition, Scope and Procedure; (5) discussed requests regarding the A.A. History Book, and saw no reason to bring back the draft. There was agreement that the A.A. History Book not be made available in the Archives or anywhere else since it runs the risk of becoming "unofficial" A.A. literature and could involve legal problems; (6) discussed the possibility of publishing a volume of Bill W.'s correspondence and noted that Bill was an extremely prolific writer (approximately 20,000 letters = 20-22 square feet of records in



archival measures). Bill's writings are available in such volumes as *A.A. Comes of Age*, *The Language of the Heart*, and *As Bill Sees It*, etc., and the committee decided not to pursue another; (7) discussed the request to change the wording of the Responsibility Pledge from: "I am responsible... When anyone, anywhere reaches out for help I want the hand of A.A. always to be there. And for that: I am responsible," to: "I am responsible... When anyone, anywhere reaches out for help **with an alcoholic problem**, I want the hand of A.A. always to be there. And for that: I am responsible." The committee decided that this would not be pursued since there is concern that the historic content might be damaged. This Responsibility Pledge was the theme of the 1965 International Convention in Toronto. (Note: The word and spirit of the responsibility declaration reaffirmed by the General Service Conference in 1971 and 1977.); (8) an inaccurate date in the Foreword to the Second Edition of the Big Book was reviewed and there was no action taken. (The date of the first meeting of the Cleveland Group in the original text written by Bill W., of the Foreword to the Second Edition of the Big Book, was stated as 1937, when in fact the Cleveland Group started in 1939.); (9) suggested that perhaps an article in *Box 4-5-9* focusing on the needs of seniors and elderly alcoholics, as well as further discussion through workshops and at Regional Forums, might heighten awareness of the problem.

Gay Garner, chairperson

Staff report: The Literature coordinator serves as secretary to the trustees' and Conference Literature Committees and works closely with the editor, writers and illustrators on preparing all new recovery pamphlets, books, displays and audiovisuals, in accordance with recommendations from the General Service Conference. The coordinator, along with the editor, follows the progress of writers and illustrators on the updating and revising of all recovery pamphlets. Final design and production of all this material is under the auspices of the A.A. World Services' Publications Department.

The Literature desk receives and responds to correspondence from A.A. members and groups about literature. We maintain contact with all current area, district, intergroup/central offices and A.A. group literature chairpersons. Each newly elected literature chairperson receives a welcoming letter and guidelines to assist the chairperson in this vital responsibility. Additionally, the

Literature coordinator is the liaison with the French Literature Service in Montreal, Quebec, Canada and also serves as Native North American contact person.

Under the present structure of G.S.O., the staff member on the Literature desk serves as editor of *Box 4-5-9*, published in English, French and Spanish. Work is ongoing all year for ideas for *Box 4-5-9* articles, and the calendar of events is kept up-to-date daily. The staff member works closely with the editor of the Publications Department and a small editorial committee to bring the Fellowship news and notes from G.S.O. through *Box 4-5-9*.

Pat Rosenstiel

LONERS, INTERNATIONALISTS, HOMERS

Staff report: As the name implies, Loners are A.A.s who are unable to attend meetings because there are no groups nearby. There are about 334 Loners in 83 countries, including the U.S. and Canada. Seagoing A.A.s, known as Internationalists, number about 134 with an additional 41 Port Contacts. Thirteen Internationalist Groups meet aboard ships or in ports. Homers are A.A.s who are housebound due to long-term illness or physical disability. We now have 153 Homers in the Loners/Internationalists Group. Loners, Homers, and Internationalists stay sober by reading A.A. literature and by sharing A.A. experience, strength and hope with other A.A.s around the world through letters and tapes.

A literature package is sent to each new Loner, Homer or Internationalist. Each also receives a directory of Loners, Homers, and Internationalists, complimentary subscriptions to *Box 4-5-9* and *Loners/Internationalists Meeting-By-Mail*, a bimonthly meeting-in-print which shares excerpts of letters received at G.S.O. from LIM members. Over 904 Loner Sponsors, A.A.s who do attend meetings regularly, share group activities and personal experience with the Loners, Homers and Internationalists.

A.A.'s message of hope continues to be carried around the world through traveling A.A. members, through our literature, and now through e-mail. Homer John G., Liverpool, England, shares via e-mail: "Many thanks for the LIM which arrived today. Lovely to see e-mail contacts—already I have had three messages from some of them and I shall enjoy getting the replies moving. It is a whole new world to me and so interesting."

Since January 1997, new Loners have come from remote





places such as Mozambique, Korea, Poland, India, Ireland, Germany and Russia. From Perth Village, Guyana, Loner Francis M. writes: "I can't see how I could do without those yellow pages that come to me so regularly. Indeed, *LIM* has done very much for me. Without *LIM*, I would have never made it. I can't say enough thanks to all of you for the years you've all helped me on the road to recovery. You've never asked for anything in return for your help. God bless all of you abundantly."

Internationalists or "seagoing A.A.s" are out in the Arabian Gulf, the Mediterranean and the Black Sea. The *LIM* helps, as the following message from Internationalist Dan L. indicates: "At this time, I would like to thank you at G.S.O.'s Loners/Internationalists Desk. For all the years I have been going to sea, my favorite mail was my *Meeting-By-Mail*. Though I do not know you personally, you have helped me to maintain my sobriety over the last 19 years. Each time I've received material, attended a meeting on a new ship or received correspondence from a new member to the Fellowship, it has helped when I was so far away from home. Thank you from the bottom of my heart for your support, caring and fellowship."

Much gratitude goes to Loner Sponsors who share regularly. Loner Sponsor Jim C. writes: "I wrote my first letter in 1978 and have been writing or taping ever since. It is with a warm heart that I can remember the many, many letters that have come in and gone out since then. Friendships have been made with people in places that I never dreamed of. Around the world in England, Germany, Ireland, India, Australia, etc. Little did I know when I came through the doors of A.A. that there would be such a thing, but here it is. In many ways, my correspondence is the backbone of my program—whether we have met yet, or not, isn't important. What's important is the fact that we all share in the *LIM* and we can all hear what we need to hear, in order to stay sober."

Adrienne Brown

NOMINATING

Trustees' committee: The committee reviewed the proposal from the Remote Communities Committee that the 90th Meridian be the dividing line in the Northwest Territories between the Eastern and Western Canada Regions and recommended that the General Service Board accept this change and forward this proposal to the Conference Committee on Trustees for consideration at the 1997 General Service Conference.

We also discussed fractional votes in the election of regional or at-large trustees and recommended that the 1997 Conference Committee on Trustees consider changing the "rounding-off" procedure from the nearest whole to a mathematically accurate number and that such change, if approved, go into effect at the 1998 General Service Conference.

Resumes of "friends of A.A." with backgrounds related to the field of corrections were reviewed and four were invited to be interviewed during the February 1997 board weekend. The committee recommended that the Honorable Linda L. Chezem serve as a Class A trustee.

A draft of suggested guidelines from the Procedures subcommittee was presented as being close to completion. It was suggested that the subcommittee meet once again prior to the 1997 Conference to complete its work which will then be reviewed, if feasible, by the Nominating Committee during the General Service Conference. The resulting document will then be passed to the General Service Board for consideration at the August meeting or, if more work is necessary, to the 1997-1998 Nominating Committee at its August 1997 meeting.

A letter was sent to all current Class A trustees, except Jim Estelle, and to all Class A trustees who have rotated since 1988 asking if they are interested in serving as chairperson of the General Service Board when Jim Estelle rotates in April 1997. In December, the Nominating Committee interviewed those who expressed interest. The committee's unanimous recommendation, at a trustees' only meeting on January 31, 1997, was that Gary Glynn serve as chairperson of the General Service Board, following the 1997 General Service Conference.

The committee approved Robert McCoy to serve as an appointed committee member on the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community.

Although two general service trustee vacancies will occur on the A.A. World Services Board, the committee recommended that the A.A. World Services Board forward one nominee to serve as general service trustee during the 1997-1998 year to have a more balanced rotation in the future.

The committee recommended the following nominations:
A.A. World Services Board: Garry McAuley, Western Canada regional trustee, replacing Julian Rhinehart; Richard Roughton to serve as general service trustee, replacing Michael McPherson; John Koster and Jacqueline Johnston to serve as nontrustee directors replacing Jacques Filteau and Richard Roughton; Michel

Girard, trustee-at-large/Canada to serve as an interim director. *A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board:* Carl Budd, West Central regional trustee, replacing Larry Nelson; Tom Maguire to serve as general service trustee, replacing Jane Schulberg; David Every to serve as a nontrustee director, replacing Tom Maguire.

The proposed slates of General Service Board members, officers of the board, A.A. World Services and A.A. Grapevine directors were forwarded to the 1997 Conference Committee on Trustees for disapproval, if any.

The committee reviewed and will recommend the following slate of trustees at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April, following presentation at the 1997 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Class A

John N. Chappel, M.D.	Arthur L. Knight, Jr.
Linda L. Chezern	Robert O. Miller, D. D.
Gary A. Glynn	Peter Roach
Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.	

Class B*

Carl Budd	Raul Marin
William Bungay	Julian Rhinehart
Chuck Crist	Richard Roughton
Michel Girard	MaryJane Roy
Tom Maguire	

Two regional trustees (East Central and Southeast) and the trustee-at-large/U.S. to be elected in April 1997)

The committee recommended the following slate of officers of the General Service Board to be presented to the 1997 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

<i>Chairperson</i>	Gary Glynn
<i>First Vice-Chairperson</i>	John N. Chappel, M.D.
<i>Second Vice-Chairperson</i>	Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.
<i>Treasurer</i>	Arthur L. Knight, Jr.
<i>Secretary</i>	Julian Rhinehart
<i>Assistant Treasurer</i>	Donald Meurer
<i>Assistant Secretary</i>	Susan Ulseth
	(to be replaced at staff rotation, September 1997)

The committee reviewed and recommended the following slate of directors of A.A. World Services, Inc., to be presented to the 1997 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

George Dorsey	Gerard L. Ouellette
Michel Girard	Richard Roughton
Jacqueline Johnston	MaryJane Roy
John Koster	Susan Ulseth
Garry McAuley	(to be replaced at staff rotation, September 1997)

The committee reviewed and recommended the following slate of directors of A.A. Grapevine, Inc., to be presented to the 1997 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any:

Carl Budd	Raul Marin
Chuck Crist	Ray Stiver
David V. Every	Ames Sweet
Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.	Gregory Tobin
Tom Maguire	

MaryJane Roy, chairperson

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Trustees' committee: The responsibilities of the trustees' Public Information Committee include: creating a greater public understanding of the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous; producing television and radio public service announcements; producing films about A.A.; preparing press releases and reports to the public; coordinating health fairs and other community exhibits with local P.I. committees; conducting the A.A. Membership Survey; carrying A.A.'s message through electronic media as well as public media.

The committee met three times since the last Conference. Much of the work of the committee was done through the 1996 A.A. Membership Survey subcommittee. Following is a list of work over the past year:

- Extensive research of options for the 1996 Membership Survey pamphlet regarding reporting the results of the new race and disability questions.
- Extensive review of data resulting from the 1996 Membership Survey with comparisons to past data to determine consistency of results.
- Discussion of recommending 1998 as a proposed date for the next A.A. Membership Survey in order to return to the historical triennial survey pattern.

The following items have been referred for consideration to the 1997 Conference P.I. Committee:

- Approval of the draft of the 1996 Membership Survey pamphlet.
- Approval of the draft of the 1998 Membership Survey Questionnaire.
- Approval of production of three television Public Service Announcements emphasizing membership of young people, membership of minorities and generic A.A. information (cost not to exceed \$40,000) as the first stage of a plan for the trustees' Public Information Committee to study and update, where necessary, all television and radio P.S.A.s including cultural references, availability in French and Spanish as well as availability in formats compatible with current technology.
- Discussion of 1996 reports on A.A. Web Site activity and its use as a Public Information tool.
- Review of the Public Information Kit and Workbook.

Jane Murphy Schulberg, chairperson

Staff report: The goal of the Public Information assignment is to help to carry the A.A. message to the alcoholic, potential alcoholic and the general public through the media, health fairs, schools and A.A. Web Site on the World Wide Web/Internet. It is a crucial part of Public Information work here at the General Service Office to be a resource for the "collected experience and sharing" of Public Information committees throughout the United States and Canada. Currently the Public Information staff person sends P.I. information three or four times a year to approximately 500 P.I. Committee chairpeople at the area, district, intergroup/central office and group level. The staff person is responsible for handling interviews with the media, describing what A.A. is and what we can and cannot do. The staff member and staff assistant respond to hundreds of written and telephone inquiries and provide accurate information to the media, researchers, students and the general public about Alcoholics Anonymous.

During the past year, we have arranged for literature to be available at local health and community fairs. In many cases, local Public Information committees provide this literature and participate in these fairs. Whenever possible, we try to connect the community contact with local A.A. Public Information committees so that there can be a local group conscience decision about how A.A. can best participate in these events and so that

* General Service Board to operate short one general service trustee between April 1997 and April 1998.

communication can be established between the community event organizers and local A.A. committees.

New area Public Information chairpeople are automatically sent the Public Information Workbook and all Public Information committee chairpeople receive *Box 4-5-9* as well as updated P.I. information from the staff member.

Extensive preparation and planning has facilitated the completion of the 1996 Membership Survey. The staff member coordinates several mailings to delegates who in turn distribute Survey Questionnaires to the groups which are selected on a random scientific basis from the G.S.O. mailing list. The delegates are responsible for returning completed Survey Questionnaires to the staff member in either English, French or Spanish. This information from the participating groups becomes the basis for the 1996 Membership Survey pamphlet, when approved.

When the Public Information coordinator receives information about anonymity breaks at the level of press, radio or film, this information is forwarded to area delegates who respond to each anonymity break on a case-by-case basis.

The annual media anonymity letter, with a return postcard for those who wish additional information, was mailed in February as follows (each category reflects mailing to both the United States and Canada): daily and weekly newspapers with a circulation of 7,000 + ; AM and FM radio stations broadcasting at 5kws in top 20 markets; television stations (all news stations, TV networks, cable) all black publications; Hispanic publications.

The Public Information staff person now has an inventory of ½" cassettes, suitable for home VCRs, containing all our P.S.A.s. These cassettes are sent out upon request as an additional tool to help TV stations and P.I. committees become familiar with the contents of our P.S.A.s. We are gathering evaluations from media professionals and P.I. committees regarding updating the contents of our current P.S.A.s. A letter was mailed in November 1996 to all area and other P.I. committee chairpeople to encourage the use of radio and TV P.S.A.s in P.I. Twelfth Step work. A single-page P.I. service piece has been prepared and was distributed with the November mailing to help local committees set up P.S.A. contacts at local TV and radio stations.

We respond to requests from newspaper and magazine professionals for information about Alcoholics Anonymous or information on subjects related to alcoholism. We refer questions not directly related to Alcoholics Anonymous to the appropriate sources. We also review movie, television and radio scripts to see that references to Alcoholics Anonymous are accurate and in keeping with our Traditions. We also decline to comment on many "hot" issues in keeping with our Tradition of not entering into public controversy. Alcoholics Anonymous is unique in that Public Information often succeeds when we do *not* get media attention.

Valerie O'Neill

SPANISH SERVICES

Staff report: Throughout the years, G.S.O. has provided services in several languages, including Spanish. But it was not until 1984 that the assignment of Spanish Services was formally initiated. In our general service structure there are more than 40,000 Spanish-speaking A.A. members. They meet in 1,500 groups in the U.S., Puerto Rico and Canada. The Spanish Services staff person, who does not rotate, coordinates and revises Spanish translations of material from the other staff assignments and assists other staff members in providing services to the Spanish-speaking community which are as equal as possible to the services provided to English-speaking A.A. groups. All Spanish-speaking

groups receive *Box 4-5-9* in Spanish. The General Service Board's *Quarterly Report* is also distributed in Spanish, and a list of preliminary and final Conference Agenda items is distributed in Spanish to all delegates and alternate delegates.

As more bilingual people come into A.A., communication between the Spanish- and English-speaking groups is improving; the groups are represented by G.S.R.s at district meetings, where they elect bilingual D.C.M.s who represent the districts at area assemblies. Many Spanish-speaking districts have been added recently to the areas in our service structure. Service material is translated into Spanish and kept up-to-date. More and more Conference-approved literature is published in Spanish by our Publications Department. The Spanish Services staff member helps answer the correspondence received in Spanish by most other assignments and especially by the International assignment. The staff member on this assignment represents G.S.O. at the Ibero-American Commission for Translation and Adaptation of A.A. literature and attends conventions, Hispanic intergroup meetings, Regional Forums, the World Service Meeting and the International Convention, as well as greeting Spanish-speaking visitors to G.S.O.

Danny Mooney

STAFF COORDINATOR

Staff report: Services to A.A. groups and members are provided through ten staff assignments. In addition to assuming the responsibility for a functional assignment, staff members correspond with groups and members in a specific region of the U.S. and Canada, as well as with A.A.s in overseas countries. Staff members rotate assignments every two years; assignments are monitored by the staff coordinator. E-mail numbers have been added to staff assignments and are available to the Fellowship upon request. The staff is divided into three units so that G.S.O. mail is processed and responded to as soon as possible. Unit A consists of P.I., C.P.C., C.F., and T.F. Unit B includes coordinators of Staff, Conference, Regional Forums/Group Services. Unit C is made up of Overseas, Literature and Spanish Services coordinators. The International Convention assignment works parallel to all of the other units.

In 1996, G.S.O. staff received approximately 16,780 pieces of mail, and the staff coordinator ensures that mail is handled when staff members are involved with large projects, and in times of sickness and vacation. Weekly staff meetings are chaired by the staff coordinator; at these, discussion centers on problems that require direction from the group conscience, and more and better ways of providing service to A.A. groups and members. The staff coordinator maintains a calendar of required staff trips to area assemblies/conventions, making sure that the office is adequately covered at all times, and also serves as a liaison between staff members and other G.S.O. departments.

In 1996, four longtime staff members took early retirement, which created new staff vacancies. For the staff openings, a letter

Gary Miller (Mississippi) related that when his plane stopped in Atlanta former President Jimmy Carter got on and graciously walked through the plane, greeting passengers and shaking hands.

Gary also reports that he now holds a new service job in his group — "butt picker." He goes around with a can picking up cigarette butts, and "it's becoming an important job."



was sent out to trustees, directors and delegates announcing vacancies and briefly describing the requirements for the job. The information was also posted in *Box 4-5-9*. Six years of sobriety is a requirement for a G.S.O. staff member. Business experience, excellent communication skills, A.A. service experience are among the criteria used in the selection process. Several hundred applicants sent in resumes and three new staff were hired. The staff coordinator helped in new staff orientation and training.

During 1996, staff attended a total of 90 conventions, assemblies, roundups and Regional Forums in the U.S. and Canada. These weekend events provide an opportunity to communicate about G.S.O. services, to meet A.A.s throughout the U.S. and Canada and to receive information that can be shared with other groups.

In the past year, approximately 1,365 visitors from around the world came to G.S.O. Each visitor has the opportunity to tour the G.S.O. and Grapevine offices, learning about the services to the Fellowship. Often visiting members and guests attend the weekly A.A. meeting held at G.S.O. at 11:00 a.m. on most Fridays.

As assistant secretary of the General Service Board, the staff coordinator is responsible for scheduling committee meetings, distributing advance materials, preparing the minutes of the General Service Board meetings and also serves as editor of the *Quarterly Report*, the summary of the boards' activities.

The staff coordinator is a voting member of the General Service Conference, and serves as secretary of the Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions. In accordance with Concept IV, the staff coordinator is also a director of A.A. World Services, Inc.

None of the activities would be possible without the help of a most able staff assistant working with the staff coordinator. We have a good workable team in order to get the job done. It has always been a privilege to serve the A.A. Fellowship.

Susan Ulseth

TREATMENT FACILITIES

Trustees' committee: The purpose of the trustees' Committee on Treatment Facilities is to "... further the acceptance of A.A. in hospitals, rehabilitation centers, and similar facilities and to bring additional help to alcoholics under treatment there." (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. S123.) Consequently, the way in which the A.A. message is finally heard by alcoholics in treatment facilities is a matter of concern, attention and development by the committee.

Since the 1996 Conference, our committee has met three times. We reviewed the Composition, Scope and Procedure. Following through with Conference recommendations, we completed work on a softcover Treatment Facilities Handbook and a concise, streamlined version of the existing Treatment Facilities Workbook (three-ring binder). This material was forwarded to the 1997 Conference Treatment Facilities Committee. We approved, with minor changes, the message to professionals for the Web Site.

The committee also reviewed additional Conference T.F. Committee considerations and suggested a letter be sent to area Treatment Facilities chairpersons asking for their input on the following: (1) How has the number of treatment facilities meetings changed in your area, district, etc.—increased or decreased and by what percent? (2) How have changes in treatment facilities affected your committee's Twelfth Step work in A.A. meetings? (3) How have treatment facilities changes affected sponsorship, temporary contact programs or bridging the gap efforts? (4) Any other changes in treatment facilities work you would like to share with us?

A subcommittee was formed to collect information regarding new trends in treatment facilities. Suggestions were made to contact the Association of Treatment Facilities Administrators, talk to treatment facilities organizations, and look into increases in residential and outpatient after-care. These findings would result in a

written report to be forwarded to the 1997 Conference Treatment Facilities Committee. The subcommittee submitted a report on collected material from area Treatment Facilities committees, as well as from professional agencies that responded to questionnaires. The information was summarized as follows:

- Due to changes in health care delivery systems and insurance reimbursement, there is limited inpatient treatment of alcoholics.
- Length of time in residential facilities has decreased.
- Increasing number of treatment episodes, but definition of treatment episodes has changed from several weeks of residential inpatient to include outpatient counseling sessions.
- Alcoholism treatment facilities have declined and substance abuse treatment facilities have increased.
- General decline in nonprofit, local and state funded programs.

The committee forwarded the subcommittee report on *The Changing Landscape of Treatment Facilities* to the 1997 Conference Treatment Facilities Committee and to area Treatment Facilities, Bridging the Gap and H&I chairpersons for discussion. Having reviewed both the "Bridging the Gap" and "A.A. in Treatment Facilities" pamphlets, the committee noted no necessary changes in the pamphlet "A.A. in Treatment Facilities" and suggested, if feasible, to print the last page of the "Bridging the Gap" pamphlet on a separate sheet. We also discussed adding material to the Treatment Facilities Workbook on Twelfth Stepping "wet drunks" and felt that there was no need to add anything more on Twelfth Step work.

The annual letter to Treatment Facility Administrators was reviewed, and it was decided to send the letter with the 1996 Membership Survey and a single-sheet attachment to include information on our primary purpose, nonaffiliation and anonymity; the letter will also be sent to treatment professionals. We also suggested the development and utilization of a new treatment facility mailing list.

Following much discussion, the report on background regarding Service Kits and Workbooks for C.P.C., C.F., P.I. and T.F. was accepted and forwarded to the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee for consideration.

In response to our request for information on trends in treatment facilities, our professional friends confirmed many of the impressions given by area treatment chairpersons. As the number of inpatient alcoholism treatment programs decreases, the committee discussed the need for more creative and collaborative efforts in reaching and working with the alcoholic, where they are. Temporary Contact/Bridging the Gap programs have emerged as an essential tool for Twelfth Step work, introducing the newcomer to Alcoholics Anonymous and helping alcoholics in treatment recover through the A.A. program.

Peter Roach, chairperson

Staff report: The primary purpose of the Treatment Facilities assignment is to provide material to assist the service work of local A.A. members who wish to carry the A.A. message to alcoholics in treatment. We now have about 97 area Treatment Facilities chairpersons, 422 district Treatment Facilities chairpersons, and 78 "Other" Treatment Facilities chairpersons. We try to keep an up-to-date list of the chairs of these committees and to provide them with considerable information and literature. In order to carry the message "inside," the A.A. mem-

ber often meets with the administrators and personnel in many different kinds of treatment settings. He or she must become familiar with the rules and regulations of the facility and be willing to comply with them. As an oldtimer once said, "If we can't get in, we can't carry the message!" The local A.A. member also offers to provide information about A.A. groups in the patient's hometown and encourages active participation upon leaving the facility. This is called "bridging the gap."

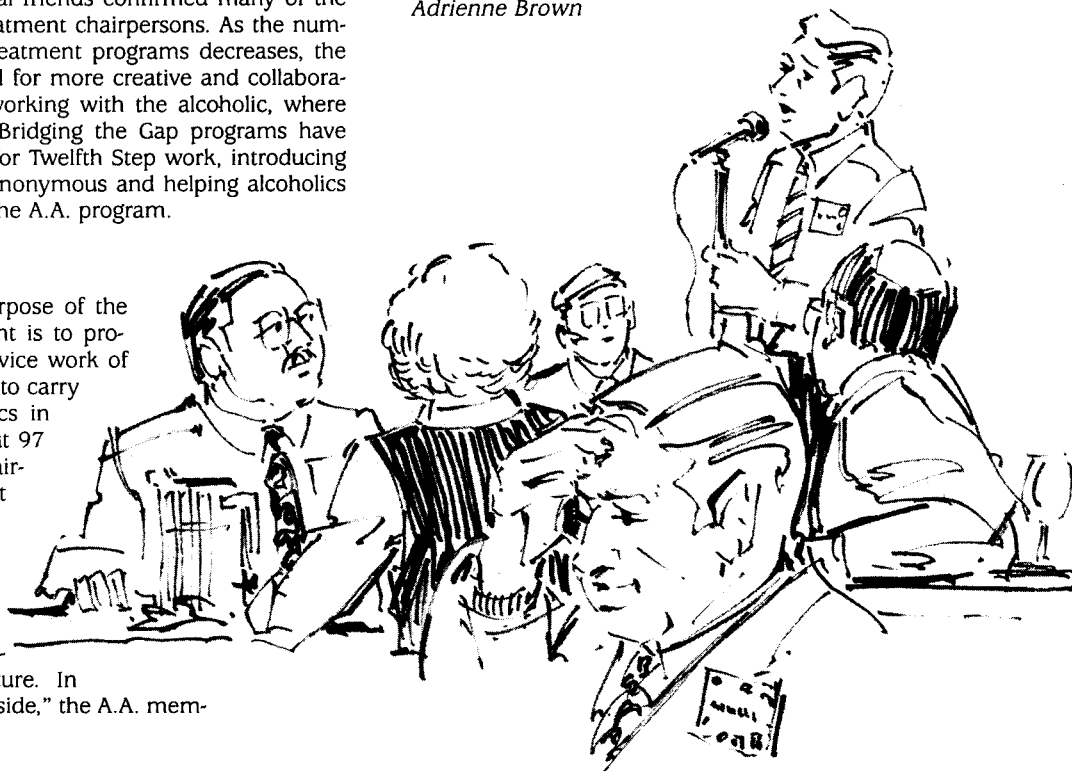
If a treatment center wants A.A. and "bridging the gap" information, the presenter makes clear the purpose of A.A. The video "Hope: Alcoholics Anonymous" is often shown to treatment center staff as well as to patients and continues to be a useful tool. Helping a newcomer just out of treatment get settled into a regular home group is the essence of Twelfth Step work.

A Treatment Facilities Workbook is sent to all area, district and other chairpeople. This workbook is a comprehensive guide about carrying the message "inside." It contains shared experienced, suggestions, general information, guidelines and literature. Treatment Facilities chairpersons receive *Box 4-5-9, About A.A.* and a current list of the 97 chairs in the U.S. and Canada. All chairs have copies of the U.S. and Canada Directory of intergroups and central offices for referral purposes.

Inquiries come to the Treatment Facilities desk via letter, telephone, fax and e-mail, from four sources: (1) newly sober alcoholics in treatment facilities; (2) local A.A.s who have become or are interested in becoming active on treatment facilities committees; (3) treatment facilities administrators or personnel requesting information about A.A. and assistance in setting up meetings; and (4) area treatment facilities committees' meeting minutes and reports.

In addition, another major staff activity entails serving as secretary to both trustees' and Conference Committees on Treatment Facilities. Responsibilities in this area include responding to mail from committee members, helping to prepare agendas for committee meetings, preparing background material and preparing minutes at the conclusion of meetings. The staff member also gathers material for an occasional treatment Facilities article in *Box 4-5-9*.

Adrienne Brown



Reports from the A.A. Grapevine

Directors' report: The twelve-month span of time since the 46th General Service Conference has been an active and challenging one for the A.A. Grapevine Board and staff. Two new nontrustee directors came aboard, a new executive editor took office, a magazine price increase was put into effect, and an entirely new A.A. magazine (La Viña) was brought to life. In addition, there has been an upswing of interest internationally in materials published and copyrighted by the A.A. Grapevine which has required ongoing clarification and implementation of the established policies of the board regarding translation, reprinting, and distribution of Grapevine materials. Throughout this period, the board has also maintained a consistent focus on matters relating to Grapevine circulation, corporate governance and composition of the board, and advancing technology which might be useful to the Grapevine as we approach the year 2000.

Circulation and Price Increase: On April 1, 1996, a subscription price increase went into effect on the Grapevine magazine and a new price schedule was drawn up which incorporated some cost-saving options, including modest discounts for bulk subscriptions, a three-year subscription term, and the opportunity for subscribers to take advantage of a special one-time rate by renewing before August 1, 1996. In addition, starting with the May issue, the magazine expanded to 64 pages in an effort to provide a higher quality product for readers. Reaction to all these measures has been generally positive and though circulation has dropped incrementally throughout the year, the large circulation dips which followed former price increases have not occurred.

Finance—Year-End Results: The Grapevine loss on operations for 1996 amounted to \$188,227 as compared to a budgeted loss of \$93,000. These year-end figures were fairly close to the revised projections reviewed by the board and the trustees' Finance Committee at mid-year, when some concern was expressed regarding lower than anticipated sales for the Grapevine's related materials. While sales did pick up through the last quarter, by year's end the Grapevine experienced an overall drop of \$25,000 in the gross profit on Other Publishing Income. In addition, in order to comply with acceptable accounting principles, \$20,000 of excess inventory had to be written off, principally related to copies of "The Home Group" booklet which were printed for the International Convention but did not sell. Adding further to the deficit was an increase over budget for salaries and benefits based on the office restructuring plan which was approved by the board in March 1995, amounting to \$40,000.

The loss on operations for La Viña was \$138,290 as compared to a \$98,000 budgeted loss. While circulation was higher than the 6,000 copies budgeted, ending the year at greater than 8,000 copies, expenses were also higher than anticipated, principally in the areas of personnel and mailing cost. The original business plan projected only one salary (the editor of Spanish resources), though in actuality it was necessary to include a full-time clerical worker to process the circulation and accounting information and supply the necessary data-entry and customer service functions. In addition, the first three issues of the magazine were mailed using first-class postage in order to ensure postal updates and address changes in an effort to generate as clean a mailing list as possible.

1997 Budget: In January, the board approved and forwarded to the trustees' Finance Committee a budget for 1997 which anticipates a loss of \$60,262. The budget includes a decrease in circulation from the average 1996 circulation of 128,360 to an annual 1997 average of 126,350. This projected drop can still be attributed to the magazine price increase, as subscriptions ordered at the old price come due for renewal in the next few months.

The board also reviewed a 1997 budget for La Viña which projected a loss of \$97,809. After considerable discussion, the budget was approved and passed on to the trustees' Finance Committee with the understanding that the theoretical framework of the original business plan needed to be revised in light of actual experience, and that such a revised plan would be presented to the trustees' Finance Committee in July.

Board and Management Structure: As part of the ongoing board discussion regarding the question of corporate governance, the board opted not to fill the staff director position left open by Ann Warner's retirement in April 1996, leaving the number of directors currently at nine. In addition, after reviewing and discussing a plan for reorganization of the Grapevine office presented by executive editor Ames Sweet, the board endorsed the plan unanimously. Central to the reorganization plan were the promotions of Bob Slotterback to the position of assistant controller and Cynthia Keyworth to the position of senior editor. In addition, an editor of Spanish resources and a circulation manager began in April and May, respectively.

In November, after interviewing a number of highly qualified candidates, the board forwarded the name of David Every to the trustees' Nominating Committee for the position of nontrustee director on the Grapevine board, and put forward the name of Tom Maguire for the position of general service trustee.

Update on Grapevine Business Plan: The board reviewed and accepted an update to the Grapevine Business Plan which was prepared by management and originally accepted by the board in April 1995. The update presented a project status report, an evaluation of Grapevine's current situation, and a commentary on proposed strategies to reach the following three-year goals: a) Expand Circulation Base; b) Introduce New Technology Wherever Appropriate; c) Enhance Grapevine's Responsiveness to the Fellowship; d) Contain Costs, Maintain Gross Margins, Increase Volume; e) Increase Communication with Overseas Service Structures.

La Viña: In April 1995, when the Conference gave its approval for the idea of a Spanish Grapevine and the trustees' Finance Committee reviewed a business plan from Grapevine management, the Grapevine office had to put together a working structure and assemble a set of procedures for ongoing publication of the Spanish magazine that were theoretical in nature. With no real history of publishing Spanish-language materials or communicating directly with the Spanish-speaking A.A. community, there were a number of challenges that had to be overcome. With nearly a year's worth of actual experience now in hand, however, both the board and staff are in a much better position to evaluate La Viña's progress and make more realistic assessments for the future. To this end, staff is currently revising the original business plan, based on actual experience, and will present this information to the board and the trustees' Finance Committee in July.

From a circulation standpoint, the news regarding La Viña is good, especially considering the original target goal for the first year of 6,000 copies and the actual circulation of over 8,000. Also, from an editorial standpoint, comments about the product itself have been overwhelmingly positive. There are currently about 125 Spanish Grapevine Representatives (GvRs), and as the Spanish-speaking A.A. community around the world continues to embrace the magazine, circulation will continue to grow.

One of the first critical junctures for La Viña is just on the horizon, however, as many of the initial subscriptions come due for renewal. If we can keep the subscribers we already have, continue to add new ones, and start getting the magazine into the hands of suffering alcoholics who need it, La Viña stands a good chance of fulfilling its enormous promise.

International Activity: For the first time, the Grapevine took part in the World Service Meeting, held in New York in October 1996, with a session on A.A. magazines and newsletters moderated by executive editor, Ames Sweet. Presentations were made during the session by the delegates from New Zealand, El Salvador, and Norway, and covered topics describing how the A.A. magazines in those countries operate. In addition, the corporate board hosted 27 World Service Meeting delegates at the November board meeting and were gratified by their active interest and participation in the meeting.

The board has had a number of discussions throughout the year regarding the feasibility of the Grapevine utilizing monies from the International Literature Fund of the World Service Meeting, which is administered by A.A.W.S., in order to undertake translations of Grapevine materials, most notably *The Language of the Heart*. No conclusions have been reached and the discussion is ongoing.

Over the last year, interest has been expressed by Mexico, El Salvador, and Colombia regarding publication in those countries of the Grapevine's Spanish translation of *The Language of the Heart*, and the board has updated its policies and procedures related to translation, reprinting, and distribution of Grapevine materials. After a visit to the Grapevine's counterpart in Mexico (their A.A. magazine is called Plenitud), Grapevine was able to provide original mechanicals of our translation at a minimal expense from which the Mexican General Service Office was able to publish their own edition of *El Lenguaje del Corazón*. Similar discussions are now underway with the General Service Offices in Colombia and El Salvador and Grapevine staff is trying to determine the most cost-effective and technologically proficient way to supply the text to these countries.

Canadian Warehousing and Drop-Shipping: After many years of discussion, Grapevine management was finally able to secure a Canadian distribution point for the magazine to go along with the warehouse Grapevine shares with A.A.W.S. in Ontario for storage and packaging of Canadian pick-pack orders. There are currently more than 10,000 Canadian magazine subscriptions, and these orders are now being shipped in bulk directly from the printer to the new location in Winnipeg, where they are inserted into envelopes and entered directly into the Canadian mails. So far, reports indicate this has significantly reduced the delivery time, and Grapevine management has been able to reduce the pricing level on bulk subscriptions to reflect the cost savings Grapevine has been able to achieve.

The Grapevine on the Internet: The board discussed the possibility of the Grapevine establishing a presence on the Internet and agreed that the Grapevine should develop a Grapevine Web Site independent of the site maintained by A.A.W.S. Initially the site could include some general information about the Grapevine and the Grapevine's e-mail address for further contact. Based on budgetary constraints, however, it was understood that such plans might not get underway until late 1997 or early 1998. The board also discussed a report by Greg Tobin on current technology, particularly in relation to desktop publishing, and determined that while the Grapevine's set-up is adequate, we should continue to stay abreast of new developments in the field.

Conference Business: After a full review by the board, a draft of the proposed pamphlet on the Grapevine was approved for forwarding to the Conference Grapevine Committee for their consideration at the 1997 Conference. In addition, the board reviewed a list of related-item ideas for possible production in 1999, along with new text related to La Viña for the next edition of *The A.A. Service Manual*, and forwarded both items on to the Conference Grapevine Committee.

GRAPEVINE CIRCULATION — GEOGRAPHIC BREAKDOWN

	CIRCULATION		INCREASE/ DECREASE
	APRIL 1997	APRIL 1996	
UNITED STATES			
Alabama	1,169	1,367	— 198
Alaska	562	571	— 9
Arizona	1,742	1,891	— 149
Arkansas	681	677	4
California	11,921	12,694	— 773
Colorado	1,792	1,751	41
Connecticut	1,975	2,061	— 86
Delaware	488	457	31
District of Columbia	250	284	— 34
Florida	6,159	6,288	— 129
Georgia	2,783	3,010	— 227
Hawaii	497	517	— 20
Idaho	547	594	— 47
Illinois	4,940	5,291	— 351
Indiana	1,823	1,892	— 69
Iowa	1,409	1,485	— 76
Kansas	1,489	1,569	— 80
Kentucky	1,111	1,258	— 147
Louisiana	1,089	1,165	— 76
Maine	772	891	— 119
Maryland	1,687	1,861	— 174
Massachusetts	3,716	3,849	— 133
Michigan	3,693	3,743	— 50
Minnesota	2,953	3,101	— 148
Mississippi	736	790	— 54
Missouri	2,041	2,227	— 186
Montana	654	664	— 10
Nebraska	1,210	1,345	— 135
Nevada	660	693	— 33
New Hampshire	764	756	8
New Jersey	3,319	3,521	— 202
New Mexico	684	709	— 25
New York	7,687	7,981	— 294
North Carolina	2,733	2,929	— 196
North Dakota	474	508	— 34
Ohio	3,522	3,691	— 169
Oklahoma	1,323	1,474	— 151
Oregon	1,365	1,373	— 8
Pennsylvania	5,203	5,403	— 200
Rhode Island	529	539	— 10
South Carolina	1,294	1,322	— 28
South Dakota	498	503	— 5
Tennessee	1,548	1,618	— 70
Texas	5,302	5,479	— 177
Utah	646	683	— 37
Vermont	425	476	— 51
Virginia	2,552	2,748	— 196
Washington	3,324	3,537	— 213
West Virginia	516	535	— 19
Wisconsin	2,853	2,976	— 123
Wyoming	339	350	— 11
Puerto Rico	69	87	— 18
U.S. Possessions	93	86	7
Subtotal U.S.	107,611	113,270	—5,659
CANADA			
Alberta/NWT	1,131	1,274	— 143
British Columbia/Y'kn	1,346	1,655	— 309
Manitoba	459	484	— 25
New Brunswick/ Prince Edward Island	465	566	— 101
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	651	793	— 142
Ontario	3,503	4,212	— 709
Quebec	329	419	— 90
Saskatchewan	660	760	— 100
Subtotal Canadian	8,544	10,163	—1,619
FOREIGN	1,668	1,799	— 131
Grand Total	117,823	125,232	—7,409

(exclusive of monthly orders)

(exclusive of monthly orders)

Service Activity: The Grapevine has participated in three Regional Forums in the last year: in Salt Lake City, Utah for the Pacific region; Sherbrooke, Ontario for the Eastern Canada region; and Asheville, North Carolina for the Southeast region. The Grapevine also participated in the 14th Annual Intergroup/Central Office Seminar in Minneapolis, Minnesota in November, along with representatives from the General Service Office and A.A.W.S., Inc. In December, the circulation manager attended a Spanish district meeting, hosted by the Grapevine committee in Sacramento, California, and in January, the editor of Spanish resources attended a Spanish district meeting in Manhattan. Also in January, Ames Sweet and Jaime Manrique attended a meeting of the Southeast New York Area's Spanish committee, which consists of all the Spanish D.C.M.s, in order to clarify some questions about La Viña.

Other Board Business: Immediately following the 46th Conference, the Grapevine Board met to elect officers, and incoming (now outgoing) chairperson, Chuck Crist, appointed Larry Nelson as chair of the Grapevine Nominating Committee and appointed Ray Stiver to the Employees Retirement Committee. The board also reconstituted the circulation task force subcommittee, with Tom Maguire as chairperson, and including Ray Stiver, Gregory Tobin, and Ames Sweet.

After many years of discussion by management, the corporate board, General Service Board, the Grapevine auditors, and the General Service Conference itself, the Grapevine Financial Statements have now been changed to classify interest income from Cash Flow and the Reserve Fund as income from operations. Also, in September, after discussion with the auditors, the Grapevine made a change in the calculation of the value of the magazines transferred from the Unfulfilled Subscription Liability to Magazine Income. This change was necessary to reflect the current prices of the magazines mailed.

In June, the board heard a detailed financial presentation on the budgetary impact of the Wall Calendars and Pocket Planners and decided to endorse their production for 1997. It was the consensus to produce the Wall Calendar in full color again and a suggestion was considered to set up the Pocket Planner to run from Monday to Sunday in order to keep the weekends together and allow for contiguous scheduling of A.A. and other events which take place on the weekends.

In July the board reviewed a "Position Statement" prepared by the Editorial Advisory Board, and welcomed publication of an article about the Grapevine in the General Service Office bulletin, *About A.A.*—a newsletter for professionals.

Chuck Crist, chairperson

Staff report: The primary mission of the A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is to publish a magazine that shares the experience, strength and hope of a wide variety of individual A.A. members around the world, and expresses current thinking in the Fellowship on matters affecting recovery, unity and service. Bill W. described the Grapevine's role early on when he wrote that the magazine's central purpose was "to carry the A.A. message to alcoholics and practice the A.A. principles in all our affairs." The Grapevine, he wrote, would be "the voice of the Alcoholics Anonymous movement. Its editors and staff will be primarily accountable to the A.A. movement as a whole. . . . Within the bounds of friendliness and good taste, the Grapevine will enjoy perfect freedom of speech on all matters directly pertaining to Alcoholics Anonymous. . . ." The principles of autonomy and diversity have continued to guide the magazine for nearly 53 years.

The Grapevine is managed by the executive editor who has oversight responsibility as chief executive and reports directly to

the Grapevine Corporate Board. A nonalcoholic controller/business administrator manages financial and accounting functions. There are four major areas of operations: editorial, circulation, accounting/bookkeeping and shipping.

The editorial department, managed by the executive editor, consists of a senior editor, Spanish resources editor, executive secretary, and an editorial assistant. The department produces the monthly Grapevine magazine, the bimonthly Spanish-language magazine *La Viña*, all related materials (anthologies, audio cassette tapes, etc.), flyers and order forms, the GvR News and related GvR materials, pamphlets and workbooks about the Grapevine, and the annual wall calendar and pocket planner. Virtually all materials are designed in-house, using the Grapevine's desktop publishing capability. The department also answers all editorial queries and processes several hundred manuscript submissions every month.

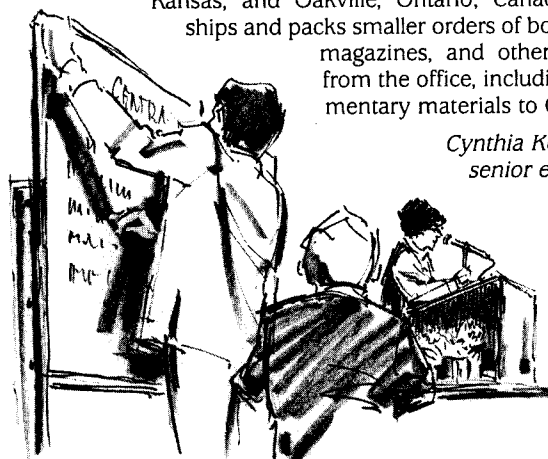
Several important changes have taken place in the editorial department in the past year: the Grapevine magazine has increased to 64 pages, allowing the magazine to offer more experience, strength and hope in every issue, and *La Viña* was launched and has produced its first five issues for a subscriber base of over 8,000 readers.

In 1996, a new circulation manager, was hired to help with circulation strategies for both the English-language and Spanish-language ventures. The circulation department maintains subscriber and donor lists. In 1996, it processed 26,267 new subscriptions and 74,049 renewals, as well as almost 11,000 changes of address. Circulation also prepares mailing labels for the magazine, creates summary reports and analyses, and oversees the shipment of postal forms, custom papers, and labels to the two subscription fulfillment centers, one in Mechanicsburg, Pennsylvania, and one in Winnipeg, Manitoba, out of which Canadian orders are now being shipped. A series of our renewal notices are prepared monthly for those whose subscriptions are about to lapse and are forwarded to the Subscription Fulfillment Service Center in Pennsylvania.

The bookkeeping department opens and distributes all incoming mail. Manuscripts, letters to the editor, calendar of events items, reprint requests, and matters requiring the editors' attention go to the editorial department. Both cash and credit card orders, for subscriptions and related materials, are sorted into categories for processing. In 1996, the Grapevine processed about 140,000 orders. The administrative unit of bookkeeping maintains employee payroll and administers employee benefits programs. The controller, as part of this unit, is responsible for the safeguarding of all corporate assets. He maintains control over all books of accounts, prepares statements of financial operations, and prepares the annual budgets.

The shipping department arranges for inventory transfers to and from warehouse distribution centers in Kansas City, Kansas, and Oakville, Ontario, Canada. It also ships and packs smaller orders of books, tapes, magazines, and other materials from the office, including complimentary materials to GvRs.

*Cynthia Keyworth,
senior editor*



Literature Distributed - 1996

ENGLISH

Books

Alcoholics Anonymous	451,616
Alcoholics Anonymous (soft cover)	391,143
Alcoholics Anonymous (large print)	21,158
Alcoholics Anonymous (pocket abridged)	99,629
Daily Reflections	138,905
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (reg. ed.)	202,775
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (gift ed.)	25,897
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (soft cover)	160,508
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (large print)	9,660
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (pocket ed.)	43,761
A.A. Comes of Age	14,429
As Bill Sees It	64,615
Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers	14,124
"Pass It On"	14,443
Total	1,652,763

Booklets

The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service	35,571
Living Sober	166,255
Came to Believe	87,425
A.A. in Prisons: Inmate to Inmate	26,436
Total	315,687

Pamphlets

A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs	11,079
A.A. and the Armed Services	4,605
A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic	33,931
A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional	16,628
A.A. for the Native North American	17,015
A.A. for the Woman	106,834
The A.A. Group	71,458
A.A. in Your Community	21,907
A.A. in Correctional Facilities	18,468
A.A. in Treatment Facilities	26,342
The A.A. Membership Survey	24,250
The A.A. Member - Medications and Other Drugs	91,774
A.A. Tradition - How It Developed	29,603
A.A.'s Legacy of Service	9,032
A Brief Guide to Alcoholics Anonymous	116,711
Circles of Love and Service	22,374
Bridging the Gap	23,759
Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.	14,655
The Co-Founders of Alcoholics Anonymous	15,876
Do You Think You're Different?	120,617
44 Questions	202,406
G.S.R.	34,308
How A.A. Members Cooperate	13,465
How It Works	66,276
If You Are a Professional	18,330
Inside A.A.	44,787
Is A.A. for You?	281,989
Is A.A. for Me?	114,235
Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?	89,221
It Happened to Alice	46,035
It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell	52,598
The Jack Alexander Article	25,099
Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends	11,017

Letter to a Woman Alcoholic	83,518
A Member's-Eye View of A.A.	54,633
Memo to an Inmate Who May Be an Alcoholic	48,334
A Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators	8,152
A Newcomer Asks	288,730
Problems Other Than Alcohol	123,828
Questions and Answers on Sponsorship	282,588
Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings	14,644
The Twelve Concepts for World Service Illustrated	14,965
The Twelve Steps Illustrated	84,457
The Twelve Traditions Illustrated	42,035
This Is A.A.	242,340
Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W.	18,374
Time to Start Living	59,768
Time to Start Living (large print)	9,139
Too Young?	83,267
Understanding Anonymity	66,443
What Happened to Joe	50,880
Young People and A.A.	117,249
Total	3,490,028

Miscellaneous

Wallet cards-two-fold	492,090
Wallet cards-I Am Responsible	64,790
Wallet cards-Anonymity	37,894
Anonymity Display Card	3,625
Parchment-scrolls	2,455
Placards	393
C.P.C. Workbook	1,757
Correctional Facilities Workbook	1,546
P.I. Workbook	1,636
Treatment Facilities Workbook	360
A.A. Guidelines	50,273
Group Handbook	2,978
Wire Racks	2,114
Cassettes (tape cassettes)	2,759
Alcoholics Anonymous (cassette album)	5,165
A.A. Comes of Age (cassette album)	558
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (cassette album)	2,439
TV Public Service Announcement	228
Radio Public Service Announcements	362
Twelve Steps Shade displays	2,030
Twelve Traditions Shade displays	1,872
Fact Files	3,454
Table Top Display 12 & 12	637
Total	681,415
Grand Total	6,139,893

SPANISH

Books

Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous soft cover)	27,405
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous hardcover)	3,855
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous abridged pocket size)	4,788
Como Lo Ve Bill (As Bill Sees It)	6,199
A.A. Llega a su Mayoría de Edad (A.A. Comes of Age)	3,238
El Dr. Bob y los Buenos Veteranos (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	2,160
Reflexiones Diarias (Daily Reflections)	6,728
Total	54,373

Booklets

Viviendo Sobrio (Living Sober)	15,165
El Manual de Servicios de A.A./Doce Conceptos para el Servicio Mundial (A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts)	2,230
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions)	26,000
Llegamos a Creer (Came to Believe)	7,054
A.A. en Prisiones de Preso a Preso (Inmate to Inmate)	5,509
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (pocket ed.)	4,025
Total	59,983

Pamphlets

A.A. en Su Comunidad (A.A. in Your Community)	10,420
44 Preguntas (44 Questions)	25,800
Esto es A.A. (This is A.A.)	27,851
Es A.A. para Usted? (Is A.A. for You?)	52,934
Carta a una Mujer Alcohólica (Letter to a Woman Alcoholic)	7,688
Hay un Alcohólico en su Vida? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	8,292
Carta a un Preso que Puede Ser Un Alcohólico (Memo to an Inmate)	7,009
El Punto de Vista de un Miembro de A.A. (A Member's-Eye View)	3,293
Alcohólicos Anónimos por Jack Alexander (Jack Alexander Article)	3,622
Tres Charlas a Sociedades Medicas por Bill W. (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	3,415
Un Principiante Pregunta (A Newcomer Asks)	10,343
Como Trabaja el Programa (How It Works)	7,365
Lo que le Sucedió a José (What Happened to Joe)	7,814
Comprendiendo el Anonimato (Understanding Anonymity)	2,914
El Grupo de A.A. (The A.A. Group)	6,901
Preguntas y Respuestas sobre el Apadrinamiento (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	8,581
El Miembro de A.A. - Los Medicamentos y Otras Drogas (The A.A. Member - Medications and Other Drugs)	5,712
Las Doce Tradiciones Ilustradas (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	4,807
A.A. en Centros de Tratamiento (A.A. in Treatment Centers)	2,908
Los Jóvenes y A.A. (Young People and A.A.)	10,575
La Tradición de A.A. - ¿Cómo se Desarrolló? (A.A. Tradition - How It Developed)	2,136
Una Breve Guía a A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	7,298
A.A. en las Instituciones Correccionales (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	1,849
Problemas Diferentes del Alcohol (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	8,309
Es Mejor que Estar Sentado en una Celda (It Sure Beats Sitting In a Cell)	7,547
¿Cómo Cooperan los Miembros de A.A.? (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	1,624
Dentro de A.A. (Inside A.A.)	2,573
A.A. como Recurso para los Profesionales de la Salud (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	2,168
Un Ministro Religioso Pregunta Acerca de A.A. (The Clergy Asks)	1,985
R.S.G. (G.S.R.)	2,059

¿Se Cree Usted Diferente? (Do You Think Your Different?)	8,167
Le Sucedió a Alicia (It Happened to Alice)	5,820
Hablando en Reuniones no-A.A. Speaking at non-A.A. Meetings	2,302
A.A. Para la Mujer (A.A. for the Woman)	8,304
Encuesta Sobre los Miembros de A.A. (A.A. Membership Survey)	1,009
A.A. y los Programas de Alcoholismo Empresariales (A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs)	1,454
Es A.A. Para Mi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	6,372
Tiempo Para Empezar a Vivir (Time to Start Living)	3,685
Los Doce Pasos Ilustrados (The Twelve Steps Illustrated)	7,548
Total	300,453

Miscellaneous

Guías (Guidelines)	5,946
Parchments, Spanish	494
Tarjetas Tamaño Billetera (wallet cards)	11,188
Alcohólicos Anónimos (cassette album) (Big Book on cassette)	477
Los Doce Pasos (cassette album) (Twelve Steps on cassette)	839
Total	18,944
Grand Total	433,753

FRENCH

Books

Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous - format relie)	4,090
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous - format souple)	2,952
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous - format poche)	4,965
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve - format relie)	1,728
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve - format souple)	2,513
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve - format poche)	4,050
Le Mouvement des A.A. devient Adulte (A.A. Comes of Age)	705
Reflexions de Bill (As Bill Sees It)	3,044
Reflexions Quotidiennes (Daily Reflections)	4,656
Dr Bob et les pionniers (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	3,412
Total	32,115

It's getting to be a tradition (small t)

Last year many of the delegates and trustees discovered the Stardust Diner (a New York-style deli featuring entertainment, singing and dancing) where all had a "high-time" after the Wednesday night session. Many repeated the entertaining evening this year, and Arnold Ross (Maryland) and Eddie McGee (Northern New Jersey) were easily the most memorable (tallest and shortest) couple on the dance floor.

Plaquettes (Booklets)

Nous en sommes venus a croire (Came to Believe)	2,027
Vivre ... sans alcool! (Living Sober)	2,800
Le Manuel du Service et les Douze Concepts	2,505
Total	7,332

Brochures (Pamphlets)

Voici les A.A. (This is A.A.)	17,815
Les A.A.: 44 Questions (44 Questions)	2,466
Les A.A.: sont-ils pour vous? (Is A.A. for You?)	23,215
Les A.A. pour la femme (A.A. for the Woman)	957
Collaboration des membres des A.A. (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	316
Les A.A. et les programmes d'aide aux employes (A.A. & Employee Assistance Programs)	469
Le membre des A.A. face aux medicaments et a la drogue (The A.A. Member - Medications & Other Drugs)	887
Les A.A. - Article du Saturday Evening Post (The Jack Alexander Article)	270
Collaborons avec nos amis (Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends)	164
Questions et reponses sur le parrainage (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	2,852
Les A.A.: Une ressource pour les medecins (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	401
Les A.A. dans les centres de traitement (A.A. in Treatment Facilities)	301
La Tradition des A.A. et son developpement (A.A. Tradition/How It Developed)	1,284
Vous vous occupez prof. d'alcoolisme? (If You Are a Professional)	647
L'Histoire de Nicole (It Happened to Alice)	449
Jean face a son probleme d'alcool (What Happened to Joe)	517
Les A.A. dans votre milieu (A.A. in Your Community)	1,741
Problemes autres que l'alcoolisme (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	1,845
Point de vue d'un membre sur les A.A. (A Member's-Eye View of A.A.)	624
Les Douze Traditions illustrees (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	1,394
Les A.A. dans les etablissements correctionnels (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	624
Ca vaut mieux que de languir en prison (It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell)	530
Petit guide pratique sur les A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	1,228
Les membres du clerge se renseignent (Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.)	596
Les deux fondateurs d'A.A. (The Co-founders of A.A.)	569
Message a l'intention d'un detenu (Memo to an Inmate)	970
Message aux Dir. d'Etabl. Correctionnels (Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators)	204
Le groupe des A.A. (The A.A. Group)	1,978
Les Douze Concepts illustres (Twelve Concepts Illustrated)	937
Le sens de l'anonymat (Understanding Anonymity)	964
Trois causeries a des societes medicales (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	403
Y-a-t-il un alcoolique dans votre vie? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	870
Le R.S.G. (The G.S.R.)	1,462

Causeries a l'exterieur des A.A. (Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings)	398
Trop jeune? (Too Young?)	1,329
La Structure de l'Association des A.A. (Inside A.A.)	1,398
L'Heritage des Services des A.A. (A.A.'s Legacy of Service)	352
Cercles d'amour et de service (Circles of Love & Service)	1,352
Vous croyez-vous different? (Do You Think You're Different?)	682
Lettre a une femme alcoolique (Letter to a Woman Alcoholic)	552
Sondage de 1992 sur les membres des A.A. (The A.A. Membership Survey)	768
Les jeunes et les A.A. (Young People & A.A.)	1,011
Votre B.S.G. (Your G.S.O.)	1,340
Il est encore temps de vivre (Time to Start Living)	644
Un nouveau veut savoir (A Newcomer Asks)	6,646
Les A.A. sont-ils pour moi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	640
Favoriser de rapprochement (Bridging the Gap)	223
Les Douze Etapes Illustrees (Twelve Steps Illustrated)	1,139
Les A.A. et les gais et lesbiennes alcooliques (A.A. for the Gay and Lesbian Alcoholic)	273
Les A.A. et les Autochtones d'Amerique du Nord (A.A. and the Native North American)	233
Total	88,919

Lignes de conduite A.A. (Guidelines)	Total	3,590
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Divers (Miscellaneous)

12 & 12 (cassette album)	176
Le Gros Livre (cassettes album)	124
Carte 12 Etapes/12 Traditions (Wallet card 12 Steps & 12 Traditions)	1,534
Carte anonymat (Francais/anglais) (Anonymity wallet card)	46
Cassettes	65
Notre Methode (How It Works)	17,168
Manuel de Groupe	74
Manuel de l'Information Publique	22
Manuel des Centres de Detention	15
Manuel de la CMP	6
Messages d'Interet Publique (Radio P.S.A.)	2
Priere Serenite (Carte) (Serenity Prayer wallet card)	19,176
Slogans (serie de 5) (Five A.A. Slogans)	231
Suggestions Reunions Debutants (Guide for Leading Beginners Meetings)	181
Manuel des Centres de Traitement	7
Dossier d'Information sur les A.A. (Fact File)	372
Total	39,199
Grand Total	171,155



Area Service Highlights

Alabama/NW Florida: Area 1 has 350 registered groups served by 22 districts, 16 of which are located in Alabama and six in the panhandle of NW Florida. We hold four assemblies a year; our annual convention rotates throughout the area. We have ten standing committees: Archives, Convention, C.P.C., Finance, P.I., T.F., C.F., Literature, Grapevine and Intergroup/Central Office Liaison. A G.S.R. workshop kicks off our assembly; other workshops are centered on Conference themes. Our meetings have been much smoother since we adopted guidelines reflective of how the Conference operates. In an effort to be better informed, our April assembly convenes just prior to the Conference to discuss agenda items. There has been much discussion lately about taxes, incorporation and interest-bearing accounts. These deliberations led to our taking an area inventory. We remain committed to our single purpose of insuring that our life-giving message will always be available to any who have a desire to stop drinking and try our way of life. — *Mike Wise*

Arkansas: Area 4 has 233 groups divided into 12 districts among the 75 counties. We have four (two-day) area assemblies a year held in a specific location. The C.P.C., P.I. and C.F. committees cooperate in conducting "court classes" in different towns. The T.F. committee not only carries meetings into the treatment centers, but also keeps an up-to-date Bridging the Gap contact list. The Convention committee is responsible for putting on the annual State convention, called "Old Grand Dad." The Archives committee is busy developing an A.A. history in Arkansas, and attempting to get recorded statements from early timers. We have had activity in locating and registering the Spanish-speaking A.A. meetings. We have a new office of registrar to handle group information changes. These activities and many more are witnesses that Arkansas is actively trying to carry the message to the alcoholic who still suffers, while practicing the Traditions and Concepts. — *Bill Reinhart*

British Columbia/Yukon: Area 79 covers almost 900,000 square miles. Of these the Yukon Territories covers almost a third, making it a district larger than most areas. Because of our size, travel expense is a large portion of our annual budget. Our groups appreciate the services we provide and respond well with contributions. Modern communication methods have enhanced our ability to reach the more remote communities. We have just set up an Internet Web page that highlights what is happening around the area. We share space for our area offices and our archives with the Vancouver Intergroup. Many of the committee members are connected to our office

through e-mail. Our quarterly meetings and annual assembly move around the area. We are pleased that the Western Region A.A. Service Assembly was revived this year in our neighboring area, and also enjoy taking part in PRAASA. The interaction between the areas in our region and our neighboring region has been a valuable learning experience for all. We enjoy and appreciate the challenges of carrying the message to our area and being a part of A.A. today. — *Ric Downey*

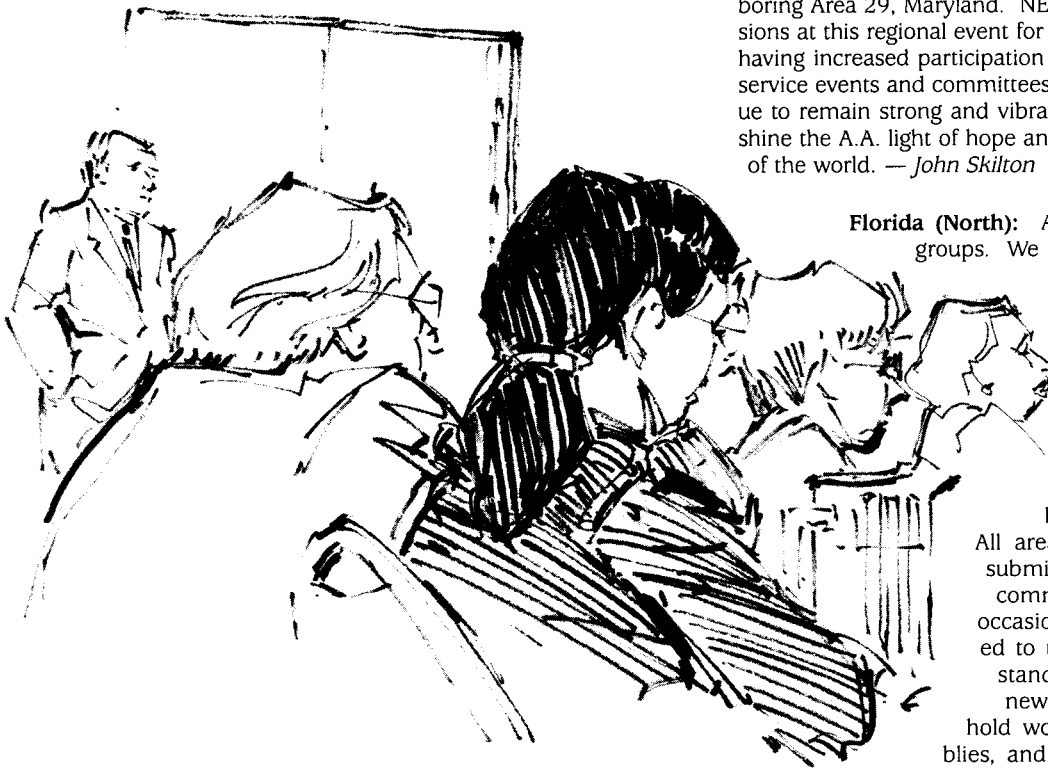
California (Northern Coastal): Area 6 is made up of 18 geographic, as well as four at-large districts which serve the Spanish-speaking community. We use the subdistrict structure, and each district has a D.C.M. chairperson. Our activities are entirely supported by group contributions from the 22 districts and 175 subdistricts, which serve approximately 2,300 groups. Our area committee meets monthly and we hold four assemblies each year. Our P.I./C.P.C. committee is chaired by our alternate delegate, and we fund a representative to the annual Bridging the Gap workshop weekend. In 1996, we added a Finance committee, which meets quarterly. We have 21 central offices/intergroups within the area, including five which represent the Spanish-speaking community, and an autonomous H&I committee. We are well informed on Conference agenda items, and had ongoing discussion on how to increase group participation and better serve the groups. We also continue to look at the commitment we ask of our area officers in the tasks assigned to them. — *Bob Kosloff*

California (Southern): In Area 5 we have 1,991 groups and 60 districts, seven of which are Spanish speaking. Since our request for an additional area was denied several years ago, our collective conscience has changed our structure in an attempt to increase the participation of D.C.M.s. Also new was a half-day orientation assembly held this year to familiarize new D.C.M.s and G.S.R.s with area service activities. One of our most important annual events is our Conference Topic Workshop, held every March, for discussion on the Conference theme and agenda, that leads to the area's group conscience on the items, and is always attended by a G.S.O. staff member and/or our regional trustee. We have active committees for Archives, Audiovisual, C.P.C., Finance, G.S.P., Grapevine, Literature, P.I., Registration, Newsletter and T.F., as well as liaisons to central offices and hospitals and institutions. Our challenge for the next two years is to have committee work at all district levels welcomed at local levels, leading to new growth and involvement. — *Joe Varonin*

Connecticut: Our area has 10 districts, and 1,379 groups, with a total membership of 20,008. We have 13 special service committees and three intergroups in our area. We hold three assemblies (one pre-Conference). The answering service is working with the districts, and doing a feasibility study on an area-wide 800 number. We have three area events: the Round-Up; the Soberfest, and an area Convention. Corrections and Treatment are carrying the message by bringing over 100 meetings into the facilities each week.

P.I. has a radio show (meeting) on Public Radio once a month. C.P.C. is very active, and has been carrying the message to hospitals, police stations, libraries, doctors' offices, and colleges. Archives brings their material to all area events and any meeting





boring Area 29, Maryland. NERAASA held Spanish-speaking sessions at this regional event for the first time. We are fortunate in having increased participation by our young people in assembly service events and committees. It promises that A.A. will continue to remain strong and vibrant in our nation's capital, and will shine the A.A. light of hope and recovery here in our little corner of the world. — *John Skilton*

Florida (North): Area 14 has 31 districts and 668 groups. We use a committee system, through which each D.C.M. is assigned to one of the three administrative committees—Finance, Growth or Site. Motions are sent to one of these committees for debate and recommendations before coming to the floor, thus allowing the area to conduct its business in an efficient manner. All area officers and committee chairs submit budget proposals to the Finance committee annually. After review and occasional debate, the budget is presented to the October assembly. The nine standing committees, including the newly formed literature committee, all hold workshops at our quarterly assemblies, and are active assisting the districts and groups. We have adopted multiple D.C.M.s as a method of handling growth, with a district adding one D.C.M. for each 15 groups. We are striving to find ways to get G.S.R.s more involved so communications between the groups, districts and area will improve, and participation at all levels will be enhanced. — *Dick Gallagher*

that asks. In cooperation with Al-Anon we put on workshops at events. Our area meets every month, as do the district and special service committees, thus insuring that we keep coming up with new ideas to help us carry the message in the most efficient way possible. — *Lisa Tyler*

Colorado: Area 10 consists of the entire state of Colorado. We have 33 districts and 707 registered groups. Effective service is conducted through active and well-established service committees. We host three area assemblies a year in various locations. We provide translation equipment at assemblies for Spanish-speaking G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s. Each year the area holds a Statewide Convention, a Corrections Conference, a T.F. Workshop and a variety of round robins and conferences. In September 1997 the 40th International Conference of Young People in A.A. will be held in Estes Park. P.I. participates in statewide health fair. The C.F. committee carries approximately 140 meetings and literature into State and Federal facilities. Changes in the field of alcoholism provide numerous opportunities for the C.P.C. committee. The challenges are to build upon our 55-year foundation through the Three Legacies, and to ensure that we maintain a safe haven for all alcoholics in the ages ahead. — *David Hansen*

District of Columbia: Area 13 comprises the District of Columbia and the Maryland suburbs of Montgomery and Prince George's counties. Close cooperation between the one intergroup and the general service assembly has been a hallmark of our A.A. unity. Jointly, we support the C.P.C., H.I., and P.I. committees. The assembly meets three times a year; conducts a lively mini-conference, at which A.A. members discuss issues and agenda items coming before the Conference; and sponsors an annual gratitude breakfast. Area 13 was the site of this year's Northeast Regional Delegates Meeting, and the area sponsored the attendance of more than 40 area officers, D.C.M.s, G.S.R.s, and others active in service at NERAASA 1997, which was sponsored by our neigh-

Florida (South)/Bahamas/Virgin Islands: Area 15 includes South Florida from Aripeka to Sebastian in the east and down through the Keys; soon we hope to welcome the Cayman Islands. We have 15 districts, and more than 2,000 groups, with an active membership of approximately 42,000. We have active C.F. and T.F. committees, and at our State convention some 500 people from surrounding facilities attended. Our first Spanish-speaker/discussion meeting was held at the same convention. Interest has been shown in creating a linguistic district in the area. Our Grapevine committees are active, especially in District 10, whose annual bonfire, hay ride, hoe-down, and speaker round-up are popular affairs. A "Sponsor Your Sponsor with a Grapevine Subscription" movement is underway. Recently, several district P.I./C.P.C. committees got together to sponsor the Conference-approved radio and television P.S.A.s, which were seen and heard throughout a tricountry area. Archives committees are active in collecting A.A. memorabilia. One of the ways that has proven most valuable in keeping our memories green has been oldtimer meetings, and taping the stories and histories of those A.A.s who came before us. These meetings are generally well-attended by our young people, and are a good way to encourage the oldtimers to "keep coming back." — *John King*

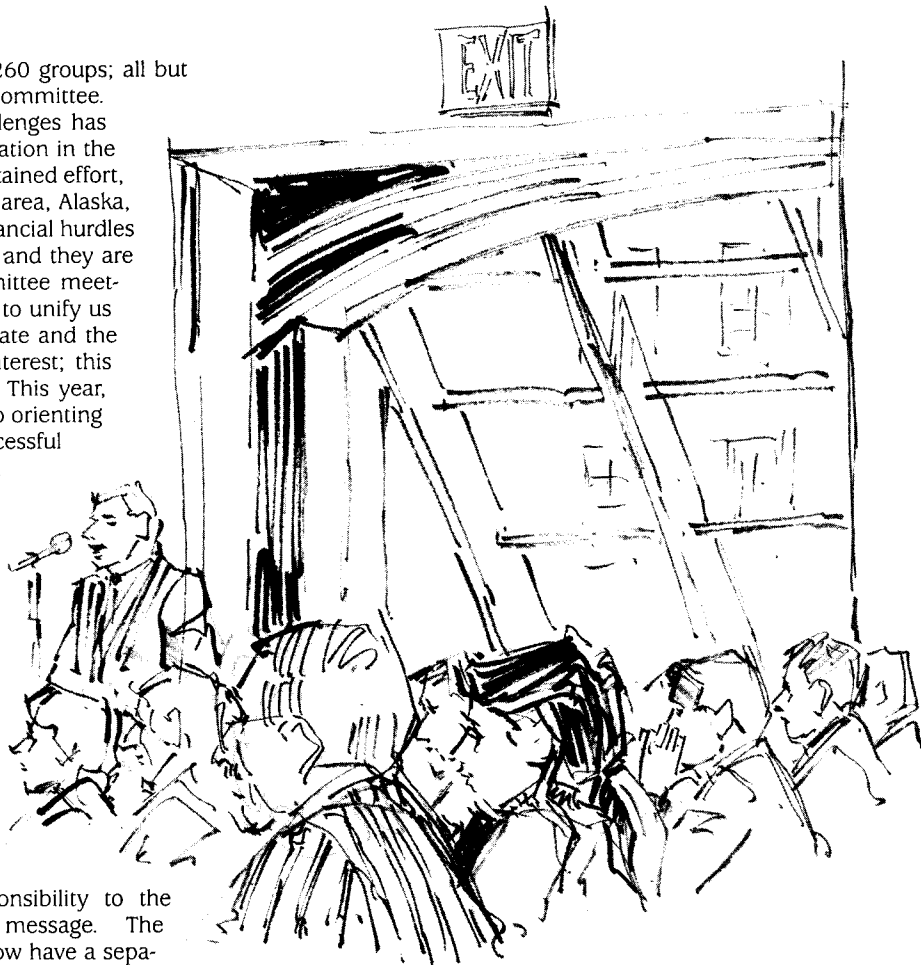
Christine Hofer (SE Michigan), the youngest Conference delegate, said it took her three years into sobriety to work up the courage to ask: "Who is this John Barleycorn and why does everyone hate him so?"

Hawaii: Area 17 consists of six islands and 260 groups; all but two islands are represented on the area committee. Because of geography, one of our great challenges has been to build unity through increased participation in the service structure, and after several years of sustained effort, we have been very successful. Like our sister area, Alaska, the groups in Hawaii must overcome great financial hurdles to participate in the general service structure, and they are doing so in greater numbers. Rotating committee meetings and assemblies around the islands helps to unify us as a Fellowship. Because we are an island state and the costs are high, money is a topic of much interest; this year the area formed a Finance committee. This year, Hawaii devoted its first assembly of the year to orienting new G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s, which was successful beyond our expectations. It was a high note in our collective service lives, and we all hope that it translates into continued enthusiasm and unity of the A.A. Fellowship. — *Tanya Every*

Illinois (Chicago): Our area is composed of 23 districts, and has approximately 4,000 A.A. meetings weekly. 1996 was a year of many changes, the most notable being the relocation of our service office after more than 40 years. Our service office is an integral part of our area's Twelfth-Step work. Volunteers handle over 5,000 calls per month, with approximately 10 percent being Twelfth-Step calls. We hope, by our service office move and our responsibility to the Fellowship, to be better able to carry the message. The Chicago area is rich in A.A. history, and we now have a separate room to store and view our archival material. Our area has six active standing service committees: C.P.C., P.I., Grapevine, C.F. and Hospital and Treatment, and a bimonthly newsletter has a circulation of over 35,000. Our annual All-Chicago Open Meeting is attended by over 12,000 people. Prior to the Conference, our area hosted our fourth forum to discuss the upcoming Conference agenda. The spirit and fellowship of A.A. is alive and well in the Chicago area. — *Laura Zeitlin*

Illinois (Southern): Area 21 covers about 70 percent of Illinois, mostly small towns and rural communities. We closely follow the service structure of G.S.R.s, D.C.M.s and area committees. Our service committees are constantly striving to increase the level of service they provide in carrying the message. Southern Illinois has several prisons and prison work camps, and our prison committee is busy carrying the message into these facilities. Our Grapevine and Archives committees have traveling displays, available to all district, area and state conferences and conventions. Our Treatment committee works with Bridging the Gap in treatment facilities throughout the area. Our Budget committee has done an excellent job of keeping us working within our means. Financial support from the groups is not as good as it could be, but it keeps on getting better. Area 21 is constantly searching for better ways to carry the A.A. message to the still-suffering alcoholic. — *Larry Hoult*

Indiana (Northern): Area 22 is now nine years old as an area structure instead of a combined state-wide structure. We have 48 districts and approximately 650 groups. The area holds four assemblies and two D.C.M. conferences each year rotated



between four quadrants of the area. 1997 is the second consecutive year that the standing committee has taken its inventory. In 1996 we held our first weekend assembly, to promote communication and carry the message of service, while educating and encouraging participation in order to have a better understanding of the responsibilities of a trusted servant. Our prudent reserve has been increased by 42 percent. The Archives committee has grown and is extremely active. We have just elected an area registrar to help improve on group information accuracy and stress its importance to groups. For the first time in memory the elections of the area standing committee had more than adequate volunteers to fill the offices and standing committee chairpeople. — *Jerry Scott*

Iowa: Area 24 has 21 districts and approximately 650 groups. The area committee meets three times a year, and has two, two-day conference assemblies annually. We have recently moved service workshop to March to allow groups and area representatives input on Conference agenda items. Increasing involvement has encouraged growth and restructuring, which led to our adding one new district. The alternate delegate has a vital role updating group information and area Directory, and chairing the G.S.R. sharing sessions at assembly meetings. Our P.I., C.P.C., G.V., Literature, G.F., C.F., Newsletter and Archives committees are very active. We have both a permanent and a traveling archives display. Our C.F. committee has increased its communication with administrators. To help provide literature to inmates, the "pink can" concept has been adopted. In Iowa, we believe service begins with each of us in the home group. — *Frank Petska*



Louisiana: During our two-day quarterly assemblies all standing committees hold meetings, providing information, shared experience and literature. The agenda includes a newcomers orientation, a G.S.R. sharing session and committee and officers reports sessions, including the delegate's report. The average attendance of 220 is representative of all 23 districts, but less than half of total groups. We supply service packets to newly elected G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s, and have a literature display. Our first Agenda committee was formed, and includes five G.S.R.s, and the delegate serving as chairperson. We hold major conventions in metropolitan and rural areas alike, and the Cajun Country Conference in Lafayette is hoping to host the 1999 Southeast Regional Conference. Service committee displays are included at our state convention. Our legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service not only increase the growth of A.A. in Louisiana, but enhance our personal growth as well. — *Danie Fontenot*

Massachusetts (Eastern): Our area includes approximately 1,700 registered groups in 26 geographical districts and two Spanish-speaking districts. Seven Conference committees and four standing committees serve the groups. Each year, we hold five assemblies in different locations, including a pre- and post-Conference assembly. The area committee meets every month. We publish an area newsletter five times a year to inform groups about the work of our Conference committees. Six central office/intergroups serve our groups, and three general service committees function jointly with them in their Twelfth Step work. Our State Convention is a joint effort with Area 31, Western Massachusetts. We have Bridging the Gap and Count On Us Programs, to help accomplish this mission. Our newly elected officers are committed to supporting and working with our districts in continuing important and vital Twelfth Step work. — *John Egan*

Michigan (Central): Area 32 has 14 districts, 563 groups and approximately 12,842 members. The area assembly rotates monthly throughout our districts. Our standing committees are P.I./C.P.C., T.F., C.F., Literature, Forum, Finance, Archives, and Grapevine. A report is given at the assembly by each committee chair. Many districts conduct workshops annually. We will be sending 20 service active people to their first East Central Regional Forum, in Illinois, May 1997. We were privileged to host the 44th Michigan State Conference in October 1996. Area 32 meets quarterly with Areas 33 and 34. An active C.F. and Grapevine committee gives reports at this statewide meeting. To

get new service representatives and keep them in service has been the focus in our area, as well as to carry the message to the alcoholic who still suffers, from the home group to anywhere in the world. — *Art Carmona*

Michigan (Southeast): Area 33 encompasses five counties with 661 registered groups and 24 districts; we have four intergroups. Our D.C.M.s hold monthly meetings to exchange ideas and discuss challenges. We have a permanent location for our archives (and a permanent archivist), with regular visiting hours. The archives are also portable and available to the groups upon request. We recently made our Hearing Impaired committee a Special Needs committee. We have invested in two computers, one of which is currently being used by our area secretary and the other by our district coordinator. One of our ongoing goals is to get more G.S.R.s actively involved in area service activities. We hope to start a quarterly G.S.R. orientation. Another goal is to find a permanent office for our archives and computers, which would make them accessible to all the committees, and provide a permanent mailing address to help groups to keep track of us. We are blessed to have many dedicated committee chairpeople and D.C.M.s who are willing to do whatever it takes to carry the message of A.A. to the alcoholics who still suffers. — *Christine Hofer*

Minnesota (Southern): Our area is experiencing changes in 1997; not only do we have new area officers and standing committee chairs, and new D.C.M.s, but we have also radically changed our calendar and meeting structure. One result is we will be holding two two-day assemblies per year, combining them with standing committee meetings and an area committee meeting. Our T.F. and C.F. committee, is looking at new ways to use a Temporary Contact Program. P.I. and C.P.C. committees have a state-of-the-art display booth and are discussing new methods of reaching the public and professionals. Literature, Grapevine, and Archives committees continue to keep us informed about the importance of our basic message and our history. We have over 1,000 registered groups in 26 districts. We have truly recognized

Rod Betonney, delegate from Utah (Panel 47), said his area tells him that his name, ROD, "is an acronym for Right of Decision."

the goals we have in common with local service entities, and communicate with them when we see an opportunity to cooperate or share information. — *Karin Nord*

Missouri (Eastern): Area 38 has 589 groups in 22 districts (two are inactive). We conduct four assemblies annually in a central location, and our October assembly is two-days. We hold an annual state convention jointly with Area 39 Western Missouri, usually in July. We support active area committees in Archives, C.P.C., C.F., Grapevine, Gratitude Gazette (our area newsletter), P.I., Special Needs and T.F. We have an area office, which is currently staffed by a paid employee supervised by the area chairperson and delegate. One of our continuing challenges is to bring new A.A.s into our service structure, especially in the black community of the inner city of St. Louis. Treatment centers located in our area no longer send new members to our meetings, because now health insurance companies seldom pay for 28-day treatment stays. Thus, we are reassuming our Twelfth Step call responsibilities. One drunk reaching out the hand of A.A. to the next will always be the road to improved sobriety for ourselves and to the still-suffering alcoholic. — *Tim Hoft*

Missouri (Western): Our area has 16 districts and approximately 225 groups. Average attendance at each of our four quarterly assemblies is 160. Although our state is divided into two areas, great strides have been made in promoting unity. Our Western area supported the Eastern area in their bid for the 2005 International Convention, and we work in cooperation to ensure a successful Missouri State Convention. Area 39 hosted the Southwest Region Service Assembly in Kansas City, which was attended by 357 from seven states. Our area committees are extremely active; C.P.C., P.I., and Literature committees provide literature and speakers for schools and professional events. T.F. and C.F. committees work jointly to host an Institutions Weekend each May, which brings A.A. members and professionals together. The Grapevine committee continues to work hard explaining how the magazine can be used to carry the message, and the Bridging the Gap and Special Needs subcommittees meet at each area assembly to address ways to assist those leaving treatment and those with special needs. Our area archives now has a permanent location. — *John Admire*

Nevada: Area 42 includes Nevada and parts of the eastern slopes of the California Sierra Nevada Mountains. We have 12 areas officers and alternates, three treasuries, a northern area service committee, a southern area service committee and, the area committee. The northern and southern service bodies meet every other month, and the area meets twice a year. We have 21 districts, with approximately 199 registered groups in the south, and 178 in the north, a total of 377. We have two major intergroup offices, in Reno and Las Vegas, and several rural intergroup structures. One challenge this unique north/south arrangement has created has been with the special committee chairs. There are special committee chairs in the north, and one in the south. However, there are no committee chairs at the area level. Workshops and training sessions are held throughout the area for G.S.R.s and other interested A.A.s. Although A.A. membership appears to be increasing, group participation and contributions are not keeping pace. The warmth and love of A.A. continues in Area 42 and is constantly demonstrated by the trusted servants who work in all aspects of general service. — *Roberta Lindeman*

New Jersey (Northern): Our area has approximately 1,300 to 1,400 groups, 35 districts, 6 sections, and about 28,000 mem-

bers. Interest and participation is on the increase, and some of this revitalization can be attributed to the activity of the G.S.R. Workshop committee. February is unofficially G.S.R. month in our area, and the committee puts on five workshops in the six sections of the area. Our Policy/Admissions committee has recently completed work on our area guidelines. This information and experience, compiled over the years, is useful in helping our officers, committees and D.C.M. carry the A.A. service message in our area with consistency. One of our districts has formed a Special Needs committee to help carry the A.A. message to these alcoholics. Area 44 is looking forward to hosting NERAASA 1998, which will be a weekend in February at the Secaucus Hilton in northern New Jersey. — *Eddie McGee*

New York (Central): Area 47 spans approximately 20 counties and 30 percent of the state's total area, as well as a few small towns on the Pennsylvania border. We have two central offices, and 11 smaller intergroups. We have 11 full area assemblies a year, moved geographically around the area, as well as our area convention in May for the delegate's report from the Conference. Our eight standing committees meet each month at our assembly. We have 43 active districts and 735 groups that are registered, and 18 correctional facility groups. Our C.F. and T.F. committees both have active Bridging the Gap programs. These committees hosted two "Corrections Connection," day-long sharing sessions with A.A. members active in corrections work in the state, and N.Y. State Dept. of Corrections personnel participating. The State Dept. of Corrections would like to include these workshops as part of its continuing education in various parts of the state. We continue to try and encourage those districts without representation at our assemblies to get involved in general service, reminding them that their voices make a difference. — *Lisa Hens*

New York (Southeast): Area 49 has 2,000 groups, of which 1,600 are registered, 893 G.S.R.s, 130 D.C.M.s and 13 D.C.M. chairs. We have five assemblies and ten committee meetings a year. We recently formed an ad hoc committee on Finance. The area sponsors service structure workshops throughout the 12 counties, including our Spanish-speaking districts, which are now fully participating within the area. The counties and districts hold various workshops on a regular basis to help improve service to the G.S.R.s. We also have an ad hoc committee on Service Participation. Our standing committees are reflective of the Conference committees. An intergroup liaison meets quarterly with our intergroups and answering services. Area 49 has an annual convention, and every four years hosts the state convention. We participate with three other areas in the New York State Informational Workshop held annually. We are honored to be the host area for the Northeast Regional Forum for the first time this June, and we will also host the Northeast Regional Convention. Many of the groups in our area now have meetings that are signed for the deaf and hard of hearing. We continually strive to make spiritual progress. — *Isadora Drayton*

North Carolina: Our area is made up of 35 districts, approximately 950 groups and many meetings. During the past few years our service structure has undergone several changes, and our area committee now consists of delegate, alternate delegate, chairperson, alternate chairperson, secretary, and treasurer/group information coordinator. The area committee also has seven standing committee chairpersons, 35 D.C.M.s and 35 non-voting alternate D.C.M.s. Before each area committee meeting area officers have a special meeting during which they resolve

any differences. Last year we established an L.C.M. structure to establish better communication; and this year we are completely restructuring our committee system. We are also planning to publish a quarterly newsletter and elect a newsletter editor. — *Art Denning*

Nova Scotia/Newfoundland/Labrador: Our area has 288 groups and approximately 3,800 members, and covers a large geographical area that spans two provinces divided into 16 districts. Because travel is both difficult and expensive, we have one assembly in the fall, which is rotated among our four major cities. We hold provincial service weekends in May to hear reports from D.C.M.s, area officers and the delegate's Conference report. Each province maintains an archives, and intergroup services are offered in the capital cities. The districts play the most important role in our structure, especially at the committee level. Most have very active P.I., C.P.C. and, where applicable, T.F. and C.F. committees. Much of our communication is by mail and telephone, and the exchange of district meeting minutes helps foster a sharing of ideas and a sense of unity throughout our area. — *Sonny Sampson*

Ohio (Central/Southeast): Our assembly meets four times a year, as does the D.C.M. committee and planning committee. Every March the area and two districts host a mini-conference, at which we discuss Conference agenda items. Area 53 will host the Ohio State Convention in Columbus in July 1997, and its 11th Annual Convention in October. The area has a number of active committees, including Grapevine, C.F., Convention, P.I., C.P.C., Archives and T.F. A New Groups committee has been formed to provide information and registration tables at area assemblies, and travel to new groups to share information. The area has a traveling G.S.R. school, staffed by two past delegates, which visits districts for programs based on the *A.A. Service Manual*. Our quarterly newsletter contains minutes from the past assembly and upcoming meetings, conventions and conferences are posted, as well as upcoming area assembly agendas. An ongoing challenge has been activating districts. Progress is being made in putting principles into action in our service structure. — *Bill Farnsworth*

Ohio (Northeast): While geographically Area 54 occupies less than one-quarter of the state, our 25,000 members in 1,300 registered groups with seven central/intergroup offices are about as large as all of the three other Ohio areas combined. Having hosted the Regional and State conventions last year, these responsibilities have now rotated to other areas, and we are turning our attention to matters within our borders. We are concentrating on making service opportunities available, attractive and announced. We have added positions through redistricting, breaking up those districts which were excessively large, and we have just created a Spanish-speaking district at large. But our greatest effort has been improving the use, size, and effectiveness of our ten standing committees. Each of our area officers is a liaison to two of these committees. We have a topnotch set of officers and committee chairs that are unifying into a well-working team. — *Bob McKimm*

Oklahoma: Area 57 has 48 D.C.M.s from eight districts, serving 361 groups and over 6,500 members. In order to help educate the membership about A.A.'s Third Legacy, the area committee sponsors workshops on committee responsibilities and activities, as well on sponsorship, spirituality and the Fifth Step. Each of the districts holds a meeting quarterly, generally a week or two prior

to our four-area committee meeting and general assembly. At these meetings the G.S.R.s discuss with the D.C.M.s group activities and problems. Each May, our annual state convention, draws between 1,800 and 2,000 members. Area 57 supports an area office and archives center, and employs a part-time area secretary. Among our greatest assets are our ex-officios, former delegates, who serve on the area advisory committee, and continue to provide experience, strength, hope, courage, wisdom and serenity. Area 57 continues to try to live up to Bill's commitment to do "anything whatever that helps us reach a fellow sufferer." — *Steven Thompson*

Ontario (Eastern): Area 83 is a large, diversified area having 616 groups in 27 districts, including a Spanish district of eight groups. Included in the area is Canada's largest populations centre, remote and rural communities many hours drive apart. Some of these groups and districts are located in the U.S., so we truly are an international district. Last year we hosted a meeting of a Remote Community Working Service Committee. Participants were all the delegates from Eastern Canada, and one from Alaska and from western Canada as well as several Native Remote Community participants. Reports were received from ad hoc committees on special needs and area voting procedures. The establishment of G.S.R. and D.C.M. training schools was well received. For the third consecutive time, our area elections took 12 ballots. We A.A.s seem to have something for this number twelve. Everyone is looking forward to the International Convention in 2005 in Toronto. — *Wilf Antheunis*

Ontario (Northeast): Our area comprises eight districts, with approximately 3,000 members in 168 groups. Due to our geographical area, we find it necessary to host three area committee meetings per year. We have one area assembly annually in September. Workshops are held on whatever topics the districts feel are of greater value at the time. We host an area conference over Thanksgiving weekend in October, rotating among our three larger cities. An area directory and our area newsletter are published four times a year. Our greatest growth is in archives. We have an area chairperson and area archivist. These members are very active collecting data and taping oldtimers in A.A. and are available to put on presentations and displays upon request. Our Area Archivist attended the workshop in Akron, Ohio in 1996; the area felt this would further her knowledge and keep up her enthusiasm. — *Jeannine Presley*

Ontario (Northwest): Our area extends about 750 miles—from Manitoba in the west, to Whiteriver in the east; from the U.S. border in the south to Hudson Bay in the north, which is 1,000 miles. There are 92 groups and 1,600 members. We have two area assemblies a year, two committee meetings and one round-up. There are eight districts; some D.C.M.s travel 350 miles to an assembly. The delegate gets to report to the Fellowship at various district round-ups. The C.F. committee is working very hard to carry the message into institutions. At our area round-up the A.A. inmates put on a luncheon for our speakers as well as 100 guests. Native language specialists are working on getting the Big Book translated into their native tongue. We have started group sponsorship to northern groups, where there are no roads. A sponsorship kit consists of two Big Books, speaker tapes, as well as the Big Book on tape, and other A.A. literature. At our area round-up we have a C.P.C. luncheon; invitations are sent to doctors, lawyers and other professionals in the community. Member of both P.I., C.P.C. committees and a young member all spoke at the luncheon last year; it is always very well attended. — *Keith Lake*



Pennsylvania (Eastern): Area 59 has 1,450 groups, represented by 45 districts. We have nine intergroup/central offices; our area committee holds quarterly meetings at various locations and has nine subcommittees. We hold three mini assemblies each year, at which the delegate gives a report. Our annual convention/assembly has an attendance of over 1,000. The area sponsors an "Area Day" to inform the Fellowship about area structure and how it functions. We also host an Area/Intergroup/Central Office Workshop to help promote unity among those carrying the message within the area; and participate with five of our intergroups in days of sharing. We continue our efforts to encourage participation within the Conference structure; to increase awareness and subscriptions to the Grapevine; to encourage archives activity, to gather and conserve our history as a resource for the Fellowship in years to come. Primarily, the area strives to find new and better ways to help reach the still-suffering alcoholic, and to maintain the Fellowship so that we are here when they need and want us. — *Clay Rittenhouse*

Pennsylvania (Western): Area 60 has 755 groups in 45 districts in 26 counties. We have quarterly committee meetings and two assemblies each year, except in an election year when we have three. Our P.I., C.P.C., T.F. and C.F. committees are active, and give presentations at our Days of Sharing meetings. The Archives, Grapevine and Literature committees have traveling displays for district, group and area events. Each year we have our Annual Getaway Weekend, followed by a pre-Conference assembly, at which we discuss Conference agenda items in order to arrive at our group conscience. Our Budget committee recommends how we can best function within our resources by utilizing the contributions from the area groups. We are fortunate to have past delegates at all of our service functions; and they have full voting privileges. Our first quarterly meeting had many G.S.R.s present to support their D.C.M.s. We in Western Pennsylvania continue to focus on carrying the message to the alcoholic who still suffers through our structure, the Traditions and the Concepts. — *Dave Bowman*

Quebec (Northeast): The Province of Quebec is divided into four large areas. Northeast Area 89 extends over 1,000 miles in length, and includes both the northern bank of the magnificent St. Lawrence river and the far north where several native communities reside. Our area comprises 22 districts and 362 groups. Within beautiful Quebec City, five districts have regrouped to form an intergroup. We hold two general assemblies a year and four area committee assemblies. When our financial situation allows, our area coordinators support the work of local P.I., C.P.C., Literature, La Vigne, C.F., T.F. and Finance committees. We also have an office with a part-time employee. In cooperation with the other three areas of the province, with whom we hold occasional meetings, we believe we can reach our goal: to help the still-suffering alcoholic. — *Robert Caron*

Quebec (Southeast): Area 88 is bordered to the west by the City of Magog, and to the east by the Magdalen Islands. It extends from the south shore of the St. Lawrence river to the border of the United States, except for the portion between Lévis and Trois-Rivières. Our area has 19 districts, with 215 groups holding 249 meetings per week (165 open meetings and 84 closed meetings). Nearly all of our members are French speaking. We hold four area meetings each year, and one large election assembly. Each district has a P.I. coordinator and a representative for *La Vigne*. Additionally, each district holds a delegate's day on the Conference theme. We also hold two dinners to express our gratitude to A.A., during which the delegate reports on the Conference. During the year, any district can ask the area to hold a Structure and Traditions Day. As our area is vast, the area committee meets in different districts to carry the message to the four corners of our territory. — *Raymond Dionne*

Texas (Northeast) Area 65 has more than 378 groups, served by 28 districts, three of which are Spanish-speaking. Translation equipment is provided to encourage more participation from Spanish-speaking members. Since 1995, the area alternate chairperson has taken on the role of workshop coordinator in the districts. Topics range from the Conference theme to the overview of

our structure, which includes all the variables that relate to our fifth Tradition. Our Grapevine committee has groups and districts sponsoring Grapevine subscriptions to correctional and other institutions. We are now conducting an annual weekend Correctional Facility Conference. Area 65 holds four assemblies a year; the area committee meets four times yearly. Our newsletter serves as a forum and keeps us current on area events. The NE Texas Area is definitely on the right track, however, as always, we must continue to be vigilant in our efforts to strive toward better service. We must also be prudent in the manner in which we serve, as well as remaining focused on our primary purpose. — *Phil Ernst*

Texas (Southeast): Area 67 has 15 districts and 440 groups, which hold over 2,000 meetings weekly. Our committee system is flourishing with active P.I., C.P.C., T.F., Archives, Grapevine and Finance committees working to meet the needs of the Fellowship and community. Every November we have a gratitude dinner, with each district contributing food. The purpose is to encourage participation throughout the groups, while allowing us to express our gratitude for sobriety. This November we had approximately 400 in attendance. Each January, the area hosts an annual convention, which rotates among our four largest cities. We hold our area assembly in conjunction with the convention, which gives the membership an introduction to general service work. The theme of the 35th Convention was "We Stood at the Turning Point," and the event was attended by 2,000 people. The rest of the year, our area assembly meets quarterly, usually the second weekends of April, July and October. — *Jane Sheppard*

Utah: Our area has 300 groups, 10 districts, three central offices, and an estimated 4,500 recovering alcoholics. The area holds three area assemblies, three area committee meetings, and two area workshops. We have established standing committee roundtables during our assembly business meetings to encourage G.S.R.s to participate by assigning them to the various committees. Our area submitted the 1997 Conference theme "Spirituality, Our Foundation," and we have submitted four Conference agenda items for consideration. We have bid to host PRAASA. in the year 2000. The wisdom of the spirit of rotation is evident in the unity and enthusiasm of our present area officers, who have benefited from the effort of the previous officers. Our area officers have already participated in two G.S.R. workshops this year. The area is making a special effort to encourage growth both in the more isolated areas of the state and in responding to those who have special needs. We are guided by the principle of attraction rather than promotion in doing our service work. — *Rod Betonney*

Virginia: Area 71 is please to be hosting the 1997 Southeast Regional Conference, to be held in conjunction with our 48th Virginia Area Convention in Hampton, Virginia, September 4-7. With 39 districts and approximately 1,425 registered groups, we are experiencing some growing pains. Our Growth committee (which seems to handle all of the jobs or assignments that don't really fit anywhere else) is compiling a questionnaire to conduct an area inventory at this year's fall assembly. We hope to learn from this experience, and come away better able to serve the still-suffering alcoholic. While all of our committees are very active and involved in their particular service work, the C.F. committee has perhaps the toughest goal this year, coordinating efforts between the Commonwealth of Virginia and each district to ensure at least weekly visits to every facility in our area. The year 2000 will mark the 60th Anniversary of A.A. in Virginia—stay tuned for more information on an area-wide celebration. — *Michaelene Fortner*

Washington (Western): In January, we began our first rotation as the restructured Area 72, and we are now directing our full attention to how best to carry the message of our area. In our first year as the Western Washington Area, districts have increased from 37 to 40, one is our first Spanish-speaking district. We have experienced a 1% increase in the number of registered groups, which at present number 1,045; of these, 47 are active in their districts. Our 1996 area assembly had 100% district representation, with 44% of our G.S.R.s participating. Our area committee meets quarterly, with one full assembly in the fall. Standing committees are active and coordinate with district counterparts quarterly. This is the first year pre-Conference meetings were arranged in regional groupings with four scheduled in March. We recognize and strive to meet the challenges of keeping the groups informed and involved, encouraging two-way communication as a means to reach our best solutions. Sharing with love and gratitude we continually look to attract the new member to service so our future is assured the good leadership it deserves. — *Phyllis Halliday*

West Virginia: Area 73 has an estimated 3,500 members represented by 310 groups who meet daily to carry the message. Our area is divided into seven regions which allows participation among our 17 districts in workshops, conventions, and assemblies. All districts hold monthly meetings, as well as attending our two annual assemblies. New committees have been selected by Third Legacy procedure and have already begun to set their agendas for the upcoming year. Past delegates play a vital role in serving. The area committee holds workshops prior to the start of our business meeting focused on service information and what we need to do to help the suffering alcoholic. As A.A. grows in West Virginia so does the responsibility of our area committee to see to it that the groups are kept informed about Recovery, Unity and Service. As our area committee members take on new positions, we rely on the experience of this Conference and past area committees to help us meet the needs of our groups, so that we may pass it on to future members of A.A. in West Virginia. — *Larry Cassady*

Wisconsin (Southern): Area 75 comprises 35 districts serving approximately 950 groups. At present, 32 of these districts are active and have D.C.M.s. The area has formed an ad hoc committee to look into the feasibility of conducting the area's business through a committee system loosely based on the Conference system. A proposal to this effect has been placed on the agenda, and, if passed, it is hope that it will generate more precise and relevant agenda items, and increase district participation. Area 75 has six regular meetings a year: two agenda planning meetings, two pre-Conference assemblies, and two Conference assemblies. The area sponsors a delegate's workshop a month before the Conference, during which time past delegates and the current delegate discuss the agenda. We have seven active committees: Archives, Bridging the Gap, C.P.C., C.F. Grapevine, Literature, and T.F. The C.F. committee recently took subscriptions for 110 English Grapevines and 41 Spanish Grapevines for correctional institutions. The committee was also instrumental in starting an annual Corrections Conference which is a great tool for sharing. Area 75 will be hosting the 7th Annual World Wide Bridging the Gap Workshop Weekend in Milwaukee in September. — *Will Kilkeary*

Despite the fact that the hotel kitchen is cautioned about any alcohol in food, a few rum-laced petite fours found their way to the buffet table one noontime. Then someone in the kitchen remembered and raced out to retrieve them, finding three missing! Must have been a Class A trustee!

Additional Committee Considerations Which Did Not Result in Recommendations

Advisory Action 40 of the 1990 General Service Conference states: "Items discussed, but no action taken or recommendation made, as well as committee recommendations which are not adopted, be included in a separate section of the Final Report." Those committee recommendations which are not adopted (less than 2/3 of the total Conference votes in favor), but which received at least a simple majority of the votes, are considered "strong suggestions" of the Conference. All items, listed by committee, are as follows:

AGENDA

- The committee reviewed and accepted the revised Conference Evaluation Form which is in this year's Conference Manual.
- The committee discussed a proposal to plan Conference agendas two years in advance and decided not to accept the suggestion.
- The committee asked the staff to prepare a form for the committee to send out each September 1st to all Conference members to gather suggestions for Conference themes, presentations and workshop topics.
- The committee suggested that the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference ask their chairperson to confer with the Conference Agenda Committee chairperson and the staff member in connection with each quarterly board meeting.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

- The committee encourages the trustees' committee efforts to combine the pamphlets "If You Are a Professional," "Alcoholics Anonymous in Your Community" and "A.A. and Employee Assistance Programs" with consideration to the following:

- 1) Brief introduction for professional groups and individuals who have contact with alcoholics.
- 2) Consider a professional presentation of items found in the A.A. Fact Sheet to provide a simple and concise overview of Alcoholics Anonymous and how we can be helpful as a resource for professionals.

- 3) Incorporate the theme "A.A. as a Resource" so it can be used in a variety of presentations. (Professionals, Community Agencies, employee Assistance Programs, etc.)

- 4) The C.P.C. Conference Committee maintains that this will eliminate the duplication and redundancy that currently exists in the above mentioned pamphlets.

- The committee suggested the following changes be made to the service piece "Information on Alcoholics Anonymous":

- 1) Retitle the section "The Nonalcoholic Addict" on page 2 to "Singleness of Purpose and

Problems Other Than Alcohol," and replace the first paragraph with the following text:

"Alcoholism and drug addiction are often referred to as 'substance abuse' or 'chemical dependency.' Alcoholics and non-alcoholics are, therefore, sometimes introduced to A.A. and encouraged to attend A.A. meetings. Anyone may attend open A.A. meetings. But only those with a *drinking* problem may attend *closed* meetings or become A.A. members. People with problems other than alcoholism are eligible for A.A. membership *only* if they have a drinking problem."

- 2) In Item 14 under "What A.A. does not do" add (following "court officials") the words "social agencies, employers, etc."

- 3) Revise existing "treatment facility" titles to "facilities and institutions."

- The committee suggested that the pamphlet "The A.A. Group" be added to the list of A.A. Conference-approved literature in the pamphlet "If You Are a Professional."
- The committee reviewed the contents of the C.P.C. Kit and Workbook and found the contents to be sufficient.
- The committee discussed ways to improve communication between A.A. and the professional community by encouraging A.A. members to become active on C.P.C. committees and in sponsorship of professionals.
- The committee suggested that the trustees' C.P.C. Committee continue its discussion on the use of the A.A. Web Site as a C.P.C. tool.

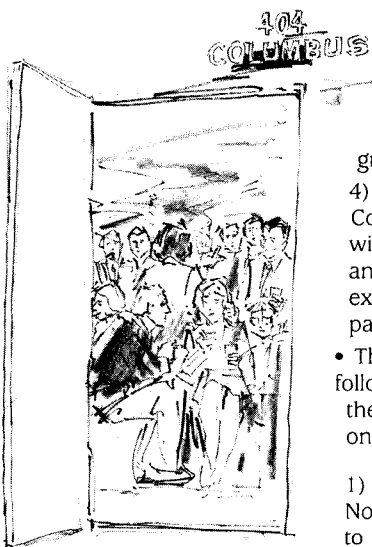
CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

- The committee reviewed the proposed additions to the Correctional Facilities Workbook on youth detention centers and short-term facilities and referred them back, with suggestions, to the trustees' Committee on Correctional Facilities to be further developed and brought back for consideration by the 1998 Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities.
- The committee reviewed the Correctional Facilities Workbook and suggested adding the pamphlet, "Twelve Steps Illustrated," to the Correctional Facilities Workbook's Literature Guide under "For Inmates (easy-to-read)" and "For Professional Staff," at the next printing.
- The committee discussed adding A.A. groups that meet in correctional facilities to the mailing list of the newsletter *Sharing From Behind the Walls*, and concluded that distribution of this newsletter to correctional facilities groups was a matter of area autonomy.
- The committee reviewed the remaining suggestions forwarded from the trustees' Committee on Correctional Facilities and suggested the following:

- 1) The trustees' Committee on Correctional Facilities undertake a review of the current A.A. correctional facilities literature, and that Correctional Facilities chairs be asked the following questions:

- a) Is the present A.A. corrections literature meeting the service needs of the Fellowship?
- b) What A.A. literature is reaching correctional professionals and their facilities and treatment programs?
- c) Is there a demonstrated need for any additional corrections literature?

This report is to be brought back to the 1998 Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities for review.



- 2) An informational letter from the General Service Office to wardens be developed and brought back to the 1998 Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities, along with projected costs of production and mailing.
- The committee reviewed the additional suggestions of the trustees' Committee on Correctional Facilities, and concluded that these suggestions did not fall within the scope of the Conference Committee on Correctional Facilities.

FINANCE

- The committee reviewed the current Self-Support pamphlet and suggested that the Publications Department review the page numbering of the current pamphlet since the numbering for the first few pages are inconsistent in pamphlets sampled.
- The committee discussed the Birthday Envelope Plan and considered the following ways of raising the Fellowship's consciousness: Communicate Birthday Envelope Plan information to delegates at the General Service Conference; give each delegate Birthday envelopes to distribute in their areas; include information about the Birthday Envelope Plan along with several contribution envelopes in New Group Handbooks, and in quarterly contribution letters.

GRAPEVINE

- The committee discussed several suggestions for related items for production in 1999 and forwarded to the Grapevine Corporate Board for development two sets of tapes on the topics of: a) Carrying the Message; and b) Emotional Sobriety.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/REGIONAL FORUMS

- The committee reviewed a draft of a Composition, Scope and Procedure for this secondary committee and accepted it unanimously with minor revisions.
- It was suggested that consideration be given to including the delegate chairperson of this committee or a member of the committee in future site-selection trips.

LITERATURE

- The committee considered the request to remove the word "never" from page 14, line 14, of the section, "What does a sponsor do?" in the pamphlet "Questions and Answers on Sponsorship," and saw no need for change.
- The committee reviewed the background material on confidentiality and suggested that the material not be produced.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

- The committee considered a request to change the cutoff date for submitting Conference agenda items and determined that no change was necessary.
- The committee discussed additional background material on Conference agenda items and emphasized the importance of sending requested background material by February 15th of each year.
- The committee discussed the policy and role of observers at the General Service Conference, who are welcome and encouraged to observe, subject to the approval of the General Service Conference.

- The committee reviewed the responses regarding the forming of a Conference Archives Committee and felt there was no need.
- The Policy/Admissions Committee reviewed and discussed the scope of the Conference Committees and encouraged each Conference Committee to inventory itself.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

- The committee requested that the trustees' P.I. Committee report back to the 1998 Conference P.I. Committee on their study of updating, where necessary, all television and radio P.S.A.s including cultural references, availability in French and Spanish as well as formats compatible with current technology.
- The committee agreed to add "electronic media" to Section 1. of the current Scope of this committee as follows:
 - "1) Create greater understanding of the Fellowship of A.A. by carrying the message through:
 - a) public media
 - b) electronic media
 - c) public information meetings
 - d) speaking to community groups"
- The committee discussed the 1996 reports on A.A. Web Site activity. The committee applauded the creation of the A.A. Web Site. The committee requested a cumulative monthly reporting of accesses beyond the A.A. Web Site Home Page.
- The committee reviewed the report on C.P.C., C.F., P.I. and T.F. Service Kits and Workbooks and, in order to create consistency in language, the committee agreed to define this material as "P.I. Service Kits and Workbooks."
- The committee reviewed the contents of the Public Information Service Kit and Workbook and agreed to the following changes:
 - 1) Add a List of Contents to the Public Information Service Kit.
- At the next printing of the P.I. Workbook:
 - 1) Add an explanation regarding the 1996 Membership Survey to the section entitled "Background on Triennial A.A. Membership Survey." This explanation will be consistent with text in the 1996 Membership Survey pamphlet.
 - 2) Add a section entitled "Suggested Public Information Committee Goals" based on sharing from a district Public Information committee.
 - 3) Add the following explanation to the title page:

"The A.A. workbooks are compiled from the practical experience of A.A. members in the various service areas. They also reflect guidance given through the Twelve Traditions and the General Service Conference (U.S. & Canada)."

REPORT AND CHARTER

- The committee unanimously agreed that there was no need to footnote the "Introduction" to the *Twelve Concepts for World Service* because the A.A. World Services Board holds the copy-

When the printer delivered the blueprint of this *Report* to the Publications department the label on the envelope read: "Contents: Blueprint for text of *1997 Final Solution*."

rights in trust on behalf of the General Service Board, U.S. and Canada, and has the right of decision in such matters.

- The committee considered at length a suggestion to eliminate the last names of G.S.R.s and group contacts from the confidential A.A. directories, publishing only the first name and first initial of the last name of those members, and agreed that full names of general service representatives and group contacts may continue to be used in confidential A.A. directories. The committee requests that the General Service Office continue to exercise discretion by distributing A.A. confidential directories within the Fellowship only, and that each A.A. member respect the anonymity of members listed in the directories.
- The committee discussed the request that the General Service Office extend the delay in processing "Alcoholics Anonymous New Group Forms" from 30 days to 60 days and agreed that there was not sufficient need to extend the delay beyond 30 days.

TREATMENT FACILITIES

- After reviewing the material collected by the trustees' Committee on Treatment Facilities regarding changes in the treatment field, the committee thanked the trustees' Committee for its efforts and encouraged them to continue to monitor changes.
- The committee discussed the increasing need for direct contacts with alcoholics in the wide variety of treatment modalities and encourages area committees to assist districts in developing locally-sensitive methods of bridging the gap to Alcoholics Anonymous.
- The committee encourages the trustees' Committee to continue their efforts to share information with others involved in bridging the gap for alcoholics into our Fellowship.
- The committee discussed efforts in their home areas to address the need for helping newer A.A. members feel comfortable in carrying the message to alcoholics reaching our doors and suggested we encourage local sharing with regional correspondents at the General Service Office and the Fellowship through Box 4-5-9, the Grapevine and other vehicles.
- The committee discussed the 1996 reports on A.A. Web Site activity and agreed to forward the following suggestions to A.A. World Services, Inc. for consideration: that tracking methods continue to be developed and e-mail addresses be added to the screens.
- The committee reviewed the letter to treatment professionals and appreciates the fresh approach.

TRUSTEES

- After reviewing the committee's Composition, Scope and Procedure, the committee suggested the following statement under Scope to reflect actual practice:

"The committee reviews resumes of appointed committee members recommended to serve on trustees' committees, i.e., Public Information, Cooperation With the Professional Community, Treatment Facilities, Correctional Facilities, and Literature."

Committee Recommendations Which Did Not Result in Conference Advisory Actions

FINANCE

- It was recommended that the *General Service Board Policy* that states: "Whenever a discount or subsidy is that which would be offered to any other organization of similar size requiring a purchased service or product of similar character and magnitude, i.e., convention rates at hotels, it may be accepted. Whenever a

discount or subsidy is partly or in total offered because we are Alcoholics Anonymous, it must be declined." Be changed to:

"Whenever a discount is that which would be offered to any other organization of similar size requiring a purchased service or product of similar character and magnitude, e.g., convention rates at hotels, it may be accepted. Whenever a discount is partly or in total offered because we are Alcoholics Anonymous, it must be declined. Alcoholics Anonymous may not accept any money from outside sources to defray expenses."

- It was recommended that there be a reaffirmation of the 1981 Conference Advisory Action - "All future events, such as the International Convention, not be planned to operate on a deficit basis, and it was also recommended that all future events of this type be self-supporting" as this is still a prudent policy.

LITERATURE

- It was recommended that the suggested changes to the *Living Sober* booklet be approved with some modifications. **(Tabled)**

PUBLIC INFORMATION

- It was recommended that the following language be added to the back cover and List of Contents of the Public Information Service Kit and to the back cover of the Public Information Workbook:

"This service material is approved by the Conference Public Information Committee."

TREATMENT FACILITIES

- It was recommended that the Treatment Facilities Workbook and the Treatment Facilities Handbook be Conference-approved literature rather than service material.

Floor Actions Which Did Not Result in Conference Advisory Actions

Floor Action #1:

It was recommended that when fiscally prudent, A.A.W.S. Publishing ought to place as a high priority goal, the audio-taping in English, and the audio-taping in Spanish of current A.A. (book) printed literature. **(Failed)**

Floor Action #2:

It was recommended that the following changes to the *Living Sober* booklet be approved:

- Page 55, after the ninth full paragraph: (footnote) "A.A. World Services publishes a pamphlet titled *The A.A. Member — Medications and Other Drugs*. Many members who must take medications for medical conditions have found its suggestions very helpful. The pamphlet is A.A. General Service Conference-approved literature. It may also be helpful to give this pamphlet to our personal physicians to assist them in increasing their knowledge of the nature of our illness, alcoholism."

- Page 4, second paragraph: Remove the sentence: "We have also found that we have to stay away from mind-changing drugs." **(Failed)**

Floor Action #3:

It is recommended that last names of G.S.R.s and group contacts be eliminated from the confidential A.A. directories and that only the first name and first initial of the last name of those members be listed. **(Not Considered)**

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
COMBINED STATEMENTS OF FINANCIAL POSITION
Years Ended December 31, 1996 and 1995**

	General Service Board of A.A.			A.A. World Services, Inc.	A.A. Grapevine, Inc.	Combined 1996	Combined 1995
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund				
ASSETS							
Cash	\$ 399,526	\$ 847,959		\$ 656,595	\$ 176,932	\$ 2,081,012	\$ 3,237,765
Accounts and interest receivable	4,628	109,036		208,685	50,714	373,063	361,593
Intercompany balances	(461,546)	(861,449)		(22,229)	1,345,224	-	-
Inventories							
Books, pamphlets, etc.				1,507,741	151,738	1,659,479	1,581,838
Paper, pre-publication costs, etc.				119,362	54,300	173,662	159,562
Investments (Note 2)							
U.S. Treasury Notes, due 1997/2004							
1996 - at market (cost \$7,225,735)							
1995 - at cost (market \$7,760,665)		7,325,145				7,325,145	7,473,908
Fixed Assets							
Leasehold improvements, computer hardware and software (net of accumulated depreciation - 1996 -\$2,026,114; 1995 -\$1,771,701)			\$ 1,062,666			1,062,666	1,317,079
Deferred charges	133,629			60,890	78,313	272,832	208,669
Other assets				20,251		20,251	20,251
Total Assets	76,237	7,420,691	1,062,666	2,551,295	1,857,221	12,968,110	14,360,665
LIABILITIES							
Accounts payable	\$ 19,224			\$ 400,711	\$ 110,195	\$ 530,130	\$ 798,118
Accrued royalties				161,020		161,020	182,397
Deferred income							
Orders and subscriptions				34,408	1,460,409	1,494,817	1,334,136
Accrued postretirement health benefit obligation (Note 5)		\$ 1,923,912				1,923,912	1,951,331
Total Liabilities	19,224	1,923,912	\$ -	596,139	1,570,604	4,109,879	4,265,982
Net Assets (Exhibit B)	57,013	5,496,779	1,062,666	1,955,156	286,617	8,858,231	10,094,683
Total Liabilities and Net Assets	76,237	7,420,691	1,062,666	2,551,295	1,857,221	12,968,110	14,360,665

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.**

COMBINED STATEMENTS OF ACTIVITIES

Years Ended December 31, 1996 and 1995

	General Service Board of A.A.			A.A. World Services, Inc.	A.A. Grapevine, Inc.		Combined 1996	Combined 1995
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund		English	Spanish Magazine		
INCOME AND COST OF LITERATURE								
Gross Sales				\$ 9,035,212	\$ 2,144,196	\$ 27,427	\$ 11,206,835	\$ 11,566,584
Less: Discounts				774,688	31,852	-	806,540	1,053,316
Net Sales				8,260,524	2,112,344	27,427	10,400,295	10,513,268
Cost of Literature Distributed								
Printing				(3,398,977)	(495,890)	(9,874)	(3,904,741)	(4,010,739)
Royalties on books				(762,446)	-	-	(762,446)	(814,226)
Direct shipping and warehousing				(898,148)	(498,042)	(28,551)	(1,424,741)	(1,420,451)
Gross Profit from Literature				3,200,953	1,118,412	(10,998)	4,308,367	4,267,852
CONTRIBUTIONS - A.A. Groups and Members	\$ 3,912,718						3,912,718	3,664,861
CONVENTION INCOME							-	3,701,053
INVESTMENT INCOME (Note 2)	1,640	\$ 294,471		2,273	81,535	-	379,919	644,429
Total Income	3,914,358	294,471		3,203,226	1,199,947	(10,998)	8,601,004	12,278,195
FUNCTIONAL EXPENSES (Exhibit C)								
Operating	5,925,189			2,305,196	1,388,173	127,293	9,745,851	9,182,710
Other	151,368	(27,419)		-	-	-	123,949	4,650,382
Total Expenses	6,076,557	(27,419)		2,305,196	1,388,173	127,293	9,869,800	13,833,092
EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSE) FOR YEAR BEFORE CUMULATIVE EFFECTS OF ACCOUNTING CHANGES	(2,162,199)	321,890		898,030	(188,226)	(138,291)	(1,268,796)	(1,554,897)
CUMULATIVE EFFECT OF CHANGES IN ACCOUNTING PRINCIPLES								
Postretirement health care benefits (Note 5)							-	(1,663,529)
Market value of investments (Note 2)		286,757					286,757	-
EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSE) FOR YEAR	(2,162,199)	608,647		898,030	(188,226)	(138,291)	(982,039)	(3,218,426)
NET ASSETS								
Balance, January 1	57,013	6,577,132	\$ 1,317,079	1,719,325	424,134	-	10,094,683	13,567,522
Depreciation on capital projects			(254,413)				(254,413)	(254,413)
			1,062,666				8,865,231	10,094,683
Intercompany donations and interfund transfers	2,162,199	(1,689,000)	-	(662,199)	50,709	138,291	-	-
Balance, December 31 (Exhibit A)	57,013	5,496,779	1,062,666	1,955,156	286,617	-	8,858,231	10,094,683

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.**

COMBINED STATEMENTS OF FUNCTIONAL EXPENSES

Years Ended December 31, 1996 and 1995

OPERATING EXPENSES	Group Services	Fellowship Services	General Service Conference	World Service Meeting	Regional Forums	International Convention	Publishing	Grapevine	Spanish Grapevine	Supporting Services	1996 Total	1995 Total
Salaries	\$ 593,494	\$ 712,269	\$ 109,753		\$ 100,816		\$ 781,571	\$ 374,944	\$ 55,065	\$ 1,790,054	\$ 4,517,966	\$ 4,450,306
Payroll taxes	49,977	56,482	7,765		8,424		61,250	34,532	5,117	147,393	370,940	350,840
Health and group insurance	143,659	96,121	13,021		9,766		125,786	56,570	10,158	368,348	823,429	733,402
Retirement expense	42,612	48,158	6,621		7,183		52,224	15,781	1,440	168,539	342,558	332,921
Other program printing	244,985	29,800	47,236	\$3,397	4,270		6,441			3,251	339,380	324,065
Mailing labor	105,357	5,797	2		4,197					925	116,278	121,467
Postage and express	239,439	49,514	23,291		12,997		8,803	14,482		28,677	377,203	360,498
Writers fees	99,390	15,171	4,615	6,460			1,011			250	126,897	53,611
Foreign literature assistance		136,805									136,805	141,863
Selling expenses							62,424	179,196	40,343		281,963	190,280
Professional fees									763	141,066	141,829	133,057
Contracted services	5,448	54,619	753	12,293	3,851		10,365			33,710	121,039	116,970
Occupancy	80,178	74,881	5,960		5,399		101,419	62,954		275,463	606,254	611,952
Telephone	23,220	17,313	2,697		1,779		19,765	10,619		55,029	130,422	126,661
Equipment maintenance		3,368					2,118			46,110	51,596	56,843
Furniture and equipment	36,350	1,009					2,430		10,909	59,211	109,909	66,758
Stationery and office	54,661	7,773	5,132	2,636	9,363		1,847	33,566		77,623	192,601	161,449
Office service and expense	5,214	15,281	11,817	4,886	1,592		20,796	33,565	3,116	158,278	254,545	224,958
Travel, meals and accommodations	929	28,358	305,502	125,858	40,529		9,189			377,582	887,947	712,273
Bad debts									382	27,910	28,292	(9,361)
Delegate fees			(80,273)	(131,729)							(212,002)	(78,103)
Total Operating Expenses	1,724,913	1,352,719	463,892	23,801	210,166		1,267,439	816,209	127,293	3,759,419	9,745,851	9,182,710
Early retirement severance benefits										151,368	151,368	-
Postretirement health benefits										(27,419)	(27,419)	287,802
Spanish magazine project										-	-	29,500
Direct Convention expenses										-	-	4,333,080
Total Expenses	1,724,913	1,352,719	463,892	23,801	210,166		1,267,439	816,209	127,293	3,853,368	9,869,800	13,833,092
Allocation of supporting services to activities	1,038,764	814,624	279,361	14,333	126,565		1,037,757	571,964	-	(3,883,368)	-	-
Total Allocated Expenses	2,763,677	2,167,343	743,253	38,134	336,731		2,305,196	1,388,173	127,293	-	9,869,800	13,833,092
Services	\$2,763,677	\$2,167,343	\$743,253	\$38,134	\$336,731						\$6,049,138	\$10,300,420
Publishing							\$2,305,196				2,305,196	2,259,855
Grapevine								\$1,388,173	\$127,293		1,515,466	1,272,817
											9,869,800	13,833,092
COMPARATIVE TOTALS - 1995	\$2,609,950	\$2,138,429	\$736,474	\$2,082	\$300,138	\$4,513,347	\$2,259,855	\$1,272,817	-		\$13,833,092	

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
Combined Statements of Cash Flows
Years Ended December 31, 1996 and 1995

CASH FLOWS PROVIDED (USED)

	<u>1996</u>	<u>1995</u>
FROM OPERATING ACTIVITIES:		
Excess of income (expense) for year (Exhibit B)	\$ (982,039)	\$ (3,218,426)
Realized and change in unrealized gains on investments	(105,699)	(4,745)
Amortization of bond premiums	5,478	2,256
Changes in assets and liabilities:		
Accounts receivable	(11,470)	38,738
Inventories	(91,741)	(454,542)
Deferred charges and other assets	(64,163)	507,470
Accounts and accruals payable	(289,365)	44,635
Deferred income	160,681	(1,183,241)
Postretirement health benefits obligation	(27,419)	1,951,331
<u>Net Cash Flows Provided (Used)</u> <u>By Operating Activities</u>	<u>(1,405,737)</u>	<u>(2,316,524)</u>
FROM INVESTING ACTIVITIES:		
Proceeds from sales of investments	3,000,000	1,500,000
Purchases of investments	(2,751,016)	-
<u>Net Cash Flows Provided</u> <u>By Investing Activities</u>	<u>248,984</u>	<u>1,500,000</u>
Net Increase (Decrease) in cash	(1,156,753)	(816,524)
Cash, beginning of year	<u>3,237,765</u>	<u>4,054,289</u>
Cash, end of year	<u><u>2,081,012</u></u>	<u><u>3,237,765</u></u>

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

Report of the Independent Auditor

AUDITORS' OPINION

The Board of Trustees

February 21, 1997

The General Service Board of
Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
475 Riverside Drive
New York, New York 10115

Ladies and Gentlemen:

We have audited the accompanying combined statements of financial position of THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC. and its wholly owned subsidiaries, ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC. and ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC., as of December 31, 1996 and 1995 and the related combined statements of activities, functional expenses and cash flows for the years then ended. These financial statements are the responsibility of the Organizations' management. Our responsibility is to express an opinion on these financial statements based on our audits.

We conducted our audits in accordance with generally accepted auditing standards. Those standards require that we plan and perform the audit to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements are free of material misstatement. An audit includes examining, on a test basis, evidence supporting the amounts and disclosures in the financial statements. An audit also includes assessing the accounting principles used and significant estimates made by management, as well as evaluating the overall financial statement presentation. We believe that our audits provide a reasonable basis for our opinion.

In our opinion, the financial statements referred to above present fairly, in all material respects, the combined financial position of the three Corporations named above as of December 31, 1996 and 1995, and the combined changes in net assets and cash flows for the years then ended in conformity with generally accepted accounting principles.

Respectfully submitted,

Owen J. Flanagan and Company
Certified Public Accountants

**THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD
OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC.
ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC.
ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC.
NOTES TO COMBINED FINANCIAL STATEMENTS
DECEMBER 31, 1996 AND 1995**

Note 1 Organization: The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc. is a not-for-profit corporation organized for the purpose of assisting in the formation of A.A. Groups and coordinating the A.A. program of rehabilitating alcoholics throughout the world. In furtherance of that objective, the Organization also publishes books, magazines, pamphlets and other material directly related to the A.A. program through two wholly owned not-for-profit corporations, A.A. World Services, Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. The activities of the General Service Board of A.A. itself are conducted in three separate funds, as follows:

The RESERVE FUND—This fund was established in 1954 for the purpose of accumulating a prudent operating reserve, which during 1977, was redefined by a special General Service Board Committee as the prior year's combined operating expenses of A.A. World Services, Inc., A.A. Grapevine, Inc. and the General

Fund of the A.A. General Service Board. That committee also recommended that all investment activities of the operating entities be consolidated into the Reserve Fund. That advisory action was approved by the Board of Trustees and since that time, all funds of the operating entities, in excess of those required for working capital, have been transferred to the Reserve Fund. Included in such transfers from A.A. Grapevine, Inc. have been amounts held as a deferred liability for subscribers reflected as a liability of the Reserve Fund. Any withdrawals from the Reserve Fund must be specifically authorized by the Board of Trustees on recommendation of the Finance and Budgetary Committee.

The CAPITAL PROJECTS FUND—This fund was established in 1990 to account for the costs of leasehold improvements and computer hardware and software incurred under major capital projects, and to record annual depreciation on such assets.

The GENERAL FUND—This fund is comprised of those assets not included in any of the other funds and may be used for any purpose for which the Corporation was formed. These purposes presently include activities related to communication and information services to A.A. groups and members, public information, cooperation with the professional community and various regional, national and international meetings, conferences and conventions.

All net assets of the Corporations are free of donor restrictions.

Note 2 Accounting Policies: The Corporations use the accrual method of accounting, where income is recorded in the period earned and expenses are recorded in the period incurred and to which they pertain. The Organizations do not receive or solicit pledges for donations, so contributions are recorded as income when the cash is received.

Intercompany balances and donations have been eliminated in the combined totals in the accompanying financial statements.

Operating expenses of the General Service Office are shared between the General Service Board of A.A. and A.A. World Services. Expenses related to service activities are charged to the General Service Board, while expenses in connection with publishing activities are allocated to A.A. World Services. Administrative and overhead costs are apportioned between the program activities they support.

Occupancy costs related to A.A. Grapevine's share of office space at the General Service Office have been allocated based on its proportionate square footage; substantially all other expenses related to magazine activities are paid and recorded directly by A.A. Grapevine under its separate accounting system.

Inventories: Inventories held are recorded at cost under the first-in, first-out, "FIFO" method of accounting. Proper allowance has been made for slow-moving or damaged merchandise.

Literature distributed without charge is not accounted for separately, but is included in the cost of printing as a reduction of inventory.

Fixed Assets: The costs of major capital projects involving leasehold improvements and computer system acquisitions are capitalized and depreciated over the term of the applicable lease, or the useful life of the equipment, in the Capital Projects Fund. In accordance with consistent practice, the costs of these expenditures continue to be recorded as an expense of the General Fund, but are then capitalized and depreciated through changes in net assets in the Capital Projects Fund.

Normal recurring expenditures for furniture and equipment are considered to be immaterial and are charged to expense in the year of purchase.

The following table sets forth, by classification of assets, the depreciation lives, the provision for depreciation for the year

ended December 31, 1996 and the accumulated reserves for depreciation at that date:

	<u>Life</u>	<u>Cost</u>	<u>Current Year</u>	<u>Reserve</u>
Leasehold improvements				
475 Riverside Drive	Terms of Leases	\$1,625,457	\$171,101	\$812,729
Furniture	8 Years	689,598	83,312	439,660
Computer—hardware	5 Years	502,054		502,054
—software	5 Years	271,671		271,671
		<u>3,088,780</u>	<u>254,413</u>	<u>2,026,114</u>

All depreciation is provided on the straight line basis.

Investments: As described above, all of the investing activity of the operating entities is consolidated in the Reserve Fund of the General Service Board. in accordance with established policy, the Fund invests in short or medium term U.S. Treasury Notes normally held to maturity.

Prior to 1996, the investments were carried at amortized cost. Effective in 1996, however, Financial Accounting Standards Board Statement No. 124 required such investments to be recorded at market value. The difference between cost (\$7,473,908) and market (\$7,760,665) at January 1, 1996 of \$286,757 has been recorded in the combined statement of activity as the cumulative effect of a change in accounting principle.

Investment income for 1996 and 1995 is comprised of the following:

	<u>1996</u>	<u>1995</u>
Interest	\$563,690	\$642,621
Realized gains on redemptions	6,289	4,745
Change in unrealized gains	(187,347)	-
Investment expenses	(2,713)	(2,937)
	<u>379,919</u>	<u>644,429</u>

Functional Expenses: The combined statements of Functional Expenses (Exhibit C) provide detail as to program costs by major activity and supporting services for 1996 and 1995.

In addition to the program costs reflected on that Exhibit, amounts shown on the combined statement of activities (Exhibit B) as cost of literature distributed also relate to the publishing and magazine programs.

The allocation of supporting services to program activities on Exhibit C is done on a pro rata basis to program expenses by entity, and is provided for informational purposes only.

Operating Expenses: For purposes of the Statements of Functional Expenses, operating expenses are defined as recurring items requiring the current outlay of cash.

Management Estimates: The management of the Corporations uses estimates and assumptions in preparing financial statements in accordance with generally accepted accounting principles. These estimates and assumptions affect the reported amounts of assets, liabilities, revenues and expenses. Actual results could vary from the estimates that management uses.

As described in Note 5 of this report, management made certain significant estimates in the calculation of liabilities for postretirement health benefits. These estimates include employee retention, health care cost trends and the actuarial lives of present and projected retirees eligible for benefits. It is reasonably possible that a change in these estimates will occur in the near term. The effect of changes in these estimates can not be determined.

Note 3 Retirement Plan: The Organizations adopted a defined benefit pension plan effective January 1, 1965 to provide retirement benefits to eligible employees.

The plan provides an annual benefit equal to 2% of final average compensation multiplied by years of service (not to exceed 35 years), less 0.65% of average social security earnings multiplied by years of service (not to exceed 30 years). The social security offset can not reduce the gross benefit by more than 50%.

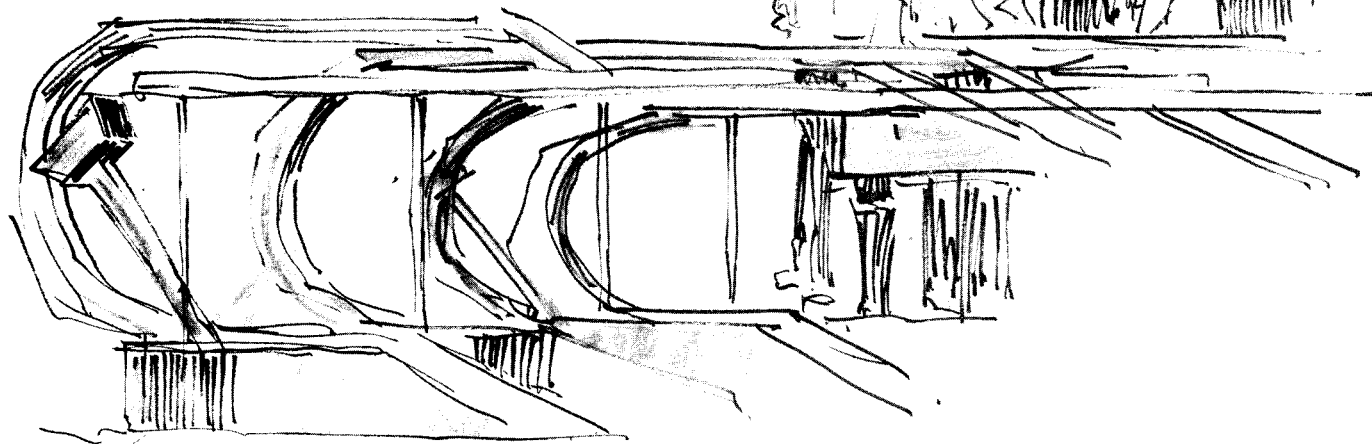
The plan's actuaries have calculated the following benefits as of December 31, 1996:

Present value of accrued benefits	\$5,409,000
Present value of vested benefits	5,084,000

The assumed rate of investment return used in determining the actuarial value of plan benefits was 7.5%. The annual rate of compensation increase has been assumed to be 5.5%.

The market value of the assets in the trust fund at December 31, 1996, was \$10,620,676, and was comprised of the following:

Cash and equivalents	\$ 189,380
Accrued income	106,356
Government bonds	2,593,831
Other bonds	2,252,525
Preferred stocks	120,625
Common stocks	<u>5,357,959</u>
	<u>10,620,676</u>



Pension expense has been consistently reported as the contributions made to actuarially fund plan benefits. That method of accounting was in accordance with generally accepted accounting principles that had been in effect since the issuance of Accounting Principles Board Statement No. 8 in 1966.

Effective as of 1987, however, Financial Accounting Standards Board ("FASB") Statement No. 87 introduced a new concept of "net periodic pension cost", in which pension cost would be accrued ratably over an employee's years of service based upon actuarial factors which would not necessarily be the same as those presently used in calculating the annual funding requirement. In addition, FASB No. 87 would require, on a deferred recognition basis, an employer to report an asset or liability on the Organization's balance sheet depending upon whether the plan was considered to be over or under funded. It is clear from the actuarial data that there is no unfunded liability in the A.A. Retirement Plan. Management still believes the annual funding payments are the more relevant measure of pension expense, and that the cost of additional actuarial calculations is not warranted. The actuaries have stated that the difference would not be a material amount. Pension expense for 1996 and 1995 was \$342,558 and \$332,921, respectively.

Effective March 31, 1996, the General Service Board approved an early retirement "window" for A.A.W.S. and General Service Board employees Employees age 55 or older with combined age and service of 64 or more are eligible. Participating employees receive a higher pension benefit by adding five years of age up to age 65, and a temporary Social Security supplement up to age 62. Severance pay is also provided based on years of service, and is borne by the General Service Board.

The program is voluntary. The original ending date of the window of September 30, 1996 has been extended to September 30, 1997.

Severance benefits of \$151,368 were incurred in 1996. Management estimates of \$100,000 of costs for 1997 have not been accrued since they are dependent on the voluntary participation of eligible employees, so their payment is uncertain.

Note 4 Lease Commitments: At December 31, 1996, A.A. World Services, Inc. as fiscal agent for the General Service Office, was subject to the following non-cancelable leases (exclusive of future operating increases) in New York City:

\$347,275 yearly office rental lease at 475 Riverside Drive effective July 1, 1991 through September 30, 2001.

\$129,116 yearly office rental lease at 475 Riverside Drive effective June 1, 1995 through September 30, 2001.

The minimum lease commitment at December 31, 1996 is \$2,263,000.

The rent expense for the years ended December 31, 1996 and 1995, was as follows:

	1996	1995
Total Rent Expense	<u>\$585,100</u>	<u>\$567,200</u>
Allocated to:		
A.A. World Services	\$148,100	\$144,000
General Service Board	349,200	338,100
A.A. Grapevine	87,800	85,100
	<u>585,100</u>	<u>567,200</u>

Note 5 Postretirement Health Benefits: The Corporations provide health care benefits for retired employees, substantially all of whom become eligible if they attain retirement age while working at the General Service Office. Benefits are provided through health insurance contracts maintained by the Corporations, 25 % of the cost of which is borne by the retirees.

Prior to 1995, the net costs for retiree health insurance were expensed as paid. Effective January 1, 1995, however, the Corporations adopted FASB Statement No. 106. The Statement requires employers to accrue a liability for the present value of the projected future costs of health care benefits over an employee's years of service.

The plan is unfunded. The assumed health care cost trend rate used to measure the expected cost of benefits covered by the plan is 5%. A discount rate of 7.5% has been used to measure the accrued postretirement health benefit obligation shown on Exhibit B. The following table sets forth the reconciliation of the plan's liability for 1996:

Liability - beginning of year		\$1,951,331
Service cost	\$ (86,041)	
Interest cost		
(at 7.5 % discount rate)	<u>146,350</u>	
	60,909	
Benefit payments	<u>(88,328)</u>	
Net change		<u>(27,419)</u>
Liability - end of year:		
Retirees	1,132,043	
Active employees	<u>791,869</u>	<u>1,923,912</u>

The reduction in service costs for 1996 reflects Management's plans to replace the current health plan for retirees during 1997 with a new plan providing comparable benefits at lower cost.

An increase of 1% in the assumed health care cost trend rate from 5% to 6% would increase the liability at the beginning of the year by \$271,321 and decrease the aggregate service and interest costs for 1996 by \$17,386, so that the liability at December 31, 1996 would be \$253,935 higher, or \$2,177,847.

The postretirement health benefit obligation at January 1, 1995 has been recorded by the Reserve Fund, as have the changes to that liability since that date. The assumption of this liability by the Reserve Fund was necessary because the operating entities are only permitted to retain enough net assets to satisfy current working capital requirements, and the postretirement health benefit obligation reflects long term costs that do not require any current working capital. As in prior years, the operating entities have continued to record and expense the current net costs of retiree health insurance as paid.

Note 6 Tax Status: The Organizations are exempt from Federal income taxes under section 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code. They are also exempt from New York State franchise and sales taxes.



Budget Highlights

1997 G.S.O. Budget

This budget describes the "OPERATIONS" of the General Service Office. It includes expenses of A.A. World Services (the Publishing operation) and the General Fund (Service activities). It excludes any activities reported separately in the Reserve Fund or the Capital Projects Fund. The Grapevine operations are described below in a separate report.

Income: The 1997 sales budget of \$9,332,000 is approximately 3% greater than the 1996 actual results. The budget calls for an increase in prices of some literature (principally hard cover) effective May 1997. The details of which are described more fully in the treasurer's report to the Conference. Net sales after discounts allowed are projected at \$9,015,800, approximately \$750,000 greater than 1996. The 1997 Budget assumes approximately a 5% decline in unit literature sales. This budget brings full circle the plan implemented in the Fall of 1994 which then called for increasing discounts and reducing certain prices for the primary purpose of reducing the Reserve Fund below its ceiling. It is no longer prudent or feasible to continue to operate at million dollar loss levels.

Manufacturing costs are budgeted approximately \$300,000 less than 1996. This takes into account both a lower unit volume of items sold and the favorable effect of purchasing trends in Publishing activities.

An increase of approximately 5% is again expected in the shipping and warehousing costs anticipating increase in postage and freight.

Gross profit from literature, is budgeted at \$4,200,000, approximately \$1,000,000 greater than 1996, as result of price increases and manufacturing costs decreases.

Contributions for 1997 have been estimated at \$4,030,000, approximately a 3% increase over 1996. It is our hope that the increase in contributions that occurred during 1996 will continue during 1997.

Total Operating Revenue for the period is anticipated at \$8,233,400, approximately 16% higher than 1996.

Total Operating Expenses for 1997 have been budgeted at \$8,372,400, approximately \$9,000 less than the 1996 actual expense.

An operating loss of \$139,000 is budgeted. This will be covered by a drawdown from the Reserve Fund. This compares with a \$1,264,000 loss for 1996 and a \$1,147,000 loss for 1995. As mentioned previously, these two years of significant losses have accomplished its goal of reducing the Reserve Fund balance to approximately 9 months.

1997 Grapevine Budget

The 1997 Grapevine Budget calls for an average circulation for 1997 of 126,350 copies compared with the 1996 average of 128,360 copies. During 1997 the Grapevine will realize a full year of higher renewals following the increase that went into effect with the May 1996 issue.

Income: Magazine income of \$1,714,000 is approximately 6% higher than the \$1,614,000 in 1996 due to the increase price. Other Publishing Income from books, cassette tapes, and miscellaneous items is budgeted at \$490,000, approximately 2% less than 1996. The Grapevine still continues to suffer from an aging product line with no new items anticipated until 1998.

Direct Costs: Magazine direct costs are budgeted at 45.6% of income as compared with 47% in 1996.

Total Gross Profit: Combining the magazine and other publishing items the gross profit of \$1,220,000 is 55.3% of budgeted income as compared to \$1,118,400, or 52.3% in 1996. This compares with 55.7% achieved in 1995.

Total Operating Expenses: Total Operating Expenses for 1997 are budgeted at \$1,365,000, approximately \$23,000 less than 1996 actuals of \$1,388,200.

Net Income: For 1997 net loss is budgeted at \$60,300 after interest earned as compared with a net loss of \$188,200 after interest in 1996.

1997 Spanish Grapevine Budget

Following the 1995 General Service Conference Advisory Action #7, the publication of the Grapevine magazine in Spanish was approved by the Grapevine Board of Directors and the trustees' Finance Committee of the General Service Board. Recognizing this publication as a new venture, both boards will review the financial impact on the Fellowship and the progress of circulation and continue to monitor the viability of this venture.

The 1997 LaViña Budget calls for an average circulation of 9,000 copies compared with the 8,068 achieved in 1996. Gross profit on the magazine for 1997 is anticipated at \$34,000 compared with a \$11,000 loss for 1996. Total costs and expenses of the project are estimated at \$131,800 for 1997 compared with \$127,300 in 1996. The net loss for 1997 is estimated at \$97,800 compared with a \$138,300 loss for 1996.

Recognizing that the entire project involved a bit more intricacies and work than originally anticipated, the Grapevine will present a revised business plan for LaViña, based on the experience gained during the first year of operation, to the July 1997 trustees' Finance Committee meeting.

The General Service Office 1997 OPERATING BUDGET

INCOME	1996 Actual	1997 Budget
GROSS SALES	\$ 9,035,212	\$ 9,332,400
Discounts allowed	774,693	316,600
<u>Net Sales</u>	8,260,519	9,015,800
Cost of Literature Distributed		
Manufacturing	3,398,977	3,081,834
Royalties	762,446	788,000
<u>Gross Margin</u>	4,099,096	5,145,966
DIRECT SHIPPING AND WAREHOUSING	898,148	946,335
<u>Gross Profit from Literature</u>	3,200,948	4,199,631
Contributions Received	3,912,718	4,030,000
Interest Income	3,912	3,800
<u>Total Revenue</u>	7,117,578	8,233,431
 OPERATING EXPENSES		
Salaries	3,772,457	3,815,000
Payroll taxes	299,803	302,000
Insurance	702,516	751,600
Retirement expense	313,739	263,025
Other program printing	339,380	357,400
Mailing, labor, etc.	116,448	114,515
Postage & express	362,553	363,500
Writers' fees	126,897	82,500
Other literature assistance	136,805	110,500
Selling expenses	62,424	85,000
Professional fees	122,218	114,500
Contracted services	117,043	126,700
Occupancy	515,015	533,600
Telephone	115,032	116,300
Furniture & equipment maintenance	51,596	63,650
Furniture & equipment	80,528	63,500
Stationery & office supplies	159,035	153,650
Office service & expense	200,193	198,175
Travel, meals, & accommodations	628,319	647,250
Bad debts	8,752	10,000
Early retirement severance	151,000	100,000
<u>TOTAL OPERATING EXPENSES</u>	8,381,753	8,372,365
Income (loss) for period	(1,264,175)	(138,934)
Drawdown from Reserve Fund	1,264,175	138,934
Net income (loss) for period	<u>— 0 —</u>	<u>— 0 —</u>

The Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.

1997 BUDGET

	1996 Actual	1997 Budget	Spanish Grapevine	
			1996 Actual	1997 Budget
PAID CIRCULATION—AVERAGE # OF COPIES	<u>128,360</u>	<u>126,350</u>	<u>8,068</u>	<u>9,000</u>
INCOME FROM MAGAZINE				
Subscription income	\$ 1,604,976	\$ 1,708,057	\$ 27,389	62,640
Single copies and back issues	<u>8,973</u>	<u>6,000</u>	<u>38</u>	<u>500</u>
Total magazine income	1,613,949	1,714,057	27,427	63,140
Total direct costs	<u>(759,985)</u>	<u>(782,570)</u>	<u>(38,425)</u>	<u>(29,160)</u>
GROSS PROFIT ON MAGAZINE	<u>853,964</u>	<u>931,487</u>	<u>(10,998)</u>	<u>33,980</u>
OTHER PUBLISHING INCOME	498,395	490,000		
Total direct costs	<u>(233,947)</u>	<u>(201,627)</u>		
GROSS PROFIT ON SPECIAL ITEMS	<u>264,448</u>	<u>288,373</u>		
TOTAL GROSS PROFIT	<u>1,118,412</u>	<u>1,219,860</u>		
COSTS AND EXPENSES				
EDITORIAL COSTS				
Salaries, including temporary help	181,528	170,500	25,491	46,800
Payroll taxes and benefits	47,266	44,798	4,584	7,998
Occupancy costs	53,314	54,950		
Office supplies and expenses	26,068	26,150	3,116	3,634
Product development	—	—		
Total Editorial	<u>308,176</u>	<u>296,398</u>	<u>33,192</u>	<u>58,432</u>
CIRCULATION AND BUSINESS				
Salaries, including temporary help	509,284	514,508	29,573	31,348
Payroll taxes and benefits	156,886	187,565	12,131	12,859
Occupancy costs	53,314	54,950	—	—
Office expense	41,063	31,800	—	—
Subscriber services	4,927	10,000	—	—
Selling expense — regular	149,512	121,500	40,343	15,000
— GvR program	24,757	30,800	—	—
Postage	14,482	17,750	—	7,950
Total Circulation and Business	<u>954,225</u>	<u>968,873</u>	<u>82,047</u>	<u>67,157</u>
GENERAL AND ADMINISTRATIVE				
Consultant fees	3,996	4,000	—	—
Insurance	5,633	5,750	—	—
Professional fees	18,848	21,500	763	1,500
Meetings and conferences	47,627	43,500	—	—
Furniture and equipment	18,471	2,500	10,909	4,000
Canadian exchange and other	31,197	22,300	382	700
Total General and Administrative	<u>125,772</u>	<u>99,550</u>	<u>12,054</u>	<u>6,200</u>
TOTAL COSTS AND EXPENSES	<u>1,388,173</u>	<u>1,364,821</u>	<u>127,292</u>	<u>131,789</u>
Add: Interest earned	<u>81,535</u>	<u>84,700</u>	<u>—</u>	<u>—</u>
NET INCOME (LOSS) FOR PERIOD	<u>(188,226)</u>	<u>(60,262)</u>	<u>(138,291)</u>	<u>(\$ 97,809)</u>

() denotes red figures

1996 Contributions From Groups — by Delegate Area

(in U.S. dollars)

AREA #	GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE AREA	#GPS. RE-PORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBER-SHIP	CONTRIB. PER CAPITA	AREA #	GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE AREA	#GPS. RE-PORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBER-SHIP	CONTRIB. PER CAPITA
1	Ala./N.W. Fla.	397	205	51.6%	29,522.03	7,685	\$3.84		Pennsylvania						
2	Alaska	222	86	38.7	11,026.98	3,689	2.98	59	East	1,423	740	52.0	111,977.05	34,066	3.28
3	Arizona	776	371	47.8	65,368.24	16,226	4.02	60	West	760	357	46.9	36,608.53	11,263	3.25
4	Arkansas	241	117	48.5	12,229.70	4,130	2.96	61	Rhode Island	246	111	45.1	15,816.17	5,781	2.73
	California							62	South Carolina	294	191	64.9	30,739.47	6,394	4.80
5	Southern	1,961	729	37.1	110,140.89	64,222	1.71	63	South Dakota	162	51	31.4	4,027.62	3,567	1.12
6	N. Coastal	1,915	1,057	55.1	184,912.46	62,448	2.96	64	Tennessee	466	233	50.0	35,153.71	10,312	3.40
7	N. Interior	704	350	49.7	43,767.98	19,113	2.28		Texas						
8	San Diego/Imp.	824	370	44.9	51,488.60	25,057	2.05	65	Northeast	429	181	42.1	42,415.04	17,335	2.44
9	Mid-South	1,758	690	39.2	86,879.59	56,256	1.54	66	Northwest	234	89	38.0	12,469.25	6,938	1.79
10	Colorado	618	360	58.2	51,561.84	15,363	3.35	67	Southeast	499	236	47.2	38,949.33	15,439	2.52
11	Connecticut	1,366	533	39.0	58,802.87	33,316	1.76	68	Southwest	446	192	43.0	30,547.37	10,320	2.96
12	Delaware	193	107	55.4	19,528.39	3,095	6.30	69	Utah	269	161	59.8	25,507.54	4,989	5.11
13	D.C.	455	232	50.9	39,067.04	14,955	2.61	70	Vermont	229	87	37.9	9,620.65	4,580	2.10
	Florida							71	Virginia	1,152	625	54.2	81,576.29	22,464	3.63
14	North	621	342	55.0	53,285.59	14,202	3.75	72	Washington West	1,031	503	48.7	79,661.57	23,640	3.36
15	South/Bahamas/ V.I.	1,537	765	49.7	121,143.96	31,692	3.82	73	West Virginia	302	127	42.0	8,840.19	3,521	2.51
16	Georgia	690	459	66.5	72,909.19	17,125	4.25	74	N. Wis./Upper Pen. Mich.	592	277	46.7	23,400.47	9,608	2.43
17	Hawaii	276	174	63.0	26,970.01	5,346	5.04	75	South	937	440	46.9	42,682.19	18,355	2.33
18	Idaho	198	103	52.0	10,208.51	3,126	3.26	76	Wyoming	113	49	43.3	5,039.21	2,026	2.48
	Illinois							77	Puerto Rico	140	79	56.4	5,872.70	1,755	3.34
19	Chicago	1,158	327	28.2	50,586.89	27,571	1.83	78	Alberta/N.W.T.	574	230	40.0	29,749.99	7,990	3.72
20	North	1,046	405	38.7	50,894.43	21,547	2.36	79	B.C./Yukon	766	349	45.5	48,407.60	14,048	3.44
21	South	459	201	43.7	22,404.65	7,798	2.87	80	Manitoba	153	58	37.9	5,862.84	4,221	1.38
	Indiana							81	N.B./P.E.I.	216	101	46.7	7,603.06	3,531	2.15
22	North	664	283	42.6	35,253.21	10,458	3.37	82	N.S./Nfld./Lab. Ontario	271	112	41.3	8,187.81	3,653	2.24
23	South	534	258	48.3	29,991.67	10,551	2.84	83	East	626	264	42.1	34,627.43	15,199	2.27
24	Iowa	638	289	45.2	30,232.39	12,683	2.38	84	Northeast	177	58	32.7	8,128.39	2,290	3.54
25	Kansas	364	190	52.1	25,942.19	9,216	2.81	85	Northwest	92	17	18.4	2,854.00	1,536	1.85
26	Kentucky	627	316	50.3	55,816.95	10,420	5.35	86	West	509	211	41.4	29,609.14	10,215	2.89
27	Louisiana	508	199	39.1	25,736.19	10,403	2.47		Quebec ¹						
28	Maine	477	150	31.4	12,747.67	8,027	1.58	87	Southwest	601	289	48.1	17,406.89	15,656	1.11
29	Maryland	890	358	40.2	50,780.45	14,337	3.54	88	Southeast	226	136	60.1	9,591.52	3,356	2.85
	Massachusetts							89	Northeast	364	290	79.7	4,548.89	6,897	0.65
30	East	1,486	576	38.7	80,133.70	51,118	1.56	90	Northwest	397	336	84.5	20,507.25	7,860	2.61
31	West	251	134	53.3	16,599.53	5,326	3.11	91	Saskatchewan	325	122	37.5	10,613.47	4,163	2.54
	Michigan							92	Washington East	416	151	36.2	16,058.88	5,824	2.75
32	Central	567	220	38.8	32,475.32	12,785	2.54		Total U.S./ Canada	55,956	25,138	44.9	\$3,392,480.34	1,257,570	2.70
33	Southeast	671	292	43.5	55,547.01	17,345	3.20		Individual, in memoriam, & special meetings				189,147.91		
34	West	447	201	44.9	28,144.80	9,047	3.11		Specials				290,871.91		
	Minnesota								Total for U.S. & Canada				\$3,872,500.16		
35	North	534	232	43.4	19,060.26	8,207	2.32		FOREIGN AND OTHER						
36	South	1,012	408	40.3	48,482.40	22,031	2.20		Birds of a Feather				1,380.00		
37	Mississippi	227	128	56.3	13,756.44	4,108	3.34		Correctional facility groups				315.00		
	Missouri								Foreign				35,165.49		
38	East	559	268	47.9	37,037.28	8,535	4.33		Internationalists				15.00		
39	West	215	107	49.7	12,763.00	6,275	2.03		Loners				1,782.35		
40	Montana	297	120	40.4	18,699.35	4,630	4.03		Internationalists groups				30.00		
41	Nebraska	696	326	46.8	49,355.88	14,817	3.33		International Dr.'s in A.A.				1,500.00		
42	Nevada	380	165	43.4	18,741.47	8,223	2.27		World Hello				30.00		
43	New Hampshire	530	205	38.6	21,794.30	8,623	2.52		Grand Total				\$3,912,718.00		
	New Jersey														
44	North	1,283	445	34.7	54,616.45	32,164	1.69								
45	South	478	241	50.4	40,790.44	8,670	4.70								
46	New Mexico	350	147	42.0	18,486.24	5,985	3.08								
	New York														
47	Central	716	264	36.9	36,100.92	11,463	3.14								
48	H./M./B.	768	284	36.9	27,366.15	11,819	2.31								
49	Southeast	1,782	762	42.7	159,780.49	55,865	2.86								
50	West	320	104	32.5	13,121.90	5,836	2.24								
51	North Carolina	863	484	56.0	79,529.43	13,661	5.82								
52	North Dakota	173	69	39.9	5,752.89	3,432	1.67								
	Ohio														
53	Cent. & S.E.	607	214	35.2	21,588.56	8,643	2.49								
54	Northeast	1,245	294	23.6	31,528.30	24,090	1.30								
55	N.W. Ohio/ S.E. Mich.	289	127	43.9	13,951.43	3,918	3.56								
56	S.W. Ohio	530	225	42.4	25,586.39	10,870	2.35								
57	Oklahoma	389	243	62.4	33,210.74	6,776	4.90								
58	Oregon	737	374	50.7	44,617.20	14,459	3.08								

CONTRIBUTION COMPARISON — 1996-1995 (in U.S. dollars)

	#GPS. RE-PORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBER-SHIP	CONTRIB. PER CAPITA
U.S. & Canada						
1996	55,956	25,138	44.9%	\$3,392,480.34 ²	1,257,570	\$2.70
U.S. & Canada						
1995	55,930	24,865	44.5%	\$3,220,355.38 ²	1,251,192	\$2.57
Increase (Decrease)	26	273	0.4%	\$172,124.96	6,378	\$0.13

¹ Reflects not only those groups that contributed directly to G.S.O., but also those groups that contributed to G.S.O. through their Conference areas (per lists of percentages submitted by areas).

² Group contributions reported on this schedule do not include contributions received as special, individual, in-memoriam, and special meetings.

1997 Conference Committees

Conference Agenda

Art Carmona
Mike Friederichs
Thomas Gore
²Charlotte Ingalls
Eddie McGee
Jeannine Presley
Joe Varonin
¹Wendy Zaparaniuk

Secretary: Richard Bush

Finance

Jack Boyle
Tanya Every
Gen Greiwe
¹James Jarchow
John King
²Bill Perrizo
Sonny Sampson
John Skilton

Secretary: Donald Meurer

Policy/Admissions

Ric Downey
Danie Fontenot
Larry Hoult
Keith Lake
²Thomas McMullen
Bert Mitchell
¹J.P. Paynter
Nina VanPatten

Secretary: Susan Ulseth

Treatment Facilities

²Ben Biegler
Dave Bowman
Larry Cassady
Phil Ernst
Karin Nord
Michael Smith
Ted Sturtevant
¹Roberta Sullivan

Secretary: Adrienne Brown

Cooperation With the Professional Community

Wilf Antheunis
Ernest Bourgeois
²Linda Firsdon
David Hansen
Frank Petska
George Reynolds
Lisa Tyler
¹Bob Watt

Secretary: Eva Sanchez

Grapevine

John Admire
Robert Caron
²Bob Cordero
Jim Dick
Michaelene Fortner
Bob McKimm
¹Gary Miller
Betty Piatt
John Walsh

Secretary: Cynthia Keyworth

Public Information

Art Denning
Mary Heiser
¹Martha Hooper
Ralph Jones
Roberta Lindeman
Don McGee
Bill Reinhart
Jerry Scott
²Jack Shaver

Secretary: Valerie O'Neill

Trustees

¹Jack Blume
Tom Canard
Raymond Dionne
Bill Farnsworth
Phyllis Halliday
Mark Richwine
Clay Rittenhouse
²Rikki Schock
Mike Wise

Secretary: Lois Fisher

Correctional Facilities

Isadora Drayton
Tim Hoft
Will Kilkeary
Bob Kosloff
¹Gilberto Lucero
Anne Malone
James Waldron
²Joycie Wren

Secretary: Doug Richardson

Literature

Rod Betonney
¹Joe Burnes
John Egan
José González
²Carolyn Hammond
Christine Hofer
John Kane
Robert Pelot
Jane Sheppard

Secretary: Pat Rosenstiel

Report and Charter

²Bill Archer
Dick Gallagher
Lisa Hens
Bob Merritt
Nick Murray
¹Arnold Ross
Steve Thompson
Laura Zeitlin

Secretary: Joanie Moncrief

³International Conventions/ A.A. Regional Forums

Michaelene Fortner
Lisa Hens
Gilberto Lucero
Sonny Sampson
Jack Shaver
Nina VanPatten
Joe Varonin
Jim Waldron

Co-secretaries: Valerie O'Neill
Lois Fisher

1998 CONFERENCE CHAIRPERSONS AND ALTERNATE CHAIRPERSONS⁴

Committee	Chairperson	Alternate
Agenda	Joe Varonin, So. California	Eddie McGee, No. New Jersey
•Cooperation With the Professional Community	David Hansen, Colorado	Lisa Tyler, Connecticut
Correctional Facilities	Tim Hoft, E. Missouri	Will Kilkeary, So. Wisconsin
Finance	John Skilton, D.C.	Tanya Every, Hawaii
Grapevine	John Admire, W. Missouri	Michaelene Fortner, Virginia
Literature	Jane Sheppard, SE Texas	Rod Betonney, Utah
Policy/Admissions	Ric Downey, B.C./Yukon	Keith Lake, NW Ontario
Public Information	Roberta Lindeman, Nevada	William Reinhart, Arkansas
Report and Charter	Steve Thompson, Oklahoma	Richard Gallagher, No. Florida
Treatment Facilities	Larry Cassady, West Virginia	Dave Bowman, W. Pennsylvania
Committee on Trustees	Phyllis Halliday, W. Washington	Mike Wise, Alabama/NW Florida
³ International Conv./Regional Forums	Lisa Hens, Central New York	Sonny Sampson, Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador

¹Chairperson

²Alternate Chairperson

³Members of this committee serve on this as a secondary committee assignment and not a primary committee assignment.

⁴The 1997 Committee chairs rotated at the end of the 47th General Service Conference.

1997 Trustees' Committees

Archives

William Bungay, *chairperson*
 Gary Glynn
 Tom Maguire
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Gerry Ouellette
 MaryJane Roy
 Frank Mauser, *secretary*

Conference

Michael McPherson, *chairperson*
 Chuck Crist
 Gay Garner
 Arthur Knight
 Julian Rhinehart
 Richard Roughton
 MaryJane Roy
 Donald Weaver
 Richard Bush, *secretary*

Cooperation With the Professional Community

John N. Chappel, M.D.,
chairperson
 Carl Budd
 William Bungay
 Garry McAuley
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Peter Roach
 Ray Stiver
 *Patricia Walters
 Eva Sanchez, *secretary*

Correctional Facilities

Donald Weaver, *chairperson*
 Carl Budd
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 Chuck Crist
 *Mark Gornik
 *Bruce Henry
 Garry McAuley
 *Sharon Stone
 Doug Richardson, *secretary*

Finance & Budgetary

Gary Glynn, *chairperson*
 Chuck Crist
 Gay Garner
 Arthur Knight
 Tom Maguire
 Gerry Ouellette
 Julian Rhinehart
 Donald Weaver
 Dennis Manders,
senior advisor
 Kevin Sunkel,
independent auditor
 Donald Meurer, *secretary*

International

Larry Nelson, *chairperson*
 William Bungay
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 Michel Girard
 Elaine Johnson, Ph.D.
 Raul Marin
 Peter Roach
 Joanie Moncrief, *secretary*

International Conventions/ A.A. Regional Forums

Elaine Johnson, Ph.D.,
chairperson
 Gay Garner
 Michael McPherson
 Larry Nelson
 Peter Roach
 Richard Roughton
 Jane Murphy Schulberg
 Greg Tobin
 Donald Weaver
 Valerie O'Neill, *secretary*
 —*International Conventions*
 Lois Fisher, *secretary*
 —*Regional Forums*

Literature

Gay Garner, *chairperson*
 *Frank Berls
 William Bungay
 *Jim Clough
 Gary Glynn
 Arthur Knight
 Garry McAuley
 Julian Rhinehart
 Richard Roughton
 Ray Stiver
 Vincina McCarthy, *consultant*
 Eleanor Widdoes, *consultant*
 Pat Rosenstiel, *secretary*

Nominating

MaryJane Roy, *chairperson*
 Gary Glynn
 Elaine Johnson, Ph.D.
 Michael McPherson
 Raul Marin
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Larry Nelson
 Jane Murphy Schulberg
 Lois Fisher, *secretary*

Public Information

Jane Murphy Schulberg,
chairperson
 Carl Budd
 Michel Girard
 *E. Anthony Hurley
 *Lindajo Loftus
 Tom Maguire
 Raul Marin
 Robert Miller, D.D.
 Gerry Ouellette
 *James Puckett
 Greg Tobin
 Valerie O'Neill, *secretary*

Treatment Facilities

Peter Roach,
chairperson
 Carl Budd
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 *Paul Cleary
 Michel Girard
 *Russ Higgins
 *Martha Lewis
 Garry McAuley
 Ray Stiver
 Greg Tobin
 Adrienne Brown, *secretary*

General Sharing Session

Raul Marin, *chairperson*
 Susan Ulseth, *secretary*

All members of the General Service Board, A.A.W.S. and GV Boards, G.S.O. and GV staffs, and trustees' committees participate in this "town meeting."

Officers of the General Service Board

Chairperson
 Jim Estelle
 First vice-chairperson
 John N. Chappel, M.D.
 Second vice-chairperson
 Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D.
 Secretary
 Michael McPherson
 Treasurer
 Gary Glynn
 Assistant secretary
 Susan Ulseth
 Assistant treasurer
 Donald Meurer

The new slate of officers is given on page 41



*Denotes appointed committee members
 Jim Estelle and George Dorsey are ex officio members of all committees.

1997 Conference Members

NONALCOHOLIC (CLASS A) TRUSTEES

W.J. (Jim) Estelle, Jr. (3681 Mesa Verde Dr., El Dorado Hills, CA 95762) was elected chairman of the board at the meeting following the 1993 Conference. Jim was director of the Texas Department of Corrections for 12 years, and brought his background in correctional administration to the board when he served as a Class A trustee, 1977-1986. Now retired, he is involved in many professional societies on criminal justice and corrections and is on the board of a California service organization that serves the needs of the families of indigent jail and prison inmates.

John N. Chappel, M.D. (School of Medicine, University of Nevada, Reno, NV 89557) was elected to the board in 1989. A graduate of the University of Alberta Medical School, John has been professor of psychiatry, University of Nevada School of Medicine, since 1974. He serves as consultant to many professional organizations and is widely published in the field of alcoholism. John chairs the Cooperation With the Professional Community Committee and serves on the Correctional Facilities, Treatment Facilities and International Committees.

²**Linda L. Chezem, J.D.** (530 Denny Dr., Mooresville, IN 46158) was elected to the board in April 1997. A graduate of Indiana University School of Law, Linda is a judge, Court of Appeals of Indiana. She started the first certified court alcohol and drug program in Indiana, and has conducted seminars and written articles on such subjects as DWI, family and addiction.

Gary A. Glynn (1112 Park Ave., New York, NY 10128) was elected to the board in April 1993 after serving as a consultant to the trustees' Finance Committee, Employee's Retirement Committee and the A.A.W.S. Board. A graduate of the University of Vermont and the Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania, he has been an investment analyst and portfolio manager for 25 years, and is active in various professional organizations and committees. Gary is treasurer of the General Service Board and chairs the Finance & Budgetary Committee; he also is a member of the trustees' Literature, Nominating and Archives Committees.

Elaine M. Johnson, Ph.D. (6631 Hunters Wood Circle, Catonsville, MD 21228) was elected to the board in May 1992. A graduate of Morgan State University and the University of Maryland, Elaine has a distinguished background in the fields of alcoholism and substance abuse. She has lectured widely, been a consultant to national and international government and professional organizations and published many articles in professional journals. She is professor of social work at Morgan State University, Baltimore, Maryland, and is a past director of the Center for Substance Abuse Prevention, which is a component of the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration under U.S. Dept. of Health and Human Services. Elaine chairs the International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums Committee and also serves on the Treatment Facilities, International and Nominating Committees, and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Arthur L. Knight, Jr. (865 Church Rd., Lake Forest, IL 60045) was elected to the board in 1995. Art's professional background is in the field of business, where he has held positions as president, director, and chief executive officer of manufacturing, distribution and financial services companies. He is a graduate of Dartmouth College and holds an M.B.A. from the University of New York, Buffalo. While Art is no longer involved in day-to-day business operations, he serves on a variety of business, professional and civic boards. He serves on the Conference, Literature, and Finance & Budgetary Committees and is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

Robert Oran Miller, D.D. (Episcopal Diocese of Alabama, 521 N. 20th St., Birmingham, AL 35203) was elected to the board in 1995. Elected ninth Bishop of the Diocese of Alabama in 1988, Bob has served as deacon and rector in several parishes in Alabama and held positions on various councils of the Episcopal church. He received an honorary Doctorate of Divinity from the University of the South, where he serves on the board of trustees. Bob serves on the Archives, Cooperation With the Professional Community, Public Information and Nominating Committees.

Peter Roach (1332 Edmison Dr., Peterborough, ON K9H 6V3, Canada) was elected to the board in 1994. Peter has been an elementary and secondary school teacher. When he retired in 1992, he had completed 18 years as director of education for Peterborough Separate School Board. Since his retirement he is involved extensively in the community by serving on the Hospital Board, United Way, the Ontario Superrannuated Teachers' Board and on a standing committee of the Community College. He is also chair of the Pastoral Council for his parish. Peter chairs the Treatment Facilities Committee and also serves on International, International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums and Cooperation With the Professional Communities Committees.

ALCOHOLIC (CLASS B) TRUSTEES

Carl Budd (1405 Collins St., Rock Springs, WY 82901) was elected West Central regional trustee in April 1996. A Panel 30 delegate, Carl has remained active in his area, particularly in collecting material for the area archives. After many years in the oil and gas industry, he retired in 1995 from the Department of the Interior, after 14 years of service. Carl serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community, Public Information, Correctional Facilities and Treatment Facilities Committees.

William Bungay (24 Johnson's Ave., Corner Brook, Newfoundland, A2H 1V8, Canada) was elected Eastern Canada regional trustee in April 1994. Bill, a Panel 39 delegate, has a background in accounting and business. He chairs the Archives Committee and also serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community, International and Literature Committees.

Chuck Crist (820 N. Bradley Dr., Chandler, AZ 85226) was elected general service trustee in April 1996, after serving three years as a director on the Grapevine Board. Chuck, a Panel 40 delegate, works in the computer field. He chairs the Grapevine Corporate Board and is a member of the Conference, Correctional Facilities and Finance & Budgetary Committees.

¹**Gay Garner** (528 Hammet Dr., Decatur, GA 30032) was elected Southeast U.S. regional trustee in April 1993. A former Panel 38 delegate, Gay has also served her area as G.S.R., D.C.M. and area chairperson and has been active in local P.I./C.P.C. activities. Her professional background is in the entertainment business, management and advertising sales. Gay chairs the Literature Committee and also serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Conference and Finance & Budgetary Committees.

Michel Girard (67, Aubert Blvd., Repentigny, Quebec, J6A 4N9, Canada), a Panel 42 delegate, was elected trustee-at-large/Canada in May 1995. He has been active in service in his area and served on the boards of A.A. French Publications and *La Vigne*. Michel is now retired from a 30-year position with a telecommunications company. He serves on the Public Information, International and Treatment Facilities Committees, and is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

¹ Rotating at the close of the 1997 Conference meeting.

² New trustee, elected by the General Service Board, April 1997.

Garry McAuley (6115-51 Avenue, Stettler, Alberta, T0C 2L2, Canada) was elected Western Canada regional trustee in April 1996. A Panel 40 delegate, he is safety and environmental advisor at a processing plant of a petroleum/gas company. Garry serves on the Correctional Facilities, Literature, Cooperation With the Professional Community and Treatment Facilities Committees.

Michael McPherson (315 W. 86th St., New York, NY 10024) was elected general service trustee in April 1993. Prior to that Michael was an A.A.W.S. director, where he served as chair for the A.A.W.S. Publications Subcommittee and was a member of the trustees' Finance Committee. He is chief administrative officer for a large nonprofit corporation. Michael chairs the Conference Committee and also serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums and Nominating Committees, and is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

Tom Maguire (941 Pineview Circle, Live Oak, FL 32060) was elected general service trustee in April 1997. Tom has served four years as a nontrustee director on The Grapevine Board. He is general manager for a national radio network, and for several television stations.

Raul Marin (234 Addax Dr., San Antonio, TX 78213) was elected Southwest regional trustee in May 1995. Raul has long been active in the southwest Texas area as G.S.R., D.C.M., area chair and delegate (Panel 30). He has been involved in starting bilingual Spanish groups, conferences and intergroups. Raul is an architect, now semi-retired. He serves on the International, Public Information and Nominating Committees and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Larry Nelson (192 Elm Ave., Imperial Beach, CA 91932) was elected trustee-at-large/U.S. in April 1993. A former Panel 38 delegate, Larry has been active in many service activities in his area. He is a pharmacist on the staff of a large health maintenance organization clinic. Larry chairs the International Committee and serves on the Nominating and International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Jack L. Ostrem (913 Grand Blvd., Joliet, IL 60436) was elected East Central regional trustee in April 1997. A Panel 34 delegate, Jack has long been active in his area, especially in corrections service work. Now retired, his major occupation for many years was in warehouse management.

Julian Rhinehart (1127 Seno Court, Boulder City, NV 89005) was elected Pacific regional trustee in April 1994. Julian was a Panel 41 delegate, where he chaired the Conference P.I. Committee. He has long been active in area service. Retiring from the Federal

Government in 1994 after a 25-year career in public relations, he now does freelance writing and consulting work. Julian chairs the A.A.W.S. Board and also serves on the Conference, Finance & Budgetary, and Literature Committees.

Dean Rinehart (613 Matthews, El Reno, OK 73036) was elected trustee-at-large/U.S. in April 1997. As a Panel 37 delegate, he chaired the Grapevine Conference Committee, and has continued to be active in service work in the area and region. A practicing attorney, Dean is also engaged in cattle and farming activities.

MaryJane Roy (430 Moonstone Beach Rd., Wakefield, RI 02879) was elected Northeast U.S. regional trustee in May 1995. MaryJane began her service work in young people's groups, local central offices and at the group level. She was a Panel 42 delegate, and chaired the Conference C.P.C. Committee. MaryJane, a physician's assistant, is clinical director of a vascular lab. She chairs the Nominating Committee and also serves on the Archives and Conference Committees and is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

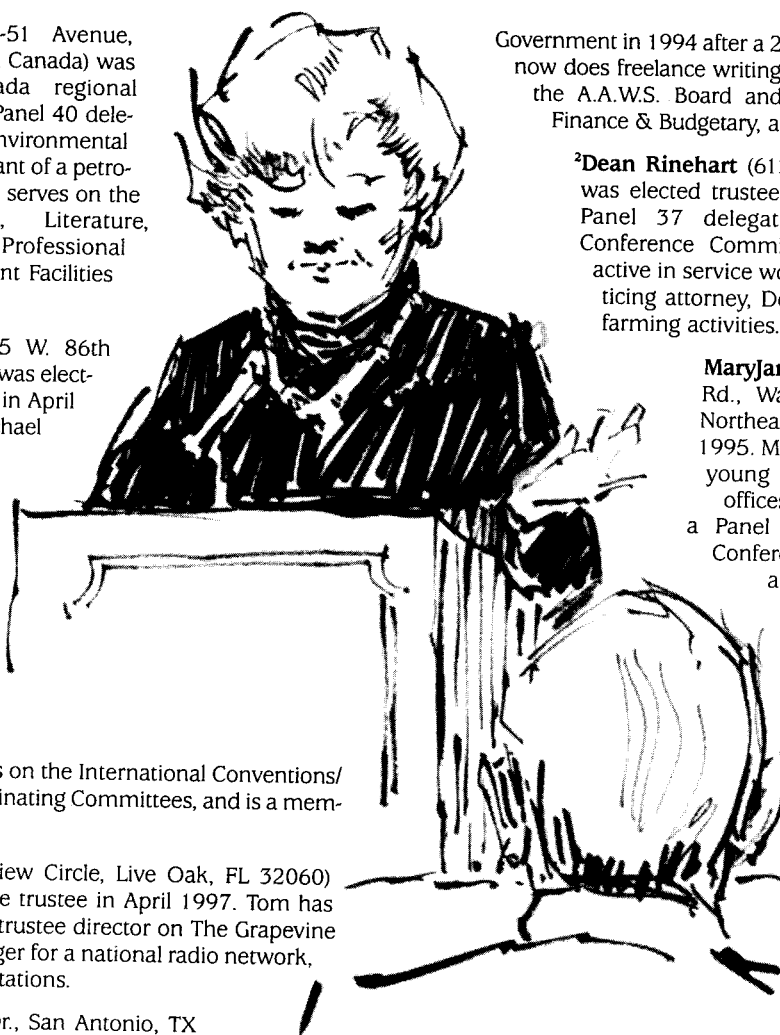
Richard Roughton (1250 N. Dearborn Pkwy., Apt. 14-B, Chicago, IL 60610) was elected general service trustee in April 1997. A Panel 34 delegate from Rhode Island, Richard has served as a nontrustee director on the A.A.W.S. Board

since 1993. He is an associate dean for continuing education at a college in the Chicago area.

Jane Murphy Schulberg (138 E. 38th St., New York, NY 10016) was elected a general service trustee in April 1993, after serving four years as a director on the Grapevine Corporate Board. Jane, who is a producer/writer with a television media house, has been active at many levels of local A.A. She chairs the Public Information Committee and also serves on the Nominating and International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees and is a member of the Grapevine Corporate Board.

Elizabeth (Betty) Stevens (1420 Nunamaker Dr., Columbia, SC 29210) was elected Southeast regional trustee in April 1997. A Panel 31 delegate, Betty has held various service positions in her area and currently is active in committee work for her local intergroup. Now retired, she has worked in EAP and as an alcoholism counselor.

Donald Weaver (10641 S. Westnedge, Portage, MI 49002) was elected East Central regional trustee in April 1993. Don has held many service jobs in his area, including Panel 34 delegate. A landscaper, he is also involved with various community activities. Don chairs the Correctional Facilities Committee and also serves on the Finance & Budgetary, Conference and International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees.



A.A. World Services Directors

Julian Rhinehart, *chairperson, regional trustee*
George Dorsey, *G.S.O. general manager*
Michel Girard, *trustee-at-large/Canada*
Arthur Knight, *class A trustee*
Michael McPherson, *general service trustee*

Gerard Ouellette, *nontrustee director*
Richard Roughton, *nontrustee director*
MaryJane Roy, *regional trustee*
Susan Ulseth, *G.S.O. staff member*

A.A. Grapevine Directors

Chuck Crist, *chairperson, general service trustee*
Elaine Johnson, Ph.D., *Class A trustee*
Thomas Maguire, *nontrustee director*
Raul Marin, *regional trustee*
Larry Nelson, *regional trustee*
Jane Murphy Schulberg, *general service trustee*

Ray Stiver, *nontrustee director*
Greg Tobin, *nontrustee director*
Ames Sweet, *Grapevine executive editor*
Cynthia Keyworth, *Grapevine senior editor*

General Service Office Staff

George Dorsey, *general manager*
Adrienne Brown
Richard Bush
Lois Fisher
Joanie Moncrief
Daniel Mooney

Valerie O'Neill
Doug Richardson
Pat Rosenstiel
Eva Sanchez
Susan Ulseth
Tom Jasper, *services director*
Frank Mauser, *archivist*

Grapevine Staff

Ames Sweet, *executive editor*

Cynthia Keyworth, *senior editor*

Others Assisting the Conference (nonvoting)

Salim Bacchus, *general office clerk*
Caryl Bertolino, *staff assistant*
Rosa Blanco, *financial secretary*
Daniel Brown, *typesetter*
Angel Calvillo, *translator*
Joseph Dennen, *staff assistant*
John de Stefano, *Spanish-language editor*
Yee Eng, *staff assistant*
Robert Gregson, *P.C. specialist*
Al Herr, *artist, Conference Report*
Mara Hennessey, *GV executive secretary*
John Kirwin Jr., *assistant controller/business administration*
Vanessa Luyando, *receptionist*
Dennis Manders, *senior advisor, finance committee*
Jaime Manrique, *GV Spanish-language editor*
Vinnie McCarthy, *publications director*
Lynda Maziarz, *staff assistant*
Don Meurer, *controller, A.A.W.S.*
Lilianna Murphy, *information services manager*
Paul Murphy, *GV editorial staff asst.*
Ramona Ortiz, *staff assistant*
Ivelisse Rivera, *staff assistant*
Miguel Rodriguez, *general office clerk*
Linda Samuels, *staff assistant*
Judith Santon, *assistant archivist*
Bob Scherer, *GV controller*
Frank Segui, *staff assistant*
Bob Slotterback, *GV assistant controller*
Elaine Soroka, *special projects manager*
Kevin Sunkel, *independent C.P.A.*
Stephen Turchyn, *data processing supervisor*
Andre Washington, *purchasing*
Cynthia White, *staff assistant*
Eleanor Widdoes, *writer/editor, Early Bird Box 4-5-9, Conference Report*

Trustees emeritus

Michael Alexander
Gordon Patrick

Area Delegates

What do panel numbers mean? Delegates to each Conference are made up of two "panels." One is even-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an even year. The other is odd-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an odd year. The 47th Conference includes Panel 46 (delegates now serving for their second year) and Panel 47 (new delegates).

UNITED STATES

State	Area no.	Panel	
Alabama/N.W. Florida	1	47	Charles (Mike) Wise 4621 Bridgedale Rd. Pensacola, FL 32505
Alaska	2	46	Charlotte Ingalls Box 876425 Wasilla, AK 99687
Arizona	3	46	Robert (Bob) Cordero 2912 N. Rio de Flag Dr. Flagstaff, AZ 86004
Arkansas	4	47	William (Bill) Reinhart 2003 McCracken Stuttgart, AR 72160
California Southern	5	47	Joseph (Joe) Varonin 16738 Tiara Court Canyon County, CA 91351
Northern Coastal	6	47	Robert (Bob) Kosloff 535 Main St., Suite 316 Martinez, CA 94553
Northern Interior	7	46	Joe Burnes Box 2649 Visalia, CA 93291-3115
San Diego/Imperial	8	46	J.P. Paynter 134 Countrywood Ln. Encinitas, CA 92024-3109
Mid-Southern	9	46	*Nick Murray 3505 S. Olive St. Santa Ana, CA 92707
Colorado	10	47	David Hensen 16458 Buckthorn Lane Parker, CO 80134
Connecticut	11	47	Elizabeth (Lisa) Tyler 117 Fair St. Wallingford, CT 06492
Delaware	12	46	Albert (Bert) Mitchell 3806 Brookfield Ave. Wilmington, DE 19803
District of Columbia	13	47	John Skilton 201 Kerby Hill Rd. Ft. Washington, MD 20744
Florida North	14	47	Richard (Dick) Gallagher 410 Spring Valley Ln. Altamonte Springs, FL 32714
S. Florida/ Bahamas/V.I.	15	47	John King 7518 NW 41st St. Coral Springs, FL 33065-2055
Georgia	16	46	Joycie Wren 5430 Southlake Dr. Douglasville, GA 30135
Hawaii	17	47	Tanya Every 150 Hauoli St., #203 Wailuku, HI 96793
Idaho	18	46	Martha (Marti) Hooper Box 488 New Plymouth, ID 83655

* Seated as Panel 46 delegate, replacing former delegate Lona Wright-Parker, who resigned.

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>		<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Illinois				Montana	40	46	Roberta (Robbie) Sullivan Box 1870 Whitefish, MT 59937
<i>Chicago</i>	19	47	Laura Zeitlin 2214 Churchill Ln. Highland Park, IL 60035-1647	Nebraska	41	46	Mark Richwine 7921 Stockwell St. Lincoln, NE 68506
<i>Northern</i>	20	46	Thomas (Tom) Gore 835 Cedar Ave. Elgin, IL 60120	Nevada	42	47	Roberta Lindeman Box 1672 Fallon, NV 89407-1672
<i>Southern</i>	21	47	Larry Hoult RR#3, Box 184 B Chrisman, IL 61924	New Hampshire	43	46	Anne Malone Box 134 Durham, NH 03824
Indiana				New Jersey			
<i>Northern</i>	22	47	Gerald (Jerry) Scott 7014 Chadwick Dr. Ft. Wayne, IN 46816	<i>Northern</i>	44	47	Edmund (Eddie) McGee 239 Montgomery St., Apt. 1C Highland Park, NJ 08904
<i>Southern</i>	23	46	Michael (Mike) Smith 4 Sleepy Hallow Dr. Westfield, IN 46074-9503	<i>Southern</i>	45	46	John J. Kane, Jr. 549 Grant Ave. Collingswood, NJ 08107
Iowa	24	47	Frank Petska 814 E. Fifth St. Spencer, IA 51301	New Mexico	46	46	Betty M. Piatt Box 1747 Las Vegas, NM 87701
Kansas	25	46	Carolyn Hammond 12403 W. 105th St. Overland Park, KS 66215	New York			
Kentucky	26	46	Gen Greiwe 233 Merravay Dr. Florence, KY 41042	<i>Central</i>	47	47	Lisa Hens 123 Myers Rd., Apt. 1 Lansing, NY 14882
Louisiana	27	47	Danie Fontenot Box 711 Washington, LA 70589	<i>Hudson/Mohawk/ Berkshire</i>	48	46	John Walsh 508 Creek Rd. Poughkeepsie, NY 12601-1012
Maine	28	46	Ted Sturtevant RR1, Box 1045 Woolwich, ME 04579	<i>Southeast</i>	49	47	Isadora Drayton 311 Sterling Pl. Brooklyn, NY 11238
Maryland	29	46	Arnold Ross 5904 Northwood Dr. Baltimore, MD 21212	<i>Western</i>	50	46	Jack (Bevo) Boyle 60 Cantwell Dr. Buffalo, NY 14220-2602
Massachusetts				North Carolina	51	47	Arthur (Art) Denning Box 310 Morehead City, NC 28557-0310
<i>Eastern</i>	30	47	John Egan 20 Kendall Ave. Braintree, MA 02180	North Dakota	52	46	Mike Friederichs 7595 180 Ave., SE Wahpeton, ND 58075
<i>Western</i>	31	46	Jack Blume 199 Silver St. Sheffield, MA 01257	Ohio			
Michigan				<i>Central Southeast</i>	53	47	Bill Farnsworth 716 Fifth St. Marietta, OH 45750
<i>Central</i>	32	47	Arturo (Art) Carmona 1549 Jane Ave. Flint, MI 48506	<i>Northeast</i>	54	47	Bob McKimm 3378 Washington Blvd. Cleveland Hts., OH 44118-2541
<i>Southeast</i>	33	47	Christine Hofer 24434 Ann Arbor Trail Dearborn Hts., MI 48127	<i>NW Ohio/SE Mich.</i>	55	46	Linda Firsdon 14221 New Rochester Rd. Pemberville, OH 43450
<i>Western</i>	34	46	James (Jim) Waldron 603 Stimson St. Cadillac, MI 49601	<i>Southwest</i>	56	46	Mary Heiser 12820 Luthman Rd. Minster, OH 45865
Minnesota				Oklahoma	57	47	Steven (Steve) Thompson 12307 W. Elm El Reno, OK 73036
<i>Northern</i>	35	46	Bill Perrizo 1341 S. Fifth Ave. Fargo, ND 58103	Oregon	58	46	James (Jim) Jarchow Box 851 Gold Beach, OR 97444
<i>Southern</i>	36	47	Karin Nord 413 Hopkins Crossroad Minnetonka, MN 55305	Pennsylvania			
Mississippi	37	46	Gary Miller Box 957 Long Beach, MS 39560	<i>Eastern</i>	59	47	Clay Rittenhouse 541 Colwell Ln. Conshocken, PA 19428
Missouri				<i>Western</i>	60	47	David (Dave) Bowman 1306 Superior Ave. Pittsburgh, PA 15212-2722
<i>Eastern</i>	38	47	Timothy (Tim) Hoft 2723 Ashrock Dr. St. Louis, MO 63129				
<i>Western</i>	39	47	John Admire 5813 Oxford Raytown, MO 64133				

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>		CANADA	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Rhode Island	61	46	Ernest (Ernie) Bourgeois Box 40024 Providence, RI 02940-0024	<u>Province</u> Alberta/N.W.T.	78	46	Robert (Bob) Watt 16 LaFonde Cr. St. Albert, AB T8N 2N6
South Carolina	62	46	Robert (Bob) Merritt Box 1652 Greenville, SC 29602-1652	B.C./Yukon	79	47	Richard (Ric) Downey PH4 9541 Erickson Dr. Burnaby, BC V3J 7N8
South Dakota	63	46	George Reynolds 614 S. Broadway Watertown, SD 57201	Manitoba	80	46	Jack Shaver 27 Makinak Bay Winnipeg, MB R2Y 1B8
Tennessee	64	46	Carl (Ralph) Jones 1496 Lawrence St. Kingsport, TN 37665	New Brunswick/P.E.I.	81	46	Rikki Schock R.R. #3, Belle River P.O. Belle River, PEI C0A 1B0
Texas <i>Northeast</i>	65	47	Geoffrey (Phil) Ernst 116 N. Suttonwood Dr. Fort Worth, TX 76108	Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	82	47	Charles (Sonny) Sampson General Delivery— Antigonish County Haure Bouchie, NS BOH 1P0
<i>Northwest</i>	66	46	Gilberto Lucero 2800 Frankfort Ave. El Paso, TX 79930	Ontario			
<i>Southeast</i>	67	47	Jane Sheppard Box 214 Beasley, TX 77417	<i>Eastern</i>	83	47	Wilfried (Wilf) Antheunis 33 Shaw St., Unit B Toronto, ON M6J 3T5
<i>Southwest</i>	68	46	Thomas (Tom) McMullen Box 790889 San Antonio, TX 78279-0889	<i>Northeast</i>	84	47	Jeannine Presley 63 Pearson Dr. Elliot Lake, ON P5A 2X2
Utah	69	47	Rod Betonney 10026 Opal Circle Sandy, UT 84094	<i>Northwest</i>	85	47	Keith Lake RR1, Airport Rd. Kenora, ON P9N 3W7
Vermont	70	46	Don (McGee) McGee Box 671 Bomoseen, VT 05732	<i>Western</i>	86	46	Jim Dick Box 21025 Cambridge, ON N3C 2G1
Virginia	71	47	Michaelene Fortner 8654 Poplar Springs Dr. Gloucester, VA 23601	Quebec			
Washington <i>East</i>	92	46	Benedict (Ben) Biegler 113 E. Bonnieview Grandview, WA 98930	<i>Southwest</i>	87	46	William (Bill) Archer 5731 Somerled, #5 Montreal, PQ H3X 1Z7
<i>Western</i>	72	47	Phyllis Halliday 3805 Cortez Loop SW Olympia, WA 98512-7065	<i>Southeast</i>	88	47	Raymond Dionne 21, Route De La Grieve Saint-Denis, PQ GOL 2R0
West Virginia	73	47	Larry Cassidy P.O. Box 307 Williamstown, WV 26187-0307	<i>Northeast</i>	89	47	Robert Caron 3443 Sarnia Ste-Foy, PQ G1X 2K5
Wisconsin <i>No. WI/ Up. Penn. MI</i>	74	46	Thomas (Tom) Canard W1785 Elk Lane Kaukauna, WI 54130	<i>Northwest</i>	90	46	Robert Pelot 1020 Louis-Ritchie Bellefeuille, PQ JOR 1A0
<i>Southern</i>	75	47	William (Will) Kilkeary E 13953 Maple Ridge Rd. Lafarge, WI 54639-8624	Saskatchewan	91	46	Wendy Zapaniuk #44 - 28th St. East Prince Albert, SK S6V 1W8
Wyoming	76	46	Nina VanPatten 6340 Buckboard #2 Casper, WY 82604				
Puerto Rico	77	46	José (Jr.) Gonzáles Box 102 Ciales, PR 00638-0102				